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MANOMOHAN GHOSH, M. A., Ph. D.

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THE NATYASA¹STRA

A TREATISE ON HINDU DRAMATURGY AND HISTRIONICS

THE NĀṬYAŚĀSTRA

A Treatise on Hindu Dramaturgy and Histrionics

Ascribed to

BHARATA - MUNI

Vol. I. (Chapters I-XXVII)

*Completely translated for the first time from the original Sanskrit
with an Introduction and Various Notes*

by

MANOMOHAN GHOSH M.A., PH. D. (Cal.)



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Dedicated
to
the memory of
those great scholars of India and the West
who by their indefatigable study and ingenious interpretation
of her Religion, Philosophy, Literature and Arts, have demon-
strated the high value of India's culture to the World at large and
have helped her towards a reawakening and political liberation,
and
who by their discovery of the Universal aspect of this culture
have made patent India's spiritual kinship with the other ancient
nations of the World and have paved the way for an ultimate
triumph of Internationalism.

971

P R E F A C E

The preparation of an annotated English translation of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* entrusted to me as early as 1944, by the Royal Asiatic Society, has been delayed for various reasons which need not be recounted here in detail. But mention must be made of one important factor of this delay, viz., the inherent difficulty of this very old text which is not yet available in a complete critical edition. From my first serious acquaintance with it in 1925 in connection with the editing of the *Abhinayadarpaṇa* (Calcutta, 1934) this work has always engaged my attention in the intervals of other duties. But it was only a few years ago, that I came to believe that the entire work could be translated into English. It was, however, only after making some actual progress in translation that I realised the difficulty of the task and understood to some extent at least why no complete translation of this very important text had so far not been made. .

However, I considered it a duty to make strenuous efforts and proceeded patiently with the work and finished at last translating the major portion of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. I am now genuinely happy to place it before the scholarly public, not because it could be done in an ideal fashion, but because it could be finished at all.

In handling a difficult old text like this it is natural that one has to offer conclusions and interpretations, here and there, which due to the absence of better materials cannot be placed on surer grounds. But whatever tentative assertions I have made, have been made after the most careful consideration with the expectation that they may prove helpful to others working in this field, and it may be hoped that their number has not been too many, and in a few cases where I myself had any doubt about the interpretation offered, the same has been expressly mentioned in the footnote.

The chapters on music covering a little more than one fourth of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* still remain to be done. These when completed will be published in the second volume. As the work on it, is progressing very slowly and it cannot be said definitely when it will be finished, it was thought advisable to publish the portion of the translation already prepared. Though the musical terms occurring in the present volume remain undefined, the absence of chapters on music where they have been discussed, will not, it is hoped, seriously interfere with the understanding of the dramaturgy and histrionics treated here.

For information regarding the plan and scope of the present work, the reader is referred to the Introduction, section I.

For the purpose of this volume, works of various scholars have been helpful to the translator and they have been mentioned

in proper places. But among them all, the American Sanskritist Dr. G. C. O. Haas deserves to be specially mentioned ; for his plan of the translation of the Daśarūpa, has been adopted in a slightly modified manner in the present work.

I am indebted to Dr. S. K. De, due to whose kindness I could utilise the unpublished portion of the Abinavabhārati. It is also a great pleasure to acknowledge the uniform courtesy of different officers of the Society from 1947-1950, especially Dr. K.N. Bagchi, and Dr. Niharanjan Ray, the General Secretaries and Mr. S. K. Saraswati, the Librarian and Mr. Rakhahari Chatterji, the Superintendent of the office, whose patience I had to tax on different occasions in course of the publication.

I am grateful to my father-in-law Sri Kali Charan Mitra who read the original draft of the first fourteen chapters of the present work and made suggestions regarding the language, and to my esteemed friend Dr. S. N. Ray, M.A., Ph.D. (London) formerly Head of the Department of English in the University of Dacca, for reading the proof of the first twelve formes and also for going through in Mss. the Introduction and for making welcome suggestions.

I wish to mention here very gratefully the debt I owe to Dr. Kalidas Nag in connexion with the preparation and the publication of this work. But for his suggestion to undertake this work it might not have reached at all the stage of publication.

Last but not the least it becomes my most cheerful duty to express my gratitude to Prof. Suniti Kumar Chatterji, who has also helped me otherwise in connexion with this work. This help and his constant encouragement have rendered this work less arduous than it might otherwise have been.

I should here also apologise to the readers for the many misprints that have crept into the volume. They are requested to make kindly, the necessary corrections pointed out in the corrigenda.

25th November, 1950

The Translator

ABBREVIATIONS AND SYMBOLS

a.	...	The first hemistich of a verse.
Abhi.	...	Bhāsa's Abhiṣekanāṭaka.
AD.	...	Nandikesvara's Abhinayadarpaṇa.
A. dy.	...	Arthadyotānikā, Rāghavabhaṭṭa's commentary on the Śakuntalā.
Ag., Abhinava	...	Abhinavagupta or his commentary of the Nāṭyaśāstra.
AMg.	...	Ardhamāgadhī.
Avi.	...	Bhāsa's Avimāraka.
AŚ.	...	Kauṭilya's Arthaśāstra (ed. Jolly).
AŚ. notes.	...	Kauṭilya's Arthaśāstra (ed. Jolly). Vol. II.
B.	•	...
b.	•	...
Bāla.	•	...
Bhāmaha.	...	Bhāmaha's Kāvyaḷamkāra.
BhNC.	...	Bhāsa-nāṭaka-cakra ed. by C. R. Devadhar
BhP.	...	Śāradātanaya's Bhāvaprakāśana.
C.	...	Chowkhamaba (Benares) edition of the Nāṭyaśāstra.
c.	...	The third hemistich in a stanza.
Cāru.	...	Bhāsa's Cārudatta.
CSS.	...	Chandaḥ-sāra-saṃgraha.
Daṇḍin.	...	Daṇḍin's Kāvyaḍarśa.
def.	...	Definition or definitions.
De's Ms.	...	The Ms. of the Abhinavagupta's commentary (Abhinavabhāratī) belonging to Dr. S. K. De.
DR.	...	Dhanañjaya's Daśarūpa.
Dūtagha.	...	Bhāsa's Dūtaghaṭotkaca.
Dūtavā.	...	Bhāsa's Dūtavākya.
Ex.	...	Example or examples.
Foundation.	...	Nobel's Foundation of Indian Poetry.
G.	...	J. Grosset's edition of the Nāṭyaśāstra.
GOS.	...	Gaikwar's Oriental Series.
Haas.	...	Haas's translation of the Daśarūpa.
I. Ant.	...	Indian Antiquary.
IHQ.	...	Indian Historical Quarterly.
ID., Ind. Dr.	...	Sten Konow's Indische Drama.
Itihāsa.	...	Hāldār's Vyākaraṇa-darśaner Itihāsa.
JDL.	...	Journal of the Dept. of Letters, Calcutta University.
JK.	...	Vidyālamkāra's Jīvanikośa.

K.
 KA.
 Karṇa.
 Kavi.

 KS.
 Kumāra.
 Kuṭṭa.
 Lévi,
 Madhyama.
 Mālati.
 Mālavī.
 MG.
 Mṛch.
 Mudrā.
 Nāṭakalakṣaṇa. }
 NL,
 ND.
 NIA.
 Nitti-Dolci.
 NŚ.
 P.
 Pañc.
 Pāṇ.
 Piṅgala.
 Pischel.
 Pr. P.
 Pr.
 Prak.
 Pratimā.
 Pratijñā.
 PŚ.
 PSM.
 R., Rām.
 Ratnā.
 RŚ.
 Śak.
 SD.
 SR.
 Śr. Pr.
 Svapna.
 tr., trans.
 Uttara.

... Kāvya-māla ed. of the Nāṭyaśāstra.
 ... Hemacandra's Kāvya-nuśāsana.
 ... Bhāsa's Karṇabhāra.
 ... Ramakrishna Kavi or his commentary to
 the ch. XVII. of the NŚ.
 ... Vātsyāyana's Kāmāsūtra.
 ... Kālidāsa's Kumārasambhava.
 ... Dāmodaragupta's Kuṭṭānimata.
 ... Sylavain Lévi's Le Théâtre indien.
 ... Bhāsa's Madhyamavyāyoga.
 ... Bhavabhūti's Mālatīmādhava.
 ... Kālidāsa's Mālvikāgnimitra. •
 ... Coomaraswamy's Mirror of Gestures.
 ... Śūdraka's Mṛchakatika. •
 ... Viśakhadatta's Mudrārākṣasa.

 ... Śāgaranandin's Nāṭakalakṣaṇaratnakosa.
 ... Rāmacandra and Guṇacandra's Nāṭyadarpaṇa.
 ... New Indo-Aryan.
 ... Nitti-Dolci's Le Grammairens Prakrit.
 ... Nāṭyaśāstra.
 ... Purāṇa.
 ... Pañcarātra
 ... Pāṇini.
 ... Piṅgala's Chandaśśūtra.
 ... Pischel's Grammatik der Prakrit-sprachen.
 ... Prākṛta-Piṅgala.
 ... Pratisākhya.
 ... Prakaraṇa.
 ... Bhāsa's Pratimā-nāṭaka.
 ... Bhāsa's Pratijñā-yaugandharāyaṇa.
 ... Pāṇiniya-Śikṣā.
 ... Pāia-sadda-mahāṇṇavo.
 ... Rāmāyaṇa.
 ... Harṣa's Ratnāvalī.
 ... Kālidāsa's Rtusamhāra.
 ... Kālidāsa's Abhijñānaśakuntala.
 ... Sāhityadarpaṇa.
 ... Śārṅgadeva's Saṃgītaratnākara.
 ... Bhoja's Śrṅgāraprakāśa.
 ... Bhāsa's Svapavāsavadattā.
 ... translation or translated.
 ... Uttararāmacarita of Bhavabhūti.

Ūru.	... Bhāsa's Ūrubhaṅga.
Vikram.	... Kālidāsa's Vikramorvaṣīya.
Winternitz.	... Winternitz's History of Indian Literature.

N.B. (a) Numerals preceding the paragraphs of the translation relate to the serial number of couplets in the original. When the same number is repeated in two consecutive paragraphs, in the first place it will indicate the first hemistich and in the second the second hemistich. Roman figures relate to the chapter of the NS.

(b) For the manner of referring to dramas, see under the Bhāsa-nāṭaka-cakra in the Bibliography (Original Texts).

(c) In the footnotes to the Introduction long vowels, cerebral sounds and the labial sibilant have been indicated by italics.

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CONTENTS

PREFACE	...	VII
LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS AND SYMBOLS	...	IX
BIBLIOGRAPHY	...	XII
INTRODUCTION	...	XXXVII

I. **The Present Work**, p. XXXVII ; 1. General History of the Study, p. XXXVII ; 2. Basic Text, p. XL ; 3. Translation, p. XLI ; 4. Notes to the Translation, p. XLI.

II. **The Ancient Indian Theory of Drama**, p. XLII ; 1. The Meaning of Nāṭya, p. XLII ; 2. The Dramatic Conventions, p. XLIV ; 3. The Time and Place of Drama, p. XLV ; 4. The Unity of Impression, p. XLV ; 5. Criticism of Drama, p. XLV ; 6. The Four Aspects of Drama, p. XLVIII.

III. **Literary Structure of the Ancient Indian Drama**, p. XLIX ; The Ten Types of Play. The Nāṭaka, p. XLIX ; (a) Subject-matter and the division into Acts, p. XLIX ; (b) Explanatory Devices. p. LI ; (i) Introductory Scene, p. LI ; (ii) The Intimating Speech, p. LI ; (iii) The Supporting Scene, p. LI ; (iv) The Transitional Scene, p. LI ; (v) The Anticipatory Scene, p. LI ; (c) The Plot and its Development, p. LI ; The Prakaraṇa, p. LII ; The Samavakāra, p. LII ; The Ihāṃga, p. LIII ; The Dīpa, p. LIII ; The Vyāyoga, p. LIII ; The Uṭṭṛṣṭikāṅka, p. LIII ; The Prahasana, p. LIII ; The Bhāṇa, p. LIV ; The Vithī, p. LIV. 2. Diction of Play, p. LIV ; (a) The Use of Metre, p. LIV ; (b) Euphony, p. LIV ; (c) Suggestive or Significant Names, p. LV ; (d) Variety of Languages Dialects, p. LV.

IV. **The Ancient Indian Drama in Practice**, p. LV ; 1. Occasions for Dramatic Performance, p. LV ; 2. The Time for Performance, p. LVI ; 3. The Playhouse, p. LVII ; 4. The Representation, p. LVIII. (a) The Physical Representation, p. LVIII ; (b) The Vocal Representation, p. LXI ; (c) The Costumes and Make-up, p. LXI ; (d) The Temperament, p. LXIII.

V. **Literature on the Ancient Indian Drama**, p. LXIV ; 1. The Early Writers : Śilālin and Kṛśāśva, p. LXIV ; 2. The So-called Sons of Bharata (a) Kohala, (b) Dattila, (c) Śātakarṇi (Śātakarna, Śālikarṇa), (d) Āśmakarṇa and Nakhakarṇa, (e) Bādarāyaṇa (Bādari), p. LXIV ; 3. Saṃ-

grahakāra, p. LXV ; 4. The Present Text of the Nāṭyaśāstra, p. LXV ; 5. Medieval Writers on Drama, (a) Nandī (Nandikeśvara), Tumburu, Viśākhila and Cārāyaṇa, (b) Sadāśiva, Padmabhū, Drauhiṇi, Vyāsa, and Āṇjaneya, (c) Kātyāyana, Rāhula and Garga, (d) Śakaligarbha and Ghaṇṭaka, (e) Vārtika-kāra-Harṣa, (f) Mātrgupta, (g) Subandhu, (h) Compilers of the Agnipurāṇa and the Viṣṇudharmottara, pp. LXV-LXVII ; (6) Late Literature on Drama. (a) Daśarūpa, (b) Nāṭakalakṣaṇaratnakośa, (c) Nāṭyadarpaṇa, (d) Ruyyaka's Nāṭakamīmāṃsā, (e) Bhāvaaprakāśana, (f) Sāhityadarpaṇa and Nāṭakaparibhāṣa, pp. LXVII-LXX.

VI. The Nāṭyaśāstra : The Text and its Commentaries, p. LXXI ; 1. Its Author, p. LXXI ; 2. The two Recensions, p. LXXI ; 3. Unity of the Nāṭyaśāstra, p. LXXII ; 4. Its Scope and Importance, p. LXXIV ; 5. Its Style and Method of Treatment, p. LXXIV ; 6. The Early Commentators : Ācārya Kirtidhara, and Bhāṣyakāra Nānyadeva (b) Bhaṭṭa Udbhaṭa, (c) Bhaṭṭa Lollaṭa, (d) Śrī Śaṅkuka, (e) Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka, (f) Bhaṭṭa Yantra, p. LXXV ; 7. Bhaṭṭa Abhinavagupta, p. LXXVI.

VII. Data of India's Cultural History in the Nāṭyaśāstra, p. LXXVIII ; 1. Language, p. LXXVIII ; 2. Literature, p. LXXVIII ; 3. Art, p. LXXVIII ; 4. Metrics, p. LXXIX ; 5. Poetics, p. LXXIX ; 6. Costumes and Ornaments, p. LXXIX ; 7. Mythology, p. LXXIX ; 8. Geography, p. LXXX ; 9. Ethnological Data, p. LXXX ; 10. Ars Amatoria, p. LXXX ; 11. Arthaśāstra, p. LXXX ; 12. Psychology, p. LXXXI.

VIII. The Date of the Nāṭyaśāstra, p. LXXXII ; 1. The Geographical Data, p. LXXXII ; 2. The Nāṭyaśāstra earlier than Kālidāsa, p. LXXXII ; 3. The Mythological Data, p. LXXXIII ; 4. The Ethnological Data, p. LXXXIII ; 5. The Epigraphical Data, p. LXXXIII ; 6. The Nāṭyaśāstra earlier than Bhāsa, p. LXXXIV.

CHAPTER ONE

THE ORIGIN OF DRAMA, Pages 1-17

1. Salutation, p. 1 ; 2-5. Sages question, p. 1 ; 6-23. Bharata answers, pp. 2-5 ; 24-25. The Nāṭyaveda and Bharata's one hundred sons, pp. 5-6 ; 26-40. Names of Bharata's one hundred sons, pp. 6-7 ; 41. Performance begins with three Styles, p. 7 ; 42-45. Need of the Kaiśikī Style, p. 7-8 ; 46-47. Creation of Apsarasas for practising the Kaiśikī Style, p. 8 ; 47-50. Names of Apsarasas, p. 8 ; 50-53. Svāti and Nārada engaged to help Brahman, pp. 8-9 ; 53-58. The Banner Festival of Indra and the first production of a play, p. 9 ; 58-63. The pleased gods reward Bharata's party, pp. 9-10 ; 64-66. Vighnas attack the actors, pp. 10-11 ; 67-68. Indra comes to their protection, p. 11 ; 69-75. The Origin of the Jarjara, p. 11 ; 75-81. The Origin of the first playhouse, pp. 11-12 ; 82-97. Different gods asked to protect different parts of the playhouse as well as the actors, pp. 12-13 ; 98-105. Brahman pacifies the Vighnas, pp. 13-14 ; 106-121. Characteristics of a drama, pp. 14-16 ; 122-129. Offering Pūjā to the gods of the stage, pp. 16-17.

CHAPTER TWO

DESCRIPTION OF THE PLAYHOUSE, Pages 18-32

1-3. Introduction, p. 18 ; 4-8. Three types of playhouse, pp. 18-19 ; 8-11. Three sizes of the playhouse, pp. 19 ; 12-16. The table of measurement, p. 20 ; 17. The playhouse for mortals, p. 20 ; 18-23. Disadvantage of a too big playhouse, pp. 20-21 ; 24-26. Selection of a suitable site, p. 21 ; 27-28. Measurement of a site, pp. 21-22 ; 28-33. Taking up the string for measurement, p. 22 ; 33-35. The ground plan of the playhouse, p. 22 ; 35-43. The ceremony of laying the foundation, pp. 23-24 ; 43-63. Raising pillars of the playhouse, pp. 24-26 ; 63-67. The Mattavāraṇi, pp. 26-27 ; 68-74. The stage, pp. 27-28 ; 75-85. Decorative work in the stage, pp. 28-30 ; 86-100. Description of a square playhouse, pp. 30-32 ; 101-104. Description of a triangular playhouse, p. 32.

CHAPTER THREE

PŪJĀ TO THE GODS OF THE STAGE, Pages 33-44

1-10. Consecration of the playhouse, pp. 33-34 ; 11-16. Offering Pūjā to the Jarjara, pp. 34-35 ; 17-20. Installation of gods, p. 35 ; 20-32. The Maṇḍala for installing the gods, pp. 35-36 ; 33-39. Offering Pūjā to the gods, p. 37 ; 40-73. Consecration of the Mattavāraṇi, pp. 37-40 ; 73-81. Consecration of the Jarjara, p. 41 ; 81-87. Homa or pouring ghṛe into sacrificial fire, pp. 41-42 ; 87-89. Breaking the jar, p. 42 ; 89-93. Illumination of the stage, pp. 42-43 ; 93-97. Good results of consecrating

XVIII

the stage, p. 43 ; 98-101. Evils following non-consecration of the stage, pp. 43-44.

CHAPTER FOUR

THE CLASS DANCE, Pages 45-75

1-14. Brahman writes the first play and gets it performed, pp. 45-46 ; 14-16. Two kinds of Preliminaries, pp. 46-47 ; 16-27. The *Aṅgahāras*, p. 47 ; 28-29. Uses of *Aṅgahāras*, p. 47 ; 29-61. The *Karaṇas*, pp. 47-49 ; 62-169. Definition of 108 the *Karaṇas*, pp. 49-60 ; 170-245. Definition of the *Aṅgahāras*, pp. 60-65 ; 246-252. The *Recakas*, pp. 65-66 ; 253-264. The *Pinḍibandhas*, pp. 66-68 ; 265-272. The Sages speak on the use of dance, pp. 68-69 ; 273-274. The *Vardhamānaka*, p. 69 ; 275. The *Āsarita*, p. 69 ; 276. The *Upohana*, p. 69 ; 277-294. Entry of female dancers and the four kinds of *Pinḍis*, pp. 69-72 ; 295-308. The *Cāndakas*, pp. 72-73 ; 309-310. The gentle dance, p. 73 ; 311-314. Occasions suited to dance, pp. 73-74 ; 315-320. Occasions when dances are prohibited ; p. 74 ; 321-324. Playing of drums, pp. 74-75 ; 325-328. When drums are not to be played, p. 75

CHAPTER FIVE

THE PRELIMINARIES OF A PLAY, Pages 76-99

1-4. The sages question, 76 ; p. 5-6. Bharata answers, p. 76 ; 7. Preliminaries defined, p. 76 ; 8-16. Parts of the Preliminaries, pp. 76-77. 17. *Pratyāhāra*, and *Avataraṇa*, pp. 78 ; 18. *Ārambha*, and *Āsrāvaṇa*, pp. 78 ; 19. *Vaktrapāṇi*, *Parighaṭṭanā*, p. 78 ; 20. *Samghoṭanā*, *Mārgāsārita*, p. 79. 21. *Āsarita* and the Application of Songs, p. 79 ; 22-23. *Uttāpana*, p. 79 ; 23-24. The Walking-round, p. 79 ; 24-25. The Benediction, 79 ; 25-26. *Śuṣkāvakṛṣṭā Dhruvā*, pp. 80 ; 26-27. *Raṅgadvāra*, p. 80 ; 27-28. The *Cārī* and the *Mahācārī*, p. 80 ; 28-29. Three Men's Talk, p. 80 ; 29-30. The Laudation, p. 80 ; 30-32. Origin of *Bahirgīta* and its justification, pp. 80-81 ; 33-36. *Daityas* and *Rākṣasas* provoked to jealousy, p. 81 ; 37-38. The gods approach *Nārada* to stop the *Nirgīta*, p. 81 ; 38-44. *Nārada* pacifies the gods, p. 82 ; 44-59. The gods are pleased with the *Nirgīta* (*Bahirgīta*), pp. 82-83 ; 60-64. Songs in pure Preliminaries, p. 84 ; 65-66. The first Walking-round, p. 84 ; 67-76. The second Walking-round, pp. 84-86 ; 77-84. The third Walking-round, pp. 86-87 ; 84-89. The fourth Walking-round, p. 87 ; 89-101. The *Parivartanī Dhruvā*, pp. 87-89 ; 101-104. The Fourth Man enters, p. 89 ; 104-107. Singing of the *Avakṛṣṭā Dhruvā*, pp. 89-90 ; 107-113. Examples of the Benediction, pp. 90-91 ; 113-116. An example of *Śuṣkāvakṛṣṭā Dhruvā*, p. 91 ; 116-119. *Raṅgadvāra*, p. 91 ; 119-127. *Cārī*, pp. 92-93 ; 127-137. *Mahācārī*, pp. 93-94 ; 137-141. The Three Men's Talk, p. 94 ; 141-142. The Laudation, pp. 94-95 ;

143-154. The Tryasra Preliminaries, pp. 95-96 ; 155-166. The Mixed Preliminaries, pp. 96-97 ; 167-179. Introduction of a play, pp. 97-99.

CHAPTER SIX

THE SENTIMENTS, pages 100-117

1-3. The sages question, p. 100 ; 4-8. Bharata answers, pp. 100-101 ; 8-14. Digest, Memorial Verse and Etymology defined, pp. 101 ; 15-16. The eight Sentiments, p. 102 ; 17-21. The Dominant States, p. 102 ; 22. The eight Temperamental States. pp. 102-103 ; 23. The four kinds of Histrionic Representation, p. 103 ; 24. The two Practices and the four Styles, p. 103 ; 25-26. The four Local Usages, and the Success, p. 104 ; 27-29. The notes, and the four kinds of musical instrument. p. 104 ; 29-31. The five kinds of Dhruvā, pp. 104-105 ; 31-33. The Sentiments explained, pp. 105-136 ; 33-38. The relation between the Sentiment and the States, p. 106-107 ; 38-43. The eight Sentiments from the four original ones, p. 107-108 ; 44-45. The presiding deities of the Sentiments, p. 108 ; 45-48. The Erotic Sentiment, pp. 108-110 ; 48-55. The Comic Sentiment, pp. 110-111 ; 56-57. Of persons of the middling type, p. 111 ; 58-61. Of persons of the inferior type, pp. 111-112 ; 61-63. The Pathetic Sentiment, p. 112 ; 63-66. The Furious Sentiment, pp. 112-113 ; 66-68. The Heroic Sentiment, p. 114 ; 68-72. The Terrible Sentiment. pp. 114-115 ; 72-74. The Odious Sentiment, pp. 115 ; 74-76. The Marvellous Sentiment, p. 116 ; 77. The three kinds of the Erotic, the Comic and the Terrible Sentiments, p. 116 ; 78. The three kinds of the Pathetic Sentiment, p. 116 ; 79. The three kinds of the Heroic Sentiment, pp. 116-117, 80. The three kinds of the Terrible Sentiment, 117. 81. The three kinds of the Odious Sentiment, p. 117 ; 82-83. The three kinds of the Marvellous Sentiment, p. 117.

CHAPTER SEVEN

THE EMOTIONAL AND OTHER STATES, Pages 118-147.

1-3. *Bhāvas* (States) explained, p. 118 ; 3-4. *Vibhāvas* (Determinants) explained, pp. 118-119 ; 4-6 *Anubhāvas* (Consequents) explained, p. 119 ; 6-7. The three kinds of State ; Dominant, Transitory and Temperamental, pp. 119-120 ; 7-8. Difference between the Dominant and the other States pp. 120-121 ; 8-9. Love, p. 121 ; 9-10. Laughter, p. 121 ; 10-14. Sorrow, p. 122 ; 14-20. Anger, pp. 122-123 ; 20-21. Energy, pp. 123-124 ; 21-25. Fear, p. 124 ; 25-26. Disgust, p. 125 ; 26-27. Astonishment p. 125 ; 27-29. The Transitory States, pp. 125-126 ; 27-30. Discouragement, p. 126 ; 30-32. Weakness, pp. 126-127 ; 32-35. Apprehension, pp. 127 ; 35-37. Envy, pp. 127-128 ; 37-46. Intoxication, pp. 128-129 ; 46-47. Weariness, p. 129 ; 47-48. Indolence, pp. 129-130 ; 48-49. Depression, p. 130 ; 49-51. Anxiety, p. 130 ; 51-53. Distraction, pp. 130-131 ; 53-55.

Recollection, p. 131 ; 55-57. Contentment, pp. 131-132 ; 57-59. Shame, p. 132 ; 59-60. Inconstancy, p. 132-133 ; 60-62. Joy, p. 133 ; 62-65. Agitation, pp. 133-134 ; 65-66. Stupor, p. 134-135 ; 66-67. Arrogance, p. 135 ; 67-69. Despair, p. 135-136 ; 69-70. Impatience, p. 136 ; 70-72. Sleeping, p. 136 ; 72-74. Epilepsy, p. 137 ; 74-76. Dreaming, pp. 137-138 ; 76-77. Awakening, p. 138 ; 77-79. Indignation, p. 138 ; 79-80. Dissimulation, pp. 138-139 ; 80-81. Cruelty, p. 139 ; 81-82. Assurance, p. 139 ; 82-83. Sickness, pp. 139-140 ; 83-85. Insanity, pp. 140-141 ; 85-90. Death, pp. 141-142 ; 90-91. Fright, p. 142 ; 91-93. Deliberation, pp. 142-143 ; 93. Temperamental States, p. 143 ; 95. Perspiration, p. 144 ; 96. Paralysis and Trembling, p. 144 ; 97. Weeping, p. 144 ; 98. Change of Colour and Horripilation, p. 144 ; 99. Change of Voice and Fainting, p. 144 ; 100-106. Representation of the Temperamental States, pp. 144-145 ; 107-124. Application of the States to the different Sentiments, pp. 145-147.

CHAPTER EIGHT

THE GESTURES OF MINOR LIMBS, Pages 148-167

1-3. Sages question, p. 148 ; 4-6 Bharata answers, pp. 148-149 ; 7. The meaning of *abhinaya*, p. 149 ; 8-9. The four kinds of *abhinaya*, p. 149 ; 11-16. The Gesture : its three varieties, pp. 149-150 ; 17-37. Gestures of the head and their uses, pp. 150-152 ; 38-42. The thirtysix Glances, pp. 152-153 ; 43-51. The Glances to express the Sentiments, pp. 153-154 ; 52-60. The Glances to express the Dominant States, pp. 154-155 ; 61-84. The Glances to express the Transitory States, pp. 155-158 ; 85-95. Uses of Glances to express the Transitory States, pp. 158-159 ; 95-98. The eyeballs, pp. 159-160 ; 99-102. Uses of the eyeballs, p. 160 ; 103-107. The additional Glances, pp. 160-161 ; 108-111. The eyelids, p. 161 ; 112-115. Uses of the eyelids, p. 162 ; 116-120. The eyebrows, pp. 162-163. 121-125. Uses of the eyebrows, p. 163 ; 126-128. The nose, pp. 163-164 ; 129-132. Uses of the nose, p. 164 ; 132-134. The cheeks ; p. 164 ; 135-137. Uses of the cheeks, pp. 164-165 ; 137-139. The lower lip, p. 165 ; 140-142. Uses of the lower lip, p. 165 ; 143-146. The chin, p. 166 ; 146-149. Uses of the chin, p. 166 ; 149-157. The mouth, pp. 166-167 ; 157-158. The colour of the face, p. 167 ; 159-165. Uses of the colour of the face, pp. 167-168 ; 166-167. The neck, p. 168 ; 167-173. Description and uses of the neck gestures, pp. 168-169.

CHAPTER NINE

THE GESTURES OF HANDS, Pages 170-190

1-3. Bharata speaks, p. 170 ; 4-17. Sixtyseven gestures of the hand, pp. 170-171 ; 17-126. Gestures of single hands, pp. 171-181 ; 126-155. Gestures of combined hands, pp. 182-185 ; 156-159. General rules regarding the use of hand gestures, p. 185 ; 160-165. Different movements of

hand gestures, p. 185 ; 166-167. Spheres of hand gestures, p. 186 ; 168-177. The quantity of gestures, pp. 186-187 ; 178-204. The Dance-hands, pp. 187-189 ; 205-211. The four Karaṇas of the hands, pp. 189-190 ; 212-214. The movements of arms, p. 190.

CHAPTER TEN

THE GESTURES OF OTHER LIMBS, Pages 191-196.

1-9. The breast, pp. 191 ; 10-15. The sides, p. 192 ; 16-17. Uses of the sides, p. 192 ; 18. The belly, p. 192 ; 19-20. Uses of the belly, pp. 192-193 ; 21-24. The waist, p. 193 ; 25-26. Uses of the waist, pp. 193-194 ; 27-31. The thigh, p. 194 ; 32-33. Uses of the thigh, p. 194 ; 34-37. The shank, pp. 194-195 ; 28-40. Uses of the shank, p. 165 ; 41-51. The feet and their uses, pp. 195-196 ; 52-54. The Cāris, p. 196.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE CĀRI MOVEMENTS, Pages 197-206

1-3. Definitions, p. 197 ; 4-6. Uses of the Cāris, p. 197 ; 7-12. The thirtytwo Cāris, pp. 197-198 ; 13-28. The earthly Cāris, pp. 198-199 ; 29-49. The aerial Cāris, pp. 199-201 ; 50-71. The Sthānas, pp. 201-203 ; 71-88. The four Nyāyas in using weapons, pp. 203-205 ; 88-91. The Sauṣṭhava, p. 205 ; 91-92. The Caturasra, p. 205 ; 92-94. The four acts relating to the bow, p. 205 ; 94-96. The method of exercise, pp. 205-206 ; 96-100 Health and nourishment of persons taking exercise ; p. 206.

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE MAṆḌALA MOVEMENTS, Pages 207-212

1-5. The Maṇḍalas, p. 207 ; 6-41. The aerial Maṇḍalas, pp. 207-210 ; 42-68. The earthly Maṇḍalas, pp. 210-212.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

THE DIFFERENT GAITS, Pages 213-237

1. Gaits for different characters, p. 213 ; 2-3. Entrance of dramatis personae, p. 213 ; 4-7. Posture for superior and middling characters at the entrance, p. 213 ; 8-10. The interval of their feet, pp. 213-214 ; 10-11. The time for their steps, p. 214 ; 12-14. The tempo of their Gait, p. 214 ; 15-24. The natural Gait, pp. 214-215 ; 25-29. Gait of kings, p. 216 ; 30-34. Gait under special conditions, p. 216 ; 35-40. Tempo of Gaits under special conditions, pp. 217 ; 41-48. Gait in the Erotic Sentiment, pp. 217-218 ; 48-54. Gait in the Terrible Sentiment, p. 218 ; 54-56. Gait in the Odious Sentiment, p. 218 ; 57-58. Gait in the Heroic Sentiment, pp. 218-219 ; 59-60. Gait in the Marvellous and the Comic Sentiments, p. 219 ; 61-69. Gait in the Pathetic Sentiment, pp. 219-220 ; 70-75. Gait (of inferior characters) in the Terrible Sentiment, p. 220 ; 76-78. Gait of

merchants and ministers, p. 220 ; 79-86. Gait of ascetics and sectarians, pp. 220-221 ; 87. Gait of a person in darkness, p. 221 ; 88-92. Gait of one riding a chariot, pp. 221-222 ; 92-95. Gait while moving in the sky, p. 222 ; 96-100. Gait in ascending a lofty palace, p. 222 ; 101-104. Gait in getting down into a lower place, pp. 222-223 ; 105-107. Gait in travelling by boat, p. 223 ; 108. Gait in riding a horse, p. 223 ; 109. Gait of serpents, p. 223 ; 110. Gait of a Parasite, p. 224 ; 112-114. Gait of the Kāncukiya, p. 224 ; 115-117. Gait of emaciated, sick and fatigued persons, p. 225 ; 118. Gait of a person walking a long distance, p. 225 ; 119-120. Gait of a corpulent person p. 225 ; 121-122. Gait of intoxicated persons, p. 225 ; 123-130. Gait of a lunatic, p. 225 ; 131-136. Gait of lame men, cripples and dwarfs, p. 226 ; 137-146. Gait of the Jester, pp. 226-227 ; 146-148. Gait of maniacs, p. 227 ; 148-149. Gait of Śākāra, p. 228 ; 150. Gait of lowly persons, p. 228 ; 151. Gait of the Mleccha tribes, p. 228 ; 152. Gait of birds ; 153-158. Gait of lions, bears and monkeys, pp. 228-229 ; 159-171. Walking postures of women, pp. 230-229 ; 171-177. Gait of women, p. 230 ; 177-179. Gait of young women, p. 231 ; 179-181. Gait of aged women, p. 231 ; 181-183. Gait of handmaids, p. 231 ; 183-186. Gait of half-women, p. 231 ; 186-187. Gait of children, p. 242 ; 187-181. Gait of hermaphrodite, p. 232 ; 188-189. Gait in the change of a role, p. 232 ; 189-191. Gait of persons in disguise, p. 232 ; 192-193. Gait of the tribal women, p. 232 ; 193-195. Gait of women ascetics ; pp. 232-233 ; 195-199. Sitting postures for men and women, p. 233 ; 196-197. Sitting at ease, p. 233 ; 197-198. Sitting in a thinking mood, p. 233 ; 198-199. Sitting in sorrow, p. 233 ; 199-200. Sitting in fainting and intoxication, p. 233 ; 200-201. Sitting in shame and sleep, p. 234 ; 201-202. Sitting on ceremonial occasions, p. 234 ; 202-203. Sitting in pacifying a beloved woman, p. 234 ; 203-206. Sitting in worshipping a deity, p. 234 ; 206-207. Seats for different characters, p. 234 ; 208-210. Seats for male characters, p. 235 ; 210-214. Seats for female characters, p. 235 ; 215-216. Seats for ascetics and sectarians, p. 235 ; 217-220. General rules about seats, p. 236 ; 221-228. Lying-down postures, pp. 236-237.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

THE ZONES AND THE LOCAL USAGES, Pages 238-247

1. The Zones, p. 238 ; 2. The arrangement of drums, p. 238 ; 3. The Zonal division, p. 238 ; 4-7. Utility of the Zonal division, p. 238 ; 8-10. Indicating relative location on the stage, p. 239 ; 11. The east on the stage, p. 239 ; 12-15. The rule of exit, p. 232 ; 16. Indication of rank in group walking, p. 239 ; 17. Indicating distance great, small and medium, p. 240 ; 18-20. Movements of gods and demigods p. 240 ; 21. Movement of men in Bhāratavarṣa, p. 240 ; 22. Departure for a distant place,

p. 240 ; 23-32. Time allowed for the events of an Act, pp. 240-241 ; 32-35. Movements of gods, p. 241 ; 36. The four Local Usages, pp. 241-242 ; 37-39. The Dākṣiṇātyā Local Usages, pp. 242-243 ; 40-42. The Āvantī Local Usage, p. 243 ; 43-46. The Oḍra-Māgadhi Local Usage, 243 ; 47-49. The Pāñcāla-Madhyamā Local Usage, p. 244 ; 50-55. The two-fold entrance in observing Local Usage, p. 244 ; 50. The two General types of plays, p. 245. 57-60. The violent type, p. 245 ; 61. The delicate type, p. 245 ; 62. The two Practices, p. 245 ; 63-64. The realistic Practice, pp. 245-246 ; 65-78. The conventional Practice, pp. 246-247.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

RULES OF PROSODY, Pages 248-261

1. The actor's speech, p. 248 ; 2-4. Importance of speech in drama, p. 248 ; 5. The two kinds of recitation, p. 248 ; 6-7. Different aspects of Recitation, p. 249 ; 8. The speech-sounds, p. 249 ; 9-19. Consonants ; their articulation, pp. 249-251 ; 20. Vowels ; their quantity, p. 251 ; 21-22. The four kinds of word, p. 252 ; 23-25. The noun, pp. 252-253 ; 26-27. The verb, p. 253 ; 28. The particle, p. 254 ; 29. The affixes, p. 254 ; 30. The nominal affix, p. 254 ; 31. The case-ending, p. 255 ; 32-33. The euphonic combination, p. 255 ; 34-35. The compound words, pp. 255-256 ; 36. The two kinds of word, p. 256 ; 37. Words in prose, p. 256 ; 38. Words in verse, p. 256 ; 39. Syllabic metres, p. 256 ; 40-42. Rhythm-types, pp. 256-257 ; 43-49. Twenty-six Rhythm-types, p. 257 ; 49-79. Possible metrical patterns, pp. 257-258 ; 79-89. Another method of defining metres, pp. 258-259 ; 89-90. The regular couplet, p. 259 ; 90-91. The stop and the foot, pp. 259-260 ; 93. Quality of syllables, colours of metres, p. 260 ; 94-95. Pitch of vowels, p. 260 ; 95-97. Three kinds of syllabic metres, p. 260 ; 98-102. Classes of metres, p. 261.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

METRICAL PATTERNS, Pages 262-292

1-2. Tanumadhyā, p. 262 ; 3-4. Makaraka-śirṣā, p. 262 ; 5-6. Mālatī, p. 263 ; 7-8. Mālinī, p. 263 ; 9-10. Uddhatā, pp. 263-264 ; 11-12. Bhramaramālikā, p. 264 ; 13-14. Siṃhalekhā, p. 264 ; 15-16. Mattaceṣṭita, pp. 264-265 ; 17-18. Vidyullekhā, p. 265 ; 19-20. Cittavilasita, pp. 265-266 ; 21-22. Madhukarī, p. 266 ; 23-24. Kuvalayamālā, p. 266 ; 25-26. Mayūrasārīṇī, pp. 266-267 ; 27-28. Dodhaka, p. 267 ; 29-30. Moṭaka, pp. 267-268 ; 31-32. Indravajrā, p. 268 ; 33-34. Upendravajrā, pp. 268-269 ; 35-36. Rathod-dhatā, p. 269 ; 37-38. Svāgatā, pp. 269 ; 39-40. Śālinī, p. 270 ; 41-42. Toṭaka, p. 270 ; 43-44. Kumudanibhā, pp. 270-271 ; 45-46. Candralekhā, p. 271 ; 47-48. Pramitākṣarā, pp. 271-272 ; 49-50. Vaṃśasthā, p. 272 . 51-52. Hariṇaplūtā, pp. 272-273 ; 53-54. Kāmadattā, p. 273 ; 55-56. Aprameyā, p. 273-274 ; 57-58. Padminī, p. 275 ; 59-60. Paṭuvṛtta,

pp. 274-275 ; 61-62. *Prabhāvati* ; p. 275 ; 63-64. *Praharṣiṇī*, pp. 275-276 ; 65-66. *Mattamayūra*, p. 276 ; 67-68. *Vasantatilaka*, pp. 276-277 ; 69-70. *Asambādhā*, p. 277 ; 71-72. *Śarabhā*, pp. 277-278 ; 73-74. *Nāṇḍimukhi*, p. 278 ; 75-74. *Gajavilasite* pp. 278-279 ; 77-78. *Pravaralalita*, p. 279 ; 79-80. *Śikharīṇī*, pp. 279-280 ; 81-82. *Vṛṣabhaceṣṭita*, p. 280 ; 83-84. *Śrīdharā*, pp. 280-281 ; 85-86. *Vamśapatrapatita*, p. 281 ; 87-88. *Vilambitagati*, pp. 281-282 ; 89-90. *Citrālekḥā*, p. 282 ; 91-93. *Śārdūlavikrīḍita*, p. 283 ; 94-96. *Suvadanā*, pp. 283-284 ; 97-99. *Sragdharā*, p. 284 ; 100-102. *Madraka*, pp. 284-285 ; 103-105. *Aśvalalita*, p. 286 ; 106-108. *Meghamālā*, p. 286 ; 109-111. *Krauñcapadī*, pp. 286-287 ; 112-114. *Bhujāṅga-vijṛmbhita*, pp. 287-288 ; 115-118. The uneven and the semi-even metres ; p. 288 , 119-120. Even metres, p. 288 ; 121-122. *Pathyā*, p. 288 ; 123-124. Uneven *Pathyā*, p. 289 ; 125-126. Inverted *Pathyā*, p. 290 ; 127-128. *Capalā*, p. 290 ; 129-136. *Vipulā*, pp. 290-292 ; 137-138. *Vāṇavāsikā*, p. 292 ; 139-140. *Ketumatī*, p. 292 ; 141-142. *Aparavaktra*, p. 93 ; 143-144. *Puṣṭi-tāgrā*, 293 ; 145-146. *Udgatā*, pp. 293-294 ; 147-151. *Lalitā*, pp. 294-295 ; 152-159. *Āryā* metres, pp. 295-296 ; 160. *Pathyā Āryā* and *Vipulā Āryā*, p. 296 ; 161. *Pathyā Āryā*, p. 296 ; 162. *Vipulā Āryā*, p. 296 ; 163-164. *Capalā Āryā*, pp. 296-297 ; 165. *Mukha-capalā* and *Jaghana-capalā Āryā*, p. 297 ; 166. *Mukha-capalā Āryā*, p. 297 ; 167-170. *Jaghana-capalā Āryā*, p. 298.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

DICTION OF A PLAY, Pages 299-322.

1-5. Thirtysix marks of a good play, pp. 299-300 ; 6. Ornateness, p. 30 ; 7. Compactness, p. 300 ; 8. Brilliance, p. 301 ; 9. Parallelism, p. 301 ; 10. Causation, p. 301 ; 11. Hesitation, p. 301 ; 12. Favourable Precedent, p. 301 ; 13. Discovefy, p. 302 ; 14. Fancy, p. 302 ; 15. Unfavourable Precedent, p. 302 ; 16. Convincing Explanation, p. 302 ; 17. Persuasion, p. 303 ; 18. Distinction, p. 303 ; 19. Accusation of Virtues, p. 303 ; 20. Excellency, p. 303 ; 21. Inference from Similitude, pp. 303-304 ; 22. Multiplex Predication, p. 304 ; 23. Description, p. 304 ; 24. Pointed Utterance, p. 304 ; 25. Deliberation, p. 304 ; 26. Inversion, p. 305 ; 27. Slip of Tongue, p. 305 ; 28. Mediation, p. 305 ; 29. Series of Offers, p. 305 ; 30. Clever Manners, p. 306 ; 31. Ceasure, p. 306 ; 32. Presumption, p. 306 ; 33. Celebrity, p. 306 ; 34. Interrogation ; 35. Identity, p. 307 ; 36. Indirect Expression of Desire, p. 307 ; 37. Wit, p. 307 ; 38. Concealment, p. 307 ; 39. Enumeration of Merits, p. 308 ; 40. Semi-uttered Expression, p. 308 ; 41-42. Compliment, p. 308 ; 33. Four figures of Speech, p. 308 ; 44. Simile, p. 309 ; 45-49. Number of objects compared, p. 309 ; 50. Five kinds of simile, p. 309 ; 51. Simile of praise, p. 309 ; 52. Simils of censure, p. 309 ; 53. Simile of conceit, p. 309 ; 24. Simile of uniqueness, p. 310 ; 55-56. Simile of

Partial likeness, p. 310 ; 57-58. Condensed Expression, p. 310 ; 59-60. Metaphor, pp. 310 ; 61. Yamaka, p. 311 ; 62-64. Ten kinds of Yamaka, p. 311 ; 65-66. Pādānta Yamaka, p. 311 ; 67-68. Kāñci Yamaka, pp. 311-312 ; 69-70. Samudga Yamaka, p. 312 ; 71-72. Vikrānta Yamaka, p. 312 ; 73-74. Cakravāla Yamaka, p. 313 ; 75-76. Sandaṣṭa Yamaka, p. 313 ; 77-78. Pādādi Yamaka, pp. 313-314 ; 79-80. Āmreḍita Yamaka, p. 314 ; 81-82. Caturvyavasita Yamaka, p. 314 ; 83-87. Mālā Yamaka, pp. 314-315 ; 88. Ten faults, pp. 315-316 ; 89. Circulocution and superfluous Expression, p. 316 ; 90-91. Want of Significance and Defective Significance, p. 316 ; 92. Tautology and Want of Synthesis, pp. 316-317 ; 93. Logical Defect and Metrical Defect, p. 317 ; 94. Hiatus and Slang, p. 317 ; 95. Guṇas, p. 317 ; 96. Ten Guṇas, pp. 317-318 ; 97. Synthesis, p. 318 ; 98. Perspicuity, p. 318 ; 99. Smoothness, p. 318 ; 100. Concentration, p. 318 ; 101. Sweetness, p. 319 ; 102. Grandeur, p. 319 ; 103. Agreeableness, p. 319 ; 104. Directness of Expression, p. 319 ; 105-106. Exaltedness, pp. 319-320 ; 107. Alamkāras and Guṇas, p. 320 ; 108-110. Sounds and figures of speech according to Sentiments, Metres according to Sentiments, In the Erotic Sentiment, p. 320 ; 111-112. Metres in the Heroic Sentiment, and in the Pathetic Sentiment, p. 321 ; 113. In the Heroic and the Furious Sentiments, p. 321 ; 114-115. Vowel length in different Sentiments and States, p. 321 ; 116-122. Uses of prolated vowels and euphony, pp. 331-322.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

RULES ON THE USE OF LANGUAGES, Pages 323-334

1-2. The Prakritic Recitation, p. 323 ; 3-5. Three kinds of Prakritic Recitation, p. 323 ; 6-17. Vowels and simple consonants, pp. 324-325 ; 18-25. Conjunct Consonants, pp. 325-326 ; 26. Four types of language, p. 326 ; 27. The Superhuman and the Noble languages, p. 327 ; 30. The two kinds of Recitation, p. 327 ; 31. Occasion for Skt. Recitation, p. 328 ; 32-35. Occasion for Pkt. Recitation, pp. 328-329 ; 36-46. Exception to the rule for Pkt. recitation, pp. 329-331 ; 47-48. Seven major dialects, p. 331 ; 49-51. Uses of major dialects, pp. 331-332 ; 52-55. Uses of minor dialects, pp. 332-333 ; 56-61. Distinguishing features of various local dialects, pp. 333-334.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

MODES OF ADDRESS AND INTONATION, Pages 335-354

1-2. Different modes of address, p. 335 ; 3. Modes of addressing males, p. 335 ; 4. Addressing gods, sectarian teachers and learned men, p. 335 ; 5. Addressing Brahmins, the king, the teacher and an old man, p. 336 ; 6. Brahmins addressing the king, p. 336 ; 7. Brahmins addressing ministers, p. 336 ; 8. Addressing the equals, Privileged inferiors

addressing superiors, pp. 336-337; 9. Addressing employees, artisans and artists, p. 337; 10. Addressing persons, of respect, 'addressing persons of equal status p. 337; 11. The charioteer addressing the chariot-rider, Addressing an ascetic or a person with beatitude, pp. 337-338; 12. Addressing princes, Addressing inferior persons, p. 338; 13. Addressing persons by their occupation or birth, p. 339; 14. Addressing a son or a disciple p. 339; 15. Addressing Buddhist and Jain monks, Addressing persons of other sects, p. 339; 16. People addressing the king, pp. 339-340; 17-18. Sages addressing the king, The Jester addressing the king, The Jester addressing the queen, her maids, and the king addressing the Jester, p. 340; 19. Women addressing their husband, p. 341; 20. Addressing the older and the younger brothers, p. 341; 21. Modes of addressing women and female ascetics and goddesses, p. 341; 22. Addressing wives of senior persons, and elderly ladies, Addressing an accessible woman and an old lady, pp. 341-342; 23-24. Addressing king's wives, p. 342; 25. Addressing unmarried princesses and a sister, pp. 342-343; 26. Addressing a Brahmin lady, a nun or a female ascetic, addressing one's wife, p. 343; 27. Women addressing their equals, addressing a hand-maid, p. 343; 28. Addressing a courtesan, p. 343; 29. Addressing the wife in love-making, p. 344; 30. Giving names to different characters in a play, p. 344; 31. Names of Brahmins and Kṣatriyas, p. 344; 32. Naming merchants and warriors, p. 344; 33. Naming king's wives and courtesans, p. 345; 34. Naming handmaids and menials, p. 345; 45. Naming superiors, p. 345; 37-37a. Naming other persons, p. 345; 37-38. Qualities of Recitation, p. 346; 38-40. Seven notes to suit different Sentiments, p. 346; 40-43. Uses of the three voice registers, p. 346; 43. Uses of the four accents, p. 347; 43-44. Two ways of intonation, p. 347; 45. The Six Alamkāras, p. 348; 45-57. Uses of the six Alamkāras, pp. 348-350; 58-59. Intonation in different Sentiments, Six limbs of enunciation, pp. 350-351; 59-60. Pause defined, pp. 351-352; 60-61. Uses of Pause, p. 352; 62-67. Hands in connexion with Alamkāras and Pause, p. 352; 68-78. Drawn-out syllables and their use, pp. 353-354.

CHAPTER TWENTY

TEN KINDS OF PLAY, Pages 355-379

1-9. Tenfold division of plays and their structure, p. 355; 10-12. The Nāṭaka, p. 356; 13-18. The Act, pp. 356-357; 19-26. Incidents not directly presentable in an Act, pp. 358-359; 27-35. The Introductory Scene, pp. 359-360; 36-38. The Supporting Scene, pp. 360-361; 39-40. Number of *dramatis personae*, p. 361; 41-42. Introducing chariots and palaces on the stage, pp. 361-362; 43-47. Introducing an army on the stage p. 362; 48-50. The Prakaraṇa, pp. 262-364; 59-63. The Nāṭikā, pp. 364-365; 64-66. The Samavakāra, pp. 365-366; 67. The first act of the

Samavakāra, p. 366 ; 68-69. The second and the third acts of the Samavakāra, pp. 366-367 ; 70. The three kinds of Excitement, p. 367 ; 71. Three kinds of Deception, p. 367 ; 72. Three kinds of Love, p. 367 ; 73. Love together with duty, pp. 367 ; 74. Love together with material gain, p. 368 ; 75. Love due to passion, p. 368 ; 76-77. Metres not allowed in the Samavakāra, p. 368 ; 78-83. The Īhāmrga, pp. 368-369 ; 84-89. The Īima, p. 370 ; 90-93. The Vyāyoga, p. 370 ; 94-96. The Utaṣṭi-kāṅka, p. 371 ; 97-101. Scenes with celestial Heroes, pp. 372. 371 ; 102. The Prahāsana, p. 372 ; 103-104. The pure Prahāsana, p. 372 ; 105-107. The mixed Prahāsana, pp. 372-373 ; 107-111. The Bhāṇa, p. 373 ; 112-113. The Vithi, pp. 373-374 ; 114-116. Thirteen types of the Vithi, p. 374 ; 117. Accidental Interpretation, p. 374 ; 118. Transference, p. 374 ; 119. Ominous Significance, p. 374 ; 120-121. Incoherent Chatter, p. 375 ; 122. Compliment, p. 375 ; 123. Enigma and Rapartee, p. 375 ; 124. Ontvying, p. 375 ; 125. Deception, 375 ; 126. Declaration, p. 376 ; 127. Crushing, p. 376 ; 128. Three Men's Talk, p. 376 ; 129-131. Undue Combination of Words, p. 376 ; 132-133. The Lāsya, p. 377 ; 134-135. The twelve types of the Lāsya, p. 377 ; 136-137. Geyapada, p. 377 ; 138. Sthitapāṭhya, p. 378 ; 139. Āsina, p. 378 ; 140. Puṣpagandikā, p. 378 ; 141. Pracchedaka, p. 378 ; 142. Trimūḍhaka, p. 378 ; 143. Saindhavaka, p. 378 ; 144. Dvimūḍhaka, p. 379 ; 145. Uttamottaka, p. 379 ; 146. Vicitrapada, p. 379 ; 147. Uktapratyukta, p. 379, 148-150. Bhāvita, p. 379.

CHAPTER TWENTY ONE

THE LIMBS OF THE JUNCTURES, Pages 380-400

1. The five Junctures of the Plot, p. 380 ; 2. The two kinds of Plot ; 308 ; 3-5. Their definition, p. 380 ; 6-8. The five stages of the action ; pp. 380-381 ; 9. Beginning, p. 381 ; 10. Effort, p. 381 ; 11. Possibility of Attainment, p. 381 ; 12. Certainty of Attainment, p. 381 ; 13-15. Attainment of Results, pp. 381-382 ; 16-17. Play to begin with the Principal Plot, p. 382 ; 18-19. Rules about the omission of Junctures, p. 382 ; 20-21. The five elements of the Plot, p. 382 ; 22. The Germ, p. 383 ; 23. The Prominent Point, p. 383 ; 24. The Episode, p. 383 ; 25. The Episodical Incident, p. 383 ; 26-27. The Dénouement, p. 383 ; 28. Secondary Junctures in the Episode, p. 384 ; 29. Limit of the Episode, p. 384 ; 30. The Episode Indication, p. 384 ; 31. The First Episode Indication, p. 384 ; 32. The Second Episode Indication, p. 384 ; 33. The Third Episode Indication, p. 384 ; 34-35. The Fourth Episode Indication, p. 385 ; 36-37. The five Junctures, p. 385 ; 38. The Opening, p. 385 ; 39. The Progression, p. 385 ; 40. The Development, p. 385 ; 41. The Pause, pp. 385-386 ; 42-43. The Conclusion, p. 386 ; 44-47. Junctures vary in different types of Drama, p. 386 ; 48-50. Subjuncture, p. 387 ; 51. Alternative Junctures, p. 387 ; 52-53. The sixfold needs of the Limbs

of the Junctures, p. 387 ; 54-57. Uses of the Limbs of the Junctures, pp. 387-388 ; 58-68. The sixtyfour limbs of the Junctures, pp. 388-389 ; 69. Limbs of the Opening, Suggestion, p. 389 ; 70. Enlargement, Establishment, p. 389 ; 71. Allurement, Decision, pp. 389-390 ; 72. Accession, Settling, p. 390 ; 73. Conflict of Feelings, Surprise, p. 390 ; 74. Disclosure, Activity, p. 390 ; 75. Incitement, Limbs of the Progression, p. 390 ; 76. Amorousness, Pursuit, p. 391 ; 77. Refusal, Pessimism, p. 391 ; 78. Joke, Flash of Joke, p. 391 ; 79. Moving Forward, Hindrance, p. 391 ; 80. Pacification, Sweet Words, pp. 391-392 ; 81. Thunderbolt, Reference, p. 392 ; 82. Meeting of Castes, Limbs of the Development, p. 392 ; 83. Mis-statement, Indication, p. 392 ; 84. Supposition, Exaggeration p. 392 ; 85. Progress, Propitiation, p. 393 ; 86. Deduction, Supplication, p. 393 ; 87. Revelation, Quarrel, p. 393 ; 88. Outwitting, Dismay, p. 393 ; 89. Panicky Commotion, Limbs of the Pause, p. 393 ; 90. Censure, Angry Words, p. 394 ; 91. Insolence, Placation, p. 394 ; 92. Assertion, Reverence, p. 394 ; 93. Rebuke, Lassitude p. 394 ; 94. Opposition, Altercation, p. 394 ; 95. Summing Up, Humiliation, p. 39 ; 965. Foresight, Limbs in the Conclusion, p. 395 ; 97. Junction, Awakening, p. 395 ; 98. Assembling, Ascertainment, p. 395 ; 99. Accusation, Confirmation pp. 395-396 ; 100. Gratification, Joy, p. 396 ; 101. Deliverence, Surprise, p. 396 ; 102. Clever Speech, Retrospect, p. 396 ; 103-105. Termination, Benediction, pp. 396-397 ; 106. Five Explanatory Devices, p. 397 ; 107-108. The Supporting Scene, p. 397 ; 109. The Intimating Speech, p. 397 ; 110-111. The Introductory Scene, p. 398 ; 112. The Transitional Scene, p. 398 ; 113. The Anticipatory Scene, p. 398 ; 114-130. An ideal Nāṭaka, pp. 398-400.

CHAPTER TWENTYTWO

THE STYLES, Pages 401-409

1-5. The origin of the Styles, p. 401 ; 6-11. The origin of the Verbal Style, pp. 401-402 ; 12. The origin of the Grand Style, p. 402 ; 13. The origin of the Graceful Style, p. 402 ; 14-16. The origin of the Energetic Style, p. 402 ; 17-25. The origin of the Nyāya, pp. 403-404 ; 26. The four varieties of the Verbal Style, p. 404 ; 27. The Laudation, p. 404 ; 28-29. The Introduction, p. 404 ; 30-31. The five varieties of the Introduction, p. 404 ; 32. Opening of the Story, p. 404 ; 33. Particular Presentation, p. 405 ; 34-37. Personal Business, p. 405 ; 38-40. The Grand Style, pp. 405-406 ; 41. The four varieties of the Grand Style, p. 406 ; 42. The Challenge, p. 406 ; 43. Change of Action, p. 406 ; 44. The Harsh Discourse, p. 406 ; 45-46. Breach of Alliance, p. 406 ; 47. The Graceful Style, p. 407 ; 48. The four varieties of the Graceful Style, p. 407 ; 49-50. The three kinds of Pleasantry, p. 407 ; 51. Beginning of Pleasantry, p. 407 ; 52. Unfoldment of Pleasantry, p. 407 ; 53-54. Covert

Pleasure, p. 408 ; 55-56. The Energetic Style, p. 408 ; 57. The four varieties of the Energetic Style, p. 408 ; 58. Compression, pp. 408-409 ; 49. Commotion, p. 409 ; 60. Raising the Theme, p. 409 ; 61-62. Conflict p. 409 ; 63-65. Styles according to Sentiments, p. 409 ;

CHAPTER TWENTYTHREE

THE COSTUMES AND MAKE-UP, Pages 410-439

1-3. Necessity of the Costumes and Make-up, 410 ; 4. Four kinds of Costumes and Make-up, p. 410. 5-8 The four kinds of model-work, pp. 410-411 ; 9. Decoration, p. 411 ; 10. Garlands, p. 411 ; 11. Four kinds of ornament, p. 411 ; 12. Piercing ornaments, Tied-up ornaments, p. 411 ; 13. Worn ornaments, Put-round ornaments, p. 412 ; 14. Ornaments according habitation and tribal origin, p. 412 ; 15. Ornaments for males : Head ornaments, Ear ornaments, p. 412 ; 16. Neck ornaments, Finger ornaments, pp. 412-413 ; 17. Ornaments of the forearm, Wrist ornaments, p. 413 ; 18. Ornaments above the elbow, Breast ornaments, p. 413 ; 19. Ornaments for the entire body, Waist ornaments, p. 413 ; 23-23. Ornaments for females : Head ornaments, p. 419 ; 23-25. Ear ornaments, pp. 414-415 ; 26-27. Neck ornaments, p. 415 ; 28. Breast ornaments, p. 415 ; 29. Arm ornaments, p. 416 ; 30. Finger ornaments, p. 416 ; 31-33. Hip ornaments, pp. 416-417 ; 34-36. Ornaments of the ankles, p. 417 ; 37-44. Other rules about ornaments, pp. 417-418 ; 45-51. Costume of celestial women, p. 418-419 ; 52. Siddha women, p. 419 ; 53. Gandharva women, p. 419 ; 54. Rākṣasa women, p. 419 ; 55. Goddesses, p. 419 ; 56-57. Monkey females, pp. 419-420 ; 58. Human females according to their countries, p. 420 ; 59. Women of Avanti and Gauḍa, p. 420 ; 60. Abhira women, p. 420 ; 61. Women of the North-east, p. 420 ; 62-63. Women of the South, p. 420 ; 64. Ornaments to be worn in the right place, pp. 420-421 ; 65-67. Dresses to suit the condition of females, p. 420 ; 68. Painting the limbs, p. 421 ; 69. The four original colours, p. 421 ; 70. The derivative colours, p. 421 ; 71-74. The primary derivative colours, pp. 421-422 ; 75-80. The secondary derivative colours, p. 422 ; 81. Living beings, p. 422 ; 82. Lifeless objects, p. 422 ; 83. Lifeless objects in human form, p. 422 ; 84. Painting the limbs, p. 422 ; 85-87. Colour for gods, p. 423 ; 88-89. Colours for demigods, 90-92. Colours for human beings in different regions, p. 424 ; 93. Colours for Bhūtas and Dwarfs, p. 424 ; 94-98. Colours of different peoples of Bhāratvarṣa, p. 424 ; 99-101. Colours of different tribes, p. 425 ; 102. Colours of different castes, p. 426 ; 103-109. Rules for the beard, p. 426-427 ; 110-127. Rules for different costumes, pp. 427-429 ; 128. Use of masks, p. 429 ; 129-139. Three kinds of crown, pp. 430-431 ; 139-145. Rules of different hairs, p. 431 ; 146-148. The Sa jīva, p. 432 ; 148-155. The use of weapons, pp. 432-433 ; 156-158. Use of other objects, p. 433 ; 159. Indra's Banner-staff, p. 433 ; 160-167. The Jarjara, pp. 433-434 ; 167-170.

The *Daṇḍakāṣṭha*, p. 434 ; 170-180. The making of masks, pp. 435-436 ; 180-187. Other accessories, p. 436 ; 187-198. The realistic and conventional objects, p. 437 ; 198-208. Making of ornaments, pp. 438-439 ; 208-211. Use of weapons on the stage, p. 439.

CHAPTER TWENTYFOUR

THE BASIC REPRESENTATION, Pages 440-482

1-2. Importance of Temperament p. 440 ; 3. The definition of Temperament, p. 440 ; 4-5. Feminine graces in the drama, pp. 440-441 ; 6. Physical graces of women, p. 441 ; 7. The origin of these graces, p. 441 ; 8. Feeling, p. 441 ; 9-10. Emotion, p. 441 ; 11. Passion, p. 441 ; 12-13. Natural Graces of women, p. 442 ; 14. Sportive Mimicry, p. 442 ; 15. Amorous Gestures, p. 442 ; 16. Dishabille, p. 442 ; 17. Confusion, p. 442 ; 18. Hysterical Mood, p. 443 ; 19. Manifestation of Affection, p. 443 ; 20. Pretended Anger, p. 443 ; 21. Affected Coldness, p. 443 ; 22. Lolling, p. 443. 23. Want of Response, p. 443 ; 24. Involuntary Graces of women, p. 444 ; 25. Beauty, p. 444 ; 26. Charm, Radiance, p. 444 ; 27. Delicacy p. 444 ; 28. Self-control, p. 444 ; 29-30. Courage, Dignity, p. 444-445 ; 31. Eight aspects of the male Temperament, p. 445 ; 32. Brilliant Character, p. 445 ; 33. Graceful Bearing, p. 445 ; 34. Self-possession, p. 445 ; 35. Tenacity, pp. 445-446 ; 36. Gravity, p. 446 ; 37. Sportiveness, p. 446 ; 38. Nobility, p. 446 ; 39. Spirit, p. 446 ; 40-41. Historionic Representation through the body, p. 446 ; 42. Word, p. 447 ; 43. *Sūcā*, p. 447 ; 44. *Ankura*, p. 447 ; 45. *Sākha*, p. 447 ; 46-47. *Nāṭyāyita*, p. 447 ; 48. *Nivṛtṭyāṅkura*, p. 448 ; 49-51. Twelve forms of the verbal Representation, p. 448 ; 52. Accosting, Prattling, p. 448 ; 53. Lament, Repeated Speaking, p. 448 ; 54. Dialogue, Change of Words, pp. 448-449 ; 55. Message, Agreement, p. 449 ; 56. Command, Pretext, p. 449 ; 57. Instruction, Statement, p. 449 ; 58-71. Another classification of the Verbal Representation, pp. 449-451 ; 72-73. The basic Representation, p. 451 ; 74-75. Regular Historionic Representation, p. 451 ; 76-77. Irregular Historionic Representation, p. 451 ; 78. *Lakṣaṇa* defined, p. 452 ; 79. Practice preferred to the *Sāstra*, p. 452 ; 80. Representation of the sensual perception, p. 452 ; 81. Sound, p. 452 ; 82. Touch, p. 452 ; 83. Form, p. 452 ; 84-85. Taste and Smell, pp. 452-453 ; 86. Importance of the mind, p. 453 ; 87. The three aspects of the of the mind p. 453 ; 88-89. The favourable mind, p. 453 ; 90. The unfavourable mind, p. 453 ; 91-92. The indifferent mind, p. 453 ; 93. The meaning of "personal", and the meaning of "external", pp. 453-454 ; 94-95. Desire, p. 454 ; 95-96. Love, p. 454 ; 97-98. Erotic Affair, p. 454 ; 99-100. Various types of women, p. 454 ; 101-102. The woman of divine type, pp. 454-455 ; 103-104. The woman of Asura type, p. 455 ; 105-106. The woman of Gandharva type, p. 455 ; 107-108. The woman of

Rākṣasa type, p. 455 ; 109-110. The woman of Nāga type, p. 455 ; 111-112. The woman of bird type, p. 456 ; 113-114. The woman of Piśāca type, p. 456 ; 115-116. The woman of Yakṣa type, p. 456 ; 117. The woman of tiger type, p. 456 ; 118-119. The human female, pp. 456-457 ; 120-121. The woman of monkey type, p. 459 ; 122-123. The woman of elephant type, p. 457 ; 124-125. The woman of deer type, p. 457 ; 126. The woman of fish type, p. 457 ; 127-128. The woman of camel type, p. 457 ; 129. The woman of Makara type, p. 458 ; 130-131. The woman of ass type, p. 458 ; 132-133. The woman of swine type, p. 488 ; 134-135. The woman of horse type, p. 458 ; 136-137. The woman of buffalo type, p. 458 ; 138-139. The woman of goat type, p. 458-459 ; 140-141. The woman of horse type, p. 459 ; 142-143. The woman cow type, p. 459 ; 144-147. Etiquette towards women, pp. 459 ; 147-149. Two classes of Etiquette, p. 460, 149-150. King's Etiquette towards women, p. 460 ; 150-155. The three classes of women ; pp. 460-461 ; 156-159. The beginning of love, p. 461 ; 160-162. Signs of love, p. 462 ; 163-165. Signs of a courtesan's love, p. 462 ; 166-167. Signs of love in a highborn lady, p. 462 ; 168. Signs of a maiden's love, p. 462 ; 169-171. Various stages of her love, 172-173. Longing, pp. 462-463. 174-175. Anxiety, p. 463 ; 176-177. Recollection, p. 463 ; 178-179. Enumeration of Merits, pp. 463-464 ; 180-181. Distress, p. 464 ; 182-183. Lamentation, p. 464 ; 184-185. Insanity, p. 464 ; 186-187. Sickness, pp. 464-465 ; 188-189. Stupor, p. 465 ; 190-191. Death, p. 465 ; 192. Manifestation of men's love, p. 465 ; 193. Characteristics of love, p. 465 ; 194-196. Women separated from the beloved one, pp. 465-466 ; 197. Relief in lovesickness, p. 466 ; 198-200. The female Messenger, p. 466 ; 201-207. The king's Etiquette to women, pp. 466-467 ; 208-209. Reasons for Conjugal Union, p. 467 ; 210-211. Eight kinds of Heroine, p. 267 ; 212. The Heroine dressed up for Union, p. 268 ; 214. The Heroine having her husband in subjection, p. 268 ; 215. The Heroine separated by quarrel, p. 268 ; 216. The enraged Heroine, p. 268 ; 217. The deceived Heroine, p. 268 ; 218. The Heroine with a sojourning husband, pp. 268-269 ; 219. The Heroine moving to her lover, p. 269 ; 220. Representation of the different Heroines, p. 469 ; 221-223. Enraged, deceived and quarreling Heroines, p. 469 ; 223. The Heroine with a sojourning husband, p. 469 ; 224. The Heroine having a husband in subjection, p. 469 ; 225. Different classes of Heroine moving to their lover, p. 469 ; 226. The courtesan, p. 470 ; 227. The woman of high family, p. 470 ; 228. The hand-maid, p. 470 ; 229-232. How to meet a sleeping lover, p. 470 ; 233-235. The Conjugal Union, p. 470 ; 236. Behaviour at the Conjugal Union, p. 470 ; 237-239. Preparation for the Conjugal Union, p. 471 ; 240-244. Acts prohibited on the stage, p. 472 ; 245-252. The Heroine in expectancy, p. 472 ; 253-257.

Personal omens, pp. 473-474 ; 258. Heroine's reception of the beloved, p. 474 ; 259-264. Receiving the guilty lover, pp. 474-475 ; 264. Causes of jealousy, p. 475 ; 265-266. Depression, p. 475 ; 267-268. Mixed Feeling, p. 475 ; 269-270. Disgust, pp. 475-476 ; 271-272. Anger, p. 476 ; 273-292. On treating a lover at fault, pp. 476-478 ; 293-298. Acts forbidden on the stage, pp. 478-479 ; 299-300. Endearing terms for the beloved p. 479 ; 301. Angry terms of address for the beloved, p. 479 ; 302-309. Endearing terms of address explained, pp. 479 ; 310-319. Angry terms of address explained, pp. 480-481 ; 320-328. Goddesses in human roles, pp. 481-482.

CHAPTER TWENTY FIVE

DEALINGS WITH COURTEZANS, Pages 483-492.

1-2. The definition of a Gallant, p. 483 ; 3-8. Qualities of a Gallant, pp. 483-484 ; 9-10. The female Messenger, p. 484 ; 11-12. Qualities of a Messenger, p. 484 ; 13-18. Functions of the female Messenger, p. 485 ; 19. The woman overcome with love, p. 485 ; 20-23. The attached woman, pp. 485-486 ; 24-27. The hostile woman, p. 486 ; 28-29. Winning back of women's heart, p. 486 ; 30-31. Causes of hostility, p. 486 ; 32-35. Acts winning women's heart, pp. 486-487 ; 36. The three types of woman, p. 487 ; 37-39. The superior woman, p. 487 ; 40-41. The middling woman, p. 487 ; 42. The inferior woman, p. 487 ; 43. The four stages of woman's youth, p. 488 ; 44. The primary youth, p. 488 ; 45. The secondary youth, p. 488 ; 46. The tertiary youth, p. 488 ; 47-48. The quarternary youth, p. 488 ; 49. Behaviour in the primary youth, p. 488 ; 50. Behaviour in the secondary youth, pp. 488-489 ; 51. Behaviour in the tertiary youth, p. 489 ; 52. Behaviour in the quarternary youth, p. 489 ; 53-54. Five types of man, p. 489 ; 55. The excellent man, p. 489 ; 56-57. The superior man, p. 489 ; 58-59. The middling man, p. 490 ; 60-61. The inferior man, p. 490 ; 62-63. The too old man, p. 490 ; 64-66. Psychological approach to women, pp. 490-491 ; 67. Conciliation, p. 491 ; 68. Gift. p. 491 ; 69. Dissention, Chastisement, p. 491 ; 70-72. Application of Conciliation, Gift etc. p. 491 ; 73. Reading a woman's heart from her behaviour, p. 491 ; 74-80. A courtesan's mercenary treatment of men, p. 492.

CHAPTER TWENTY SIX

SPECIAL REPRESENTATION, Pages 493-510

1. Special Representation, p. 493 ; 2-4. Day, night, season etc. 5. Objects on the ground, p. 493 ; 6. Moonlight, happiness and air etc, p. 494 ; 7. The sun, dust, smoke etc. 8. Midday sun, p. 494 ; 9. Pleasant objects, p. 494 ; 10. Sharp objects, p. 494 ; 11. Deep and exalted feeling, p. 494 ; 12. Necklace and flowers etc, p. 494 ; 13. The idea of entirety,

p. 494 ; 14. Audible or visible objects, p. 494 ; 15. Lighting, shooting stars etc. p. 495 ; 16. Repugnant objects, p. 495 ; 17. Hot wind and heat etc. p. 495 ; 18. Lions, bears etc. p. 494 ; 19. Worshipping superiors, p. 495 ; 20-22. Numerals, p. 495 ; 23. Umbrellas, Banners etc, p. 496 ; 24. Memory and meditation etc, p. 496 ; 25. Height, p. 496 ; 26. Past and Cessation etc, p. 496 ; 27. The autumn, p. 496 ; 28-30. The early winter, pp. 496-497 ; 31. The winter, p. 477 ; 32. The spring, p. 497 ; 33. The summer, p. 497 ; 34. The rains, p. 497 ; 35. The rainy night, p. 497 ; 36-37. Seasons in general, pp. 497-498 ; 38. The States, p. 498 ; 39-40. The Determinants, p. 498 ; 41-44. The consequents, pp. 498-499 ; 45-46. General directions for representation, p. 499 ; 47. Men's and women's efforts, p. 499 ; 48. Women's movements of limbs, p. 499 ; 49. Meaning of words, p. 499 ; 50-51. Joy, p. 499-500 ; 52. Anger, p. 500 ; 53-54. Jealous Anger of women, p. 500 ; 55. Men's sorrow, p. 500 ; 56-57. Women's sorrow, p. 500 ; 58. Men's fear, p. 500 ; 59-60. Women's fear, pp. 500-501 ; 61-64. Women's intoxicated condition, pp. 501 ; 65. Parrorts and Śārikās, p. 501. 66. Big birds, p. 501 ; 67. Asses and Camels, p. 501 ; 68-70. Bhūtas and Piśācas, p. 502 ; 70-71. Greeting an invisible person, p. 502 ; 71-73. Greeting gods superiors, p. 502 ; 73-74. Great crowd, and friends etc, p. 502 ; 74-75. Mountains and tall trees, p. 502 ; 75-78. Wide expanse of water, pp. 502-503 ; 78-79. A house and darkness etc, p. 503 ; 79-80. Lovesick, cursed and possessed persons, p. 503 ; 80-83. A swing, p. 503 ; 83-85. Speaking to the sky, pp. 503-504 ; 85-86. Speaking aside, Concealed speaking, p. 504 ; 87-88. Private Personal address, Thinking within oneself, p. 504 ; 90-91. Mentioning incidents that occurred already, pp. 504-505 ; 91-92. Representing Concealed speaking, p. 505 ; 92-94. Repetition of words, p. 505 ; 94-95. Suspension of Representation, p. 505 ; 95-97. Observing proper States, p. 505-506 ; 97-98. No movement in the state of sleeping. p. 506 ; 98-99. Declamation of a person in sleep, p. 506 ; 99-100. Declamation of old people, Children's words, p. 506 ; 100-102. Dying declamation, p. 506 ; 102-103. Representation of death, p. 507 ; 103-104. Death from disease, p. 507 ; 104-105. Death from drinking poison, p. 507 ; 105-107. The eight stages in death from poison, p. 507 ; 107-108. Weakness, p. 507 ; 108-109. Tremor, p. 507 ; 109-110. Burning sensation, p. 508 ; 110-111. Hiccough, p. 508 ; 111-112. Froth in the mouth, p. 508 ; 112-113. Breaking of the neck, Paralysis, p. 508 ; 113-115. Death, pp. 508-509 ; 115-118. General directions, p. 509 ; 118-122. The triple basis of drama, p. 509 ; 123-129. People supplying norm to the drama, pp. 509-510.

CHAPTER TWENTYSEVEN

SUCCESS IN DRAMATIC PRODUCTION, Pages 511-526

1. The Success in dramatic production, p. 511 ; 2. The two kinds

of Success, p. 511 ; 3. The human Success, p. 511 ; 4. The vocal Success, p. 511 ; 5-15. The physical Success, p. 511-513 ; 16-17. The divine Success, p. 513 ; 18-19. Three kinds of Blemishes, pp. 513-514 ; 20. Blemishes from gods, p. 514 ; 21-23. Blemishes from an enemy, p. 514 ; 23-27. Selfmade Blemishes, pp. 514-515 ; 28. Blemishes without remedy, p. 515 ; 29-36. Palpable sources of Blemishes, pp. 516-517 ; 37-39. Three grades of Blemishes, p. 517 ; 40. Wrong Benediction, p. 517 ; 41-43. Interpolation is a Blemish, pp. 517-518 ; 44-47. Limitation of human efforts in a play, pp. 518-519 ; 48-57. Spectators of a performance, pp. 519-520 ; 50. Various Classes of spectators, p. 520 ; 59-62. Disposition of different spectators, p. 520 ; 62-70. Assessors in a performance, pp. 520-521 ; 71. Controversy about a performance, p. 522 ; 72. Procedure in deciding controversies, p. 522 ; 73. Recording of Blemishes, p. 522 ; 74-75. Ideal position of Assessors in a performance p. 522 ; 76. Blemishes to be ignored, pp. 522-523 ; 77-82. Procedure of awarding the Banner, pp. 523-524 ; 83-84. Co-ordination, p. 524 ; 85-87. Charm of limbs, p. 524 ; 88-97. Suitable times for performance, p. 525 ; 98-99. Emergency performances are independent of time, p. 526 ; 100-101. Qualities of an Actor, p. 526 ; 102 An ideal performance, p. 526 ; 103. Brilliance of Pageant, p. 526 ; 104-105. The best performance, p. 526.

CHAPTER THIRTYFOUR

TYPE OF CHARACTERS, Pages 527-537

1. Three types of character in a drama, p. 527 ; 2-3. A superior male character, p. 527 ; 3-4. A middling male character, p. 527 ; 5-7. An inferior male character, p. 527 ; 8-10. A superior female character, pp. 527-528 ; 11. A middling female character, p. 528 ; 12. An inferior female character, p. 528 ; 13-14. A mixed character, p. 528 ; 15-20. The four types of the Hero, pp. 528-529 ; 20-23. The four types of Heroines, p. 529 ; 24-25. The two classes of employment for characters, pp. 529-530 ; 26-29. Female inmates of the harem, p. 530 ; 30-32. The chief queen, p. 530 ; 33-34. The other queens, p. 530 ; 35-36. High-born wives, p. 531 ; 37-39. Ordinary wives, p. 531 ; 40. Concubines, p. 531 ; 41-42. Women artistes, p. 531 ; 43-44. Actresses, pp. 531-532 ; 44-48. Dancers, p. 532 ; 48-49. Maids in constant attendance, p. 532 ; 49-51. Maids of special work, p. 532 ; 51-53. Maids in constant move, pp. 532-533 ; 53-54. Errand girls, p. 533 ; 54-55. Mahattaris, p. 533 ; 55-56. Pratihāries, p. 533 ; 56-57. Maidens, p. 533 ; 57-58. Old dames, p. 533 ; 58-60. Āyuktikās, pp. 533-534 ; 61-64. Qualities of women to be employed by the king, p. 534 ; 64-70. Other inmates of the harem, p. 534 ; 71. The Varṣadharas. p. 535 ; 72. The Nirmuṇḍas, p. 535 ; 73-74. The Kañeukins, p. 535 ; 76-77.

External persons, pp. 535-536 ; 78-82 The king, p. 536 ; 82-83. The leader of the army, p. 536 ; 84-85. Councillors, pp. 536-537 ; 85-87. Judges, p. 537 ; 87-90. Courtiers, p. 537.

CHAPTER THIRTYFIVE

DISTRIBUTION OF ROLES, Pages 538-552

1. Distribution of Roles, p. 538 ; 2-4. General principles of distribution, p. 538 ; 5-6. The role of gods, p. 538 ; 7-8. The role of Rākṣasas, the Dānavas etc, pp. 538-539 ; 9-11. The role of kings, p. 539 ; 12-13. The role of army leaders and councillors, p. 539 ; 14. The role of the Kuṇḍukin and the Śrotriya, p. 539 ; 15-17. The role of minor characters, p. 539-540 ; 19. The role of fatigued persons, The role of persons without disease, pp. 440 ; 19-21. Special cases of assigning roles, p. 540 ; 22-23. The roles of characters with extra or special limbs, pp. 540-541 ; 24. The first entry of a character. p. 541 ; 25-26. The result of proper impersonation, p. 541 ; 27. The psychological preparation for impersonation, p. 541 ; 28. The three kinds of impersonation, p. 541 ; 29. The natural impersonation, p. 541 ; 30. The unnatural impersonation, p. 541 ; 31-33. Imitative representation. p. 542 ; 33-36. Suitability of women in some roles, 542 ; 37. Training for women in different roles, p. 524 ; 38. Result of proper assignment of roles, pp 542-543 ; 39-41. Result of employing women for acting, p. 543 ; 42. The two types of dramatic production, p. 543 ; 43-47. The delicate type of production, pp. 543-544 ; 48-53. The violent type of production, pp. 544-545 ; 53-59. The typical impersonation of a king; p 545 ; 59-62. Impersonation of the attendants of gods, p. 546 ; 62-68. The characteristics of a Director, pp. 546-547 ; 69-71. The natural qualities of a Director, p. 547 ; 71-72. Characteristics of an Assistant to the Director, p. 547 ; 72-73. Characteristics of an Actor, p. 547 ; 73-74. Characteristics of the Parasite, p. 547 ; 75. Characteristics of the Śakara, pp. 547-548 ; 76. Characteristics of the Jester, p. 548 ; 77. Characteristics of the servant, p. 548 ; 78-81. Characteristics of the courtesan, p. 548 ; 81-83. Characteristics of the typical Heroine, p. 548 ; 83-85. Women disqualified to be Heroines, p. 549 ; 85-89. Members of the typical theatrical party, p. 549 ; 89-91. Characteristics of the Jester, pp. 549-550 ; 91-92. Characteristics of the master musician, p. 550 ; 92-93. Meaning of the word Naṭa, p. 550 ; 93-95. Benediction defined. p. 550 ; 96-97. Characteristics of the playwright, p. 551 ; 97-98. Characteristics of the Actor, p. 551 ; 98-99. Characteristics of the actress, p. 551 ; 99-100. The maker of headgears, p. 551 ; 100-101. The maker of ornaments, p. 551 ; 101-102. The maker of garlands, the costumer, the painter and the dyer, p. 551 ; 103-104. The Craftsmen, the Kuśilavas, p. 552 ; 104-135. The other members of the party, p. 552.

CHAPTER THIRTYSIX

THE DESCENT OF DRAMA ON THE EARTH, Pages 553-661

1-9. Sages question, pp. 553-554 ; 10. Bharata's reply, pp. 554 ; 11-23. The Preliminaries and their uses, pp. 554-555 ; 24-26. The ablution of the Director on the stage, p. 555 ; 27-29. Bharata's sons offended the sages by caricature, p. 556 ; 30-36. The sages curse Bharata's sons. pp. 556-557 ; 37-38. Gods intercede in favour of Bharata's sons, p. 557 ; 39-40. Bharata's sons approach their father, p. 557 ; 41-45. Bharata pacifies them, pp. 557-558 ; 46-49. Nahuṣa invites divine artistes to the earth, p. 558 ; 50-51. Gods reject the request, p. 558 ; 52-53. Nahuṣa approaches Bharata, p. 559 ; 54-57. Urvaśi and the mundane drama, p. 559 ; 58-61. Bharata grants the request and sends his sons to the earth, pp. 559-560 ; 62-63. Kohala is the successor of Bharata, p. 560 ; 65-68. Bharata's sons come down to the earth, p. 560 ; 62-70. Kohala and his associates, p. 560 ; 71-73. Value of the Nāṭyaśāstra, p. 561 ; 74-77. Value of the dramatic show, and the final Benediction, p. 561.

ADDITIONS AND CORRECTIONS

...

p. 562

INTRODUCTION

I. The Present Work

1. General History of the Study

Since the West came to know of the Sanskrit literature through William Jones's translation of the *Śakuntalā*¹, the nature and origin of the ancient Indian theatre have always interested scholars, especially the Sanskritists, all over the world. H. H. Wilson who published in 1826 the first volume of his famous work on the subject² deplored that the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, mentioned and quoted in several commentaries and other works, had been lost for ever³. F. Hall who published in 1865 his edition of the *Daśarūpa*⁴, a medieval work on the Hindu dramaturgy, did not see any Ms. of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* till his work had greatly advanced⁵. And for the time being he printed the relevant chapters of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* as an appendix to his *Daśarūpa*. Later on he undertook to critically edit the Ms. of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* he acquired; but this venture was subsequently given up, due perhaps to an insufficiency of materials which consisted of one unique Ms. full of numerous *lacunae*.⁶ But even if the work could not be brought out by Hall, his very important discovery soon helped others to trace similar Mss. elsewhere. And in 1874 Heymann, a German scholar, published on the basis of Mss. discovered up till that date a valuable article⁷ on the contents of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. This seems to have been instrumental in attracting competent scholars to the study of this very important text. The French Sanskritist P. Regnaud published in 1880 chapter XVII⁸ and in 1884 chapter XV (in part) and the chapter XVI⁹ of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. This was soon followed by his publication of chapters VI and VII in 1884.¹⁰ And J. Grosset another French scholar and a pupil of Regnaud, published later on (in 1888) chapter XXVIII¹¹ of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* which treated of the general theory of Hindu music.

¹ *Sacontala*, or the Fatal Ring. Translated from the original Sanskrit and Prakrit, Calcutta 1789.

² H. H. Wilson, *Select Specimens of the Theatre of the Hindus* (3 vols), Calcutta, 1826-1827. ³ Wilson, p. 37. Grosset, Introduction, p. iij.

⁴ *The Daśarūpa* by Dhanañjaya (*Bibliotheca Indica*), Calcutta, 1861-1865.

⁵ Grosset, Introduction, v. iij. ⁶ See note 5 above.

⁷ Ueber Bharata's *Natyasastram* in *Nachrichten von der Koeniglichen Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften*, Goettingen 1874, pp. 86 ff. *Ref.* Grosset, Introduction p. x; *Id.* pp. 2-3.

⁸ Le dix-septieme chapitre du *Bharatiya-natyasastra*. *Annales du Musée Guimet*; Tome, I, 1880, pp. 85 ff.

⁹ La metrique de Bharata, texte Sanscrit de deux chapitres du *Natyasastra* public pour premier fois et suivi d'une interpretation francaise, *Annales du Musée Guimet*, Tome, II, 1884, pp. 65 ff. ¹⁰ *Rhetorique sanscrite*, Paris, 1814.

¹¹ Contribution a l'étude de la musique hindou, Lyons, 1888.

But the different chapters of the work and studies on them, which were published up till 1898, though very helpful for the understanding of some aspects of the ancient Indian dramatic works cannot be said to have thrown any considerable light on the exact nature of the ancient Hindu plays, especially the manner of their production on the stage. Sylvain Lévi's *Théâtre indien* (1890) in which he discussed comprehensively the contribution of his predecessors in the field and added to it greatly by his own researches, made unfortunately no great progress in this specific direction. Though he had access to three more or less complete Mss. of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, Lévi does not seem to have made any serious attempt to make a close study of the entire work except its chapters XVII-XX (XVIII-XXII of our text) and XXXIV. The reason for his relative indifference to the contents of the major portion (nearly nine-tenths) of the work, seem to be principally the corrupt nature of his Ms. materials. Like his predecessors, Lévi paid greater attention to the study of the literary form of the ancient Hindu plays with the difference that he utilised for the first time the relevant chapters of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*,¹² to check the accuracy of the statements of later writers on the subject like Dhanañjaya¹³ and Viśvanātha¹⁴ who professed their dependence on the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. But whatever may be the drawback of Lévi's magnificent work, it did an excellent service to the history of ancient Indian drama by focussing the attention of scholars on the great importance of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. Almost simultaneously two Sanskritists in India as well as one in the West were planning its publication. In 1894 Pandits Shivadatta and Kashinath Pandurang Parab published from Bombay the original Sanskrit text of the work.¹⁵ This was followed in 1898 by J. Grosset's¹⁶ critical edition of its chapters I-XIV based on all the Mss. available up till that date.

Though nearly half a century has passed after the publication of Grosset's incomplete edition of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, it still remains one of the best specimens of modern Western scholarship, and though in the light of the new materials available, it is possible now-a-days to improve upon his readings in a few places, Grosset's work will surely remain for a long time a landmark in the history of the study of this important text. It is a pity that this very excellent work remains unfinished. But a fact equally deplorable is that it failed to attract sufficient attention of scholars

¹² Chapters XVII-XX (XVIII-XXII of our text).

¹³ The author of the *Dasarupa*. See above note 4.

¹⁴ The author of the *Sahityadarpana*. See below.

¹⁵ *Śrī Bhāratamuni-pranītam, Nāṭyaśāstram*, (*Kāyamaṇi*, 42) Bombay, 1894.

¹⁶ *Traité du Bharata sur le Théâtre. Texte sanscrit, Edition critique. Tome I. Partie, I. (Annales de l'Université de Lyons, Fasc. 40, 1898)*

interested in the subject. Incomplete though it was, it nevertheless contained a good portion of the rules regarding the presentation of plays on the stage, and included valuable data on the origin and nature of the ancient Indian drama, but no one seems to have subjected it to the searching study it deserved. Whoever wrote on Hindu plays after Lévi depended more on his work than on the Nāṭyaśāstra itself, even when this was available (at least in a substantial part) in a critical edition. It may very legitimately be assumed that the reasons which conspired to render the Nāṭyaśāstra rather unattractive included among other things, the difficulty of this text which was not yet illuminated by a commentary.

Discovery in the early years of the present century of a major portion of a commentary of the Nāṭyaśāstra by the Kashmirian Abhinavagupta¹⁷ seemed to give, however, a new impetus to the study of the work. And it appeared for the time being that the Nāṭyaśāstra would yield more secrets treasured in the body of its difficult text. But the first volume of the Baroda edition of the work (ch. I-VII)¹⁸ including Abhinava's commentary, disillusioned the expectant scholars. Apart from the question of the merit of this commentary and its relation to the available versions of the Nāṭyaśāstra, it suffered from a very faulty transmission of the text. Not only did it contain numerous *lacunae*, but quite a number of its passages were not liable to any definite interpretation due to their obviously vitiated nature. Of this latter condition the learned editor of the commentary says, 'the originals are so incorrect that a scholar friend of mine is probably justified in saying that even if Abhinavagupta descended from the Heaven and seen the Mss. he would not easily restore his original reading. It is in fact an impenetrable jungle through which a rough path now has been traced'. The textual condition of Abhinava's commentary on chapters VIII-XVIII (VIII-XX of our text) published in 1934¹⁹ was not appreciably better.

But whatever may be the real value of the commentary, the two volumes of the Nāṭyaśāstra published from Baroda, which were avowedly to give the text supposed to have been taken by Abhinava as the basis of his work, presented also considerable new and valuable materials in the shape of variant readings collated from numerous Mss. of the text as well as from the commentary. These sometimes throw new light on the contents of Nāṭyaśāstra. A study of these together with a new and more or

¹⁷ Dr. S. K. De seems to be the first in announcing the existence of a more or less complete Ms. of Abhinava's commentary, and in recommending its publication. See *Skt. Poetics*, Vol I. pp. 120-121.

¹⁸ *Nāṭyaśāstra with the commentary of Abhinavagupta*. Edited with a preface, Appendix and Index by Ramakrishna Kavi. Vol I, Baroda 1928.

¹⁹ *Nāṭyaśāstra with the commentary of Abhinavagupta*. Edited with an Introduction and Index by M. Ramakrishna Kavi. Vol. II, Baroda, 1934.

less complete (though uncritical) text of the work published from Benares in 1929²⁰ would, it is hoped, be considered a desideratum by persons interested in the ancient Indian drama. The present work has been the result of such a study, and in it has been given for the first time a complete annotated translation of the major portion of the Nāṭyaśāstra based on a text reconstructed by the author.²¹

2. The Basic Text

The text of the Nāṭyaśāstra as we have seen is not available in a complete critical edition, and Joanny Grosset's text (Paris-Lyons, 1898) does not go beyond ch. XIV. Hence the translator had to prepare a critical edition of the remaining chapters before taking up the translation.²² For this he depended principally upon Ramakrishna Kavi's incomplete edition (Baroda, 1926, 1934) running up to ch. XVIII (our XX) and including Abhinava's commentary, as well as the Nirṇayasāgar and Chowkhamba editions (the first, Bombay 1894, and the second, Benares, 1929). As the text of the Nāṭyaśāstra has been available in two distinct recensions, selection of readings involved some difficulty. After the most careful consideration, the translator has thought it prudent to adopt readings from both the recensions, whenever such was felt necessary from the context or for the sake of coherence, and these have been mentioned in the footnotes. But no serious objection may be made against this rather unorthodox procedure, for A. A. Macdonell in his critical text of the Bṛhaddevatā (Cambridge, Mass. 1904) has actually worked in this manner, and J. Grosset too in his edition 'does not give unqualified preference to any recension and confesses that due to conditions peculiar to the Nāṭyaśāstra his text has 'un caractere largement eclectique' (Introduction, p. xxv) and he further says 'nous n'avions pas l'ambition chimérique de tendre à la reconstitution du Bharata primitif.....(*loc. cit.*). Conditions do not seem to have changed much since then.

²⁰ Sri-Bharātmuni-pranitam Nāṭyaśāstram. (Kashi-Sanskrit Series), Benares, 1929.

²¹ This edition will be published later on. The following chapters of the N.S. have been translated into French: ch XIV and XV (our XV and XVI) *Vagabhinaya* by P. Regnaud in his *Métrie du Bharata*; see note 8 above, ch. XVII (our XVIII) *Ihasavidhana* by Luigia Nitti-Dolei in her *Les Grammairiens Prakrit*. This has been partially (1-24) translated into English by the present writer in his *Date of the Bharata-Nāṭyaśāstra*, See JDL, 1930, pp. 73f. Chapter XXVIII by J. Grosset in his *Contribution à l'étude de la musique hindou*; see note 10 above. Besides these, ch. XXVIII by B. Broder in his *Grund-elemente der alt-indischen Musik nach dem Bharatiya-nāṭyaśāstra*. Bonn. 1922, and ch. IV by B. V. N. Naidu, P. S. Naidu and O. V. R. Pantlu in the *Tandavalakṣaṇam*, Madras, 1936 and chapters I-III translated into Bengali by the late Pandit Asokenath Bhattacharyya in the *Vasumatī*, 1352 B.S.

3. Translation

Though the translation has been made literal as far as possible except that the stock words and phrases introduced to fill up incomplete lines have been mostly omitted, it has been found necessary to add a number of of explanatory words [enclosed in rectangular brackets] in order to bring out properly the exact meaning of the condensed Sanskrit original. Technical terms have often been repeated (within curved brackets) in the translation in their basic form, especially where they are explained or defined. In cases where the technical terms could not be literally rendered into English they were treated in two different ways : (1) they were given in romanised form with initial capital letters e.g. Bhāṇa and Vithi (XX. 107-108, 112-113), Nyāya (XXII. 17-18) etc. (2) Words given as translation have been adopted with a view to indicating as far as possible the exact significance of the original, e.g. State (*bhāva*) Sentiment (*rasa*), VI. 33-34. Discovery (*prāpti*), Persuasion (*siddhi*), Parallelism (*udāharaṇa*) (XVII. 1), Prominant Point (*bindu*), Plot (*vastu*) (XX.15) etc : Lest these should be taken in their usual English sense they are distinguished by initial capital letters. Constantly occurring optative verbal forms have been mostly ignored. Such verbs as *kuryāt* and *bhavet* etc, have frequently been rendered by simple 'is' or a similar indicative form. And nouns used in singular number for the sake of metre have been silently rendered by those in plural number and *vice versa*, when such was considered necessary from the context.

4. Notes to the Translation

Notes added to this volumes fall generally into three categories. (a) *Text-critical*. As the basic text is not going to be published immediately, it has been considered necessary to record variant readings. For obvious reasons variants which in the author's opinion are less important have not been generally recorded. (b) *Explanatory*. These include among other things references to different works on allied subjects and occasional short extracts from the same. Abhinavagupta's commentary naturally occupies a prominent place among such works, and it has very often been quoted and referred to. But this does not mean that the worth of this work should be unduly exaggerated.¹ (c) *Materials for Comparative Study*. A very old text like the Nāṭyaśāstra not illuminated by anything like a complete and lucid commentary, should naturally be studied in comparison with works treating similar topics directly or indirectly. Hence such materials have been carefully collated as far as the resources at the author's disposal permitted.

1. See M. Ghosh, "The N.S. and the Abhinavabharati" in IHQ vol. X, 1934, pp. 161ff.

But even when supplied with these notes, readers of this translation may have some difficulty in reconstructing from the work written in *a diffuse manner the picture of the ancient Indian drama in its theatrical as well as literary form, as it existed in the hoary antiquity. To give them some help the theory and practice of the ancient Hindu drama has been briefly discussed below together with other relevant matters.*

II. The Ancient Indian Theory of Drama

1. The Meaning of Nāṭya

The word "Nāṭya" has often been translated as 'drama' and the plays of ancient India have indeed some points of similarity with those of the Greeks. But on a closer examination of the technique of their production as described in the Nāṭyaśāstra, the Hindu dramas represented by the available specimens, will appear to be considerably different. Unless this important fact is borne in mind any discussion on the subject is liable to create a wrong impression. As early as 1890 Sylvain Lévi (pp. 423-424) noticed that Indian Nāṭya differed from the Greek drama from which the Westerners derived their early conception of the art. Though it is not possible to agree with Lévi on all points about the various aspects of this difference and the causes which he attributed to them, no one can possibly have any serious objection against his finding that, "Le *nāṭaka* par se nature autant que par son nom se rapproche de la danse scénique ; le *drame* est l'action même" (*loc. cit.*). Lévi however did not for reasons stated above fully utilize in this connection the Nāṭyaśāstra which contains ample materials for clarifying his conclusion.

The essential nature of the (Nāṭya) derived from its etymology cannot by any means be called fanciful. For in the Harivaṃśa¹ (c. 200 A.C) we meet with an expression like *nāṭakam nanṛtuḥ* (they danced a play) and the Karpūramāñjarī² (c. 1000 A.C.) has an expression like *saṭṭaam naccidavvam* (a Saṭṭaka is to be danced or acted).

The terms like *rūpaka* or *rūpa* (representation) and *prekṣā* (spectacle), all denoting dramatic works, also characterise the Hindu dramas and show their difference from the drama of the Greeks who laid emphasis on action and not on the spectacle. Of the six parts of the tragedy, the most typical of the Greek dramatic productions, Aristotle puts emphasis on the fable or the plot and considers decoration to be unimportant. On this point the philosopher says :

"Terror and pity may be raised by decoration—the mere spectacle; but they may also arise from the circumstance of the action itself, which is far

¹ Visṇuparvan, Ch. 93. Sl. 28,

² Ed. M. Ghosh, p. 80.

preferable and shows a superior poet, For the fable should be so constructed that without the assistance of the sight its incidents may excite horror and commiseration in those who hear them only; * * * * *
 But to produce this effect by means of the decoration discovers want of art in the poet; who must also be supplied with an expensive apparatus" (II. XIII).³

But in case of the Hindu dramas the decoration (i. e. the costumes and make-up) mostly plays an important part. Equally with five other elements such as gestures and postures (*āṅgika*), words (*vācika*), the representation of the Temperament (*satva*), it gives the Nāṭya its characteristic form. But in the theatre of the Greeks, it was not the case. In the performance of the tragedies, for example, they did not care much for the spectacle, if the declamation was properly made. For Aristotle himself says that, "the power of tragedy is felt without representation and actors" (II. III).⁴

Another peculiarity of the Hindu dramas was their general dependence on dance (*nṛtya*), song (*gita*), and instrumental music (*vādya*). Though the chorus of the Greek tragedy introduced in it some sort of dance and songs, the function of these elements seem to have been considerably different in the Hindu drama. The ancient Indian play was produced through words, gestures, postures, costumes, make-up, songs and dances of actors, and the instrumental music was played during the performance whenever necessary. But these different elements did not play an equal part in all the plays or different types of play. According as the emphasis was to be put on words, music, or dance, a play or its individual part partook of the nature of what the moderns would call 'drama', 'opera', 'ballet' or 'dramatic spectacle'.⁵ Due to this nature the Hindu dramas which connected themselves in many ways with song, dance and instrumental music, had a literary form which was to some extent different from that of the ancient Greeks. But it was not so much due to this literary form as to the technique of their production on the stage that the Hindu dramas received their special character.

After forming a general idea of this Nāṭya, from the various terms used to denote it, one should enquire what the ancient Indian theorists exactly meant by the term (Nāṭya) or what they regarded as being the essence of the dramatic art as opposed to the arts of poetry, fiction or painting. To satisfy, our curiosity on this point the Nāṭyaśāstra gives us the following passage which may pass for a definition of the Nāṭya.

"A mimicry of the exploits of gods, the Asuras, kings as well as of householders in this world, is called drama" (I. 120).

³ Poetics (Everymans Library), p. 27. ⁴ *Ibid.* p. 17.

⁵ H.H. Wilson, On the Dramatic System of the Hindus, Calcutta, 1827, p. 16, 20.

This description seems to fall in a line with Cicero's view that "drama is a copy of life, a mirror of custom, a reflection of truth". In this statement Cicero evidently takes his cue from Aristotle who considered that the art in general consisted of imitation (*mimesis*). But this does not help us very much to ascertain the nature of drama as an example of 'imitation'. For the Greek philosopher nowhere defines this very essentially important term. So when he declares that "epic poetry, tragedy, comedy, dythrambics as also for the most part the music of the flute and of the lyre all these are in the most general view of them imitations"⁶, one can at best guess how drama imitates. There seems to be no such difficulty about understanding the view of the Hindu theorists. The Nāṭyaśāstra lays down very elaborate rules as to how the drama is to make mimicry of the exploits of men and their divine or semi-divine counterparts. It is due to rules of representation that the Hindu drama has been called by the later theorists 'a poem to be seen' (SD. 270-271). By this term epic or narrative poetry and fiction etc. are at once distinguished from drama which is preminently a spectacle including a mimicry of activities of mortals, gods or demigods. It may now be asked what exactly was meant by the word mimicry (*anukarṇa*) used by the Indian theorists. Did this mean a perfect reproduction of the reality? For an answer to this question we are to look into the conventions of the Hindu drama.

2. The Dramatic Conventions

That the Hindu theorists turned their attention very early to the problem of dramatic representation and enquired about the exact place of realism or its absence in connection with the production of a play, is to be seen clearly from their very sensible division of the technical practice into "realistic" (*lokadharmī*, lit. popular) and "conventional" (*nāṭyadharmī*, lit. theatrical). By the realistic practice, the Nāṭyaśāstra (XIV. 62-76 ; XXIII. 187-188) means the reproduction of the natural behaviour of men and women on the stage as well as the cases of other natural presentation. But from the very elaborate treatment of the various conventions regarding the use of dance, songs, gestures and speeches etc. by different characters it is obvious that the tradition of the ancient Hindu theatre recognised very early the simple truth that the real art to deserve the name, is bound to allow to itself a certain degree of artificiality which receives its recognition through many conventions. One very patent example of this conventional practice on the stage, is speeches uttered 'aside' or as soliloquy. The advocates of extreme realism may find fault with these as unnatural, and the accusation cannot be denied, but on closer examination of circumstances connected with the construction of a play as well as its production on the stage, it will be found that if the spectators are to demand realism very

rigidly then no theatrical performance of any value, may be possible. Neither the Hindus nor the Greeks ran after this kind of absurdity. Critics of ancient Indian dramas will do well to remember this and to take care to understand the scope and necessity of various conventions relating to the production, so that they may better appreciate the art of great play-wrights like Bhāsa, Kālidāsa, Śūdraka and Viśākhadatta.

3. Time and place in Drama

Hindu playwrights, unlike the majority of Greek tragedians, did never make any attempt to restrict the fictional action to a length of time roughly similar to that taken up by the production of a drama on the stage. In developing plots they had not much restriction on the length of time, provided that individual Acts were to include incidents that could take place in course of a single day, and nothing could be put in there to interrupt the routine duties such as saying prayers or taking meals (XX. 23), and the lapse of time between two Acts, which might be a month or a year (but never more than a year)¹ was to be indicated by an Introductory Scene (*pravēśaka*) preceding the last one (XX. 27-28).

Similarly there was almost no restriction about the locality to which individual Actors, and gods in their human roles were to be assigned, except that the human characters were always to be placed in India i.e. Bhāratavarṣa (XX. 97).

4. The Unity of Impression

In spite of having no rules restricting the time and place relating to different incidents included in the plot of a drama, the playwright had to be careful about the unity of impression which it was calculated to produce. For this purpose the Nāṭyaśāstra seems to have the following devices :

The Germ (*bija*) of the play as well as its Prominent Point (*bindu*) was always to relate to every Act of the play and the Hero was sometimes to appear in every Act or to be mentioned there (XX. 15, 30).

An Act was not to present too many incidents (XX.24), and such subsidiary events as might affect the unity of impression on their being directly presented, were merely to be reported in an Introductory Scene. Besides this, short Explanatory Scenes were sometimes put in before an Act to clarify the events occurring in it (XXI. 106-111. All these, not only helped the play to produce an unity of impression but also imparted to its plot a rapidity of movement which is essential for any kind of successful dramatic presentation.

5. Criticism of Drama

Indians from very early times considered plays to be essentially 'spectacle' (*prakāśa*) or 'things' to be visualised ; hence persons attending

¹ Bhavabhūti however violates the rule in his Uttara. in letting many years pass between Acts I and II.

the performance of a play were always referred to (XXVII. 48-57) as 'spectators' or 'observers' (*prekṣaka*)⁸ and never as audience (*śrotr*), although there was always the speech element in it, which was a thing to be heard. This disposes of the question of judging the value of a drama except in connection with its production on the stage. This importance of the representational aspect of a play has possibly behind it an historical reason. Though in historical times we find written dramas produced on the stage, this was probably not the case in very early times, and the dialogues which contribute an important part of the drama were often improvised on the stage by the actors⁹, and this practice seems to have continued in certain classes of folk-plays till the late mediæval times¹⁰. Hence the drama naturally continued to be looked upon by Indians as spectacles even after great playwright creators like Bhāsa, Kālidāsa, Śūdraka, and Bhavabhūti had written their dramas which in spite of their traditional form were literary master-pieces.

Now, dramas being essentially things to be visualised, their judgement should properly rest with the people called upon to witness them. This was not only the ancient Hindu view, even the modern producers, in spite of their enlisting the service of professional (dramatic) critics, depend actually on the opinion of the common people who attend their performance.

The judgement of the drama which is to depend on spectators has been clearly explained in the theory of the Success discussed in the Nāṭya-śāstra (XXVII). In this connection one must remember the medley of persons who usually assemble to witness a dramatic performance and what varying tastes and inclinations they might possess. For, this may give us some guidance as to what value should be put on their judgement which appear to have no chance of unity. In laying down the characteristics of a drama the Nāṭyaśāstra has the following: "This (the Nāṭya) teaches duty to those bent on doing their duty, love to those who are eager for its fulfilment, and it chastises those who are ill-bred or unruly, promotes self-restraint in those who are disciplined, gives courage to cowards, energy to heroic persons, enlightens men of poor intellect and gives wisdom to the learned. This gives diversion to kings, firmness [of mind] to persons afflicted with sorrow, and [hints of acquiring] wealth to those who are for earning it, and it brings composure to persons agitated in mind. The drama as I

⁸ *Prekṣa* occurring in N.S. III. 99. seems to be the same as 'pekṣa' mentioned in Pall *Brahmajālasutta* See Levi. II. p. 54.

⁹ Winternitz, Vol. I. pp. 101-102.

¹⁰ The *Kṛṣṇakirtana*, a collection of Middle Bengali songs on *Kṛṣṇa* and *Radhā's* love-affairs, seems to have been the musical framework of a drama. We saw in our early boyhood that extemporised dialogues were a special feature of the old type Bengali *Yatras*. These have totally disappeared now under the influence of modern theatre which depend on thoroughly written plays.

have devised, is a mimicry of actions and conducts of people, which is rich in various emotions and which depicts different situations. This will relate to actions of men good, bad and indifferent, and will give courage, amusement and happiness as well as counsel to them all" (I.108-112).

It may be objected against the foregoing passage that no one play can possibly please all the different types of people. But, to take this view of a dramatic performance, is to deny its principal character as a social amusement. For, the love of spectacle is inherent in all normal people and this being so, every one will enjoy a play whatever be its theme, unless it is to contain anything which is anti-social in character. The remarks of the author of the Nāṭyaśāstra quoted above on the varied profits the spectators will reap from witnessing a performance, merely shows in what diverse ways different types of plays have their special appeal to the multitudinous spectators. And his very detailed treatment of this point, is for the sake of suggesting what various aspects a drama or its performance may have for the spectators. This many-sidedness of an ideal drama has been very aptly summed up by Kālidāsa who says, "The drama, is to provide satisfaction in one [place] to people who may differ a great deal as regards their tastes" (Mālavī. I.4). It is by way of exemplifying the tastes of such persons of different category that the Nāṭyaśāstra says :

"Young people are pleased to see [the presentation of] love, the learned a reference to some [religious or philosophical] doctrine, the seekers after money topics of wealth, and the passionless in topics of liberation.

Heroic persons are always pleased in the Odious and the Terrible Sentiments, personal combats and battles, and the old people in Purāṇic legends, and tales of virtue. And common women, children and uncultured persons are always delighted with the Comic Sentiment and remarkable Costumes and Make-up" (XXV. 59-61).

These varying tastes of individual spectators were taken into consideration by the author of the Nāṭyaśāstra when he formulated his theory of the Success. The Success in dramatic performance was in his opinion of two kinds, divine (*daiviki*) and human (*mānuṣi*) (XXVII. 2). Of these two, the divine Success seems to be related to the deeper aspects of a play and came from spectators of a superior order i.e. persons possessed of culture and education (XXVII. 16-17), and the human Success related to its superficial aspects and came from the average spectators who were ordinary human beings. It is from these latter, who are liable to give expression to their enjoyment or disapproval in the clearest and the most energetic manner, that tumultuous applause and similar other acts proceeded (XXVII. 3, 8-18, 13-14), while the spectators of the superior order gave their appreciation of the deeper and the more subtle aspects of a play (XXVII. 5, 6, 12, 16-17). During the medieval times the approval of the spectators of the latter kind came to be considered appreciation *par*

excellence and pre-occupied the experts or learned critics. They analysed its process in every detail with the greatest possible care in their zealous adherence of Bharata's theory of Sentiment (*rasa*) built upon what may be called a psychological basis.

But in spite of this later development of this aspect of dramatic criticism it never became the preserve of specialists or scholars. Critics never forgot that the drama was basically a social amusement and as such depended a great deal for its success on the average spectator. Even the Nāṭyaśāstra has more than once very clearly said that the ultimate court of appeal concerning the dramatic practice was the people (XX. 125-126). Hence a fixed set of rules, be it of the Nāṭyaveda or the Nāṭyaśāstra was never considered enough for regulating the criticism of a performance. This seems to be the reason why special Assessors appointed to judge the different kinds of action occurring in a play (XXVI. 65-69), decided in co-operation with the select spectators, who among the contestants deserved to be rewarded.

6. The Four Aspects of Drama.

Though the Hindu plays are usually referred to as 'drama' all the ten varieties of play (*rūpa*) described in the Nāṭyaśāstra are not strictly speaking dramas in the modern sense. Due to the peculiar technique of their construction and production they would partially at least partake of the nature of pure drama, opera, ballet or merely dramatic spectacle. To understand this technique one must have knowledge of the Styles (*vr̥tti*) of dramatic production described in the Nāṭyaśāstra (XXII). These being four in number are as follows : the Verbal (*bhāratī*), the Grand (*sālvatī*), the Energetic (*ārabhatī*) and the Graceful (*kaiśikī*). The theatrical presentation which is characterised by a preponderating use of speech (in Skt.) and in which male characters are exclusively to be employed, is said to be in the Verbal Style (XXII. 25ff.). This is applicable mainly in the evocation of the Pathetic and the Marvellous Sentiments. The presentation which depends for its effect on various gestures and speeches, display of strength as well as acts showing the rise of the spirits, is considered to be in the Grand Style (XXII. 38 ff). This is applicable to the Heroic, the Marvellous and the Furious Sentiments. The Style which includes the presentation of a bold person speaking many words, practising deception, falsehood and bragging and of falling down, jumping, crossing over, doing deeds of magic and conjuration etc, is called the Energetic one. This is applicable to the Terrible, the Odious and the Furious Sentiments (XXII. 55ff). The presentation which is specially interesting on account of charming costumes worn mostly by female characters and in which many kinds of dancing and singing are included, and the themes acted relate to the practice of love and its

enjoyment, is said to constitute the Graceful Style (XXII. 47ff). It is proper to the Erotic and the Comic Sentiments.

From a careful examination of the foregoing descriptions one will see that the Styles, excepting the Graceful, are not mutually quite exclusive in their application. On analysing the description of different types of play given in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* it will be found that the *Nāṭaka*, the *Prakarāṇa*, the *Samavakāra* and the *Ihāmṛga* may include all the Styles in their presentation, while the *Ḍima*, the *Vyāyoga*, the *Prahasana*, the *Utsrṣṭikāṅka*, the *Bhāṇa* and the *Vithī*, only some of these (XX. 88, 96). Hence one may call into question the soundness of the fourfold theoretical division of the Styles of presentation. But logically defective though this division may appear, it helps one greatly to understand the prevailing character of the performance of a play as it adopts one or more of the Styles, and gives prominence to one or the other. It is a variation of emphasis on these, which is responsible for giving a play the character of a drama (including a dramatic spectacle), an opera or a ballet. Considered from this standpoint, dramas or dramatic spectacles like the *Nāṭaka*, the *Prakarāṇa*, the *Samavakāra* and the *Ihāmṛga* may, in their individual Acts, betray the characteristics of an opera or a ballet. The *Prahasana*, an one Act drama to be presented with attractive costumes and dance, may however to some extent, partake of the nature of a ballet. The *Ḍima*, the *Vithī*, the *Bhāṇa*, the *Vyāyoga* and the *Utsrṣṭikāṅka* are simple dramas devoid of dance and colourful costumes.

III. Literary Structure of the Drama :

1. Ten Types of Play

The Nāṭaka. To understand the literary structure of the Hindu drama, it will be convenient to take up first of all the *Nāṭaka* which is the most important of the ten kinds of play described in the *Nāṭyaśāstra*¹.

(a) Subject-matter and division into Acts.

The *Nāṭaka* is a play having for its subject-matter a well-known story and for its Hero a celebrated person of exalted nature. It describes the character of a person descending from a royal seat, the divine protection for him, and his many superhuman powers and exploits, such as success in different undertakings and amorous pastimes; and this play should have an appropriate number of Acts (XX. 10-12).

As the exploits of the Hero of the *Nāṭaka* have been restricted to his success in different undertakings including love-matters, it is a sort of 'comedy', and as such it can never permit the representation of the Hero's defeat, flight or capture by the enemy or a treaty with him under compul-

¹ NS. ignores the *Upavapakas*. For these see SD. NL. and BhP. etc.

sion. Such a representation would negative the subject of the play which is the triumph or the prosperity of the Hero. But all these except his (the Hero's) death, could be reported in an Introductory Scene which may come before an Act. The presentation of the Hero's death was for obvious reasons impossible in a comedy.

The first thing that attracts the attention of reader on opening a Nāṭaka, is its Prologue (*sthāpanā* or *prastavanā*). But according to the Nāṭyaśāstra this was a part of the Preliminaries (*pūrvavāṅga*) and was outside the scope of the play proper (V. 171). That famous playwrights like Bhāsa, Kālidāsa and others wrote it themselves and made it the formal beginning of their dramas, seems to show that they made in this matter an innovation which as great creative geniuses they were fully entitled to.

But unlike the Greek plays the Hindu Nāṭakas are divided into Acts the number of which must not be less than five or more than ten (XX. 57). These Acts, however, are not a set of clearly divided scenes as they usually are in modern western compositions of this category. An Act of the Hindu drama consists of a series of more or less loosely connected scenes² which due to its peculiar technique could not be separated from one another. It has three important characteristics.

(i) Only the royal Hero, his queen, minister, and similar other important personages are to be made prominent in it and not any minor character (XX. 18). This rule seems to be meant for securing the unity of impression which has been referred to before.

(ii) It is to include only those incidents which could take place in course of a single day (XX. 23). If it so happens that all the incidents occurring within a single day cannot be accommodated in an Act these surplus events are to be reported in a clearly separated part of it, called the Introductory Scene (*praveśaka*) where minor characters only can take part (XX. 27, 30). The same should be the method of reporting events that are to be shown as having occurred in the interval between two Acts (XX. 31). Evidently these latter should be of secondary importance for the action of play. But according to the Nāṭyaśāstra these should not cover more than a year (XX. 28). This allowance of a rather long period of time for less important events occurring between two Acts of a Nāṭaka was the means by which the Hindu playwrights imparted speed to the action of the play and compressed the entire plot distributed through many events over days, months and years within its narrow frame-work suitable for representation within a few hours.

(iii) An Act should not include the representation of events relating to feats of excessive anger, favour and gift, pronouncing a course, running

² See note 2 in IV. below.

away, marriage, a miracle, a battle, loss of kingdom, death and the siege of a city and the like (XX. 20, 21). The purpose of this prohibition was probably that, when elaborately presented in an Act, these might divert much of the spectator's interest from the line of the principal Sentiment which the play was to evoke and might therefore interfere with the unity of impression which it was to make.

(b) Explanatory Devices

(i) *The Introductory Scene.* It has been shown before how the Hindu playwrights divided the entire action of the Nāṭaka into two sets of events of which the one was more important than the other, and how they represented in its Acts the important set, whereas the less important ones were reported, whenever necessary, in an Introductory Scene giving one the idea of the time that intervened between any two Acts. This Scene is one of the five Explanatory Devices (*arthopakṣepaka*) which were adopted by the playwright for clarifying the obscurities that were liable to occur due to his extreme condensation of the subject-matter.

The other Explanatory Devices are as follows: The Intimating Speech (*cūlikā*), the Supporting Scene (*viśkambhaka*) the Transitional Scene (*aṅkāvalāra*) and the Anticipatory Scene (*aṅkāmukha*).

(ii) *The Intimating Speech.* When some points [in the play] are explained by a superior, middling or inferior character from behind the curtain, it is called the Intimating Speech (XXI. 108).

(iii) *The Supporting Scene.* The Supporting Scene relates to the Opening Juncture only of the Nāṭaka. It is meant for describing some incident or occurrence that is to come immediately after (XXI. 106-107).

(iv) *The Transitional Scene.* When a scene which occurs between two Acts or is a continuation of an Act and is included in it, relates to the purpose of the Germ of the play, it is called the Transitional Scene (XXI. 112).

(v) *The Anticipatory Scene.* When the detached beginning of an Act is summarised by a male or a female character, it is called the Anticipatory Scene (XXI. 112).

(c) The Plot and its Development

The Plot or the subject-matter (*vastu*) of a Nāṭaka may be twofold: "The principal" (*ādhikārika*) and the "incidental" (*prasaṅgika*). The meaning of the principal Plot is obvious from its name, and an incidental Plot is that in which the characters acting in their own interest incidentally further the purpose of the Hero of the principal Plot (XXI. 2-5).

The exertion of the Hero for the result to be attained, is to be represented through the following five stages (XXI. 8): Beginning (*ārambha*), Effort (*prayatna*), Possibility of Attainment (*prāpti-sambhava*),

Certainty of Attainment (*niyatāpti*) and Attainment of the Result (*phalaprāpti*). These five stages of the Plot have five corresponding Elements of the Plot (XXI. 20-21) such as, the Germ (*bija*), the Prominent Point (*bindu*) the Episode (*pātākā*), the Episodical Incident (*prakāri*) and the Dénouement (*kārya*). Besides these aspects of the action and the Plot of the Nāṭaka, the elaboration of the latter has been viewed as depending on its division into the following five Junctions which are as follows: the Opening (*mukhi*), the Progression (*pratimukha*), the Development (*garbha*), the Pause (*vimarśa*) and the Conclusion (*nirvāṇa*).

And these have been further subdivided and described to give detailed hints as to how the playwright was to produce a manageable play including events supposed to occur during a long period of time.

Kālidāsa's Śakuntalā and Bhāsa's Svapna-vāsavadattā are well-known examples of the Nāṭaka

The Prakaraṇa. The second species of Hindu play, is the Prakaraṇa which resembles the Nāṭaka in all respects except that "it takes a rather less elevated range". Its Plot is to be original and drawn from real life and the most appropriate theme is love. The Hero may be a Brahmin, merchant, minister, priest, an officer of the king or a leader of the army (XX. 49-51). The female characters include a courtesan or a depraved woman of good family (XX. 53)³. But the courtesan should not meet the Hero when he is in the company of a lady or gentleman of high family, and if the courtezans and respectable ladies must meet on any account they are to keep their language and manners undistorted (XX. 55-56). From these and other features, the Prakaraṇa has been called a bourgeois comedy or comedy of manners of a rank below royalty.

Śūdraka's Mṛcchakaṭika and Bhavabhūti's Mālatīmādhava are well-known examples of the Prakaraṇa.

The Samvākara. The Samvākara is the dramatic representation of some mythological story which relates to gods and some well-known Asura, who must be its Hero. It should consist of three Acts which are to take for their performance eighteen Nāḍikās (seven hours and twelve minutes).⁴ Of these the first Act is to take twelve and the second four and the third two Nāḍikās only. The subject-matter of the Samvākara should present deception, excitement or love, and the number of characters allowed in it are twelve. And besides this, metres used in it should be of the complex kind (XX. 63-76).

³ Wilson who did not see the N.S. said, "We may however observe to the honour of the Hindu drama that the *parakiya* or she who is the wife of another is never to be made the object of dramatic intrigue, a prohibition which could sadly have cooled the imagination and curbed the wit of Dryden and Congreve (Select Specimens of Hindu Theatre, Vol. I. p. xiv).

⁴ See H.H. Wilson, On the Dramatic System of the Hindus, Calcutta, 1827, p. 16.

No old specimen of this type of drama has reached us. From the description given in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* it seems that the *Samavakāra* was not a fully developed drama, but only a dramatic spectacle on the basis of a mythological story. It naturally became extinct with the development and production of fulfilled literary dramas such as those of *Bhāsa* and *Kālidāsa*.

Ihāmṛga. The *Ihāmṛga* is a play of four Acts in which divine males are implicated in a fight over divine females. It should be a play with well-ordered construction in which the Plot of love is to be based on causing discord among females, carrying them off and oppressing [the enemies], and when persons intent on killing are on the point of starting a fight, the impending battle should be avoided by some artifice (XX. 78-82).

No old specimen of this type of play has been found. From the description given in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* it seems that the *Ihāmṛga* was a play of intrigue, in which gods and goodesses only took part.

The Dima. The *Dima* is a play with a well-constructed Plot and its Hero should be well-known and of the exalted type. It is to contain all the Sentiments except the Comic and the Erotic, and should consist of four Acts only. Incidents depicted in it are mostly earthquake, fall of meteors, eclipses, battle, personal combat, challenge and angry conflict. It should abound in deceit, jugglery and energetic activity of many kinds. The sixteen characters which it must contain are to include different types such as gods, *Nāgas*, *Rākṣasas*, *Yakṣas* and *Piśācas* (XX. 84-88).

No old or new example of this type of play has reached us. It seems that like the *Samavakāra* this was a dramatic spectacle rather than a fulfilled drama. With the advent of literary plays of a more developed kind, it has naturally become extinct.

Vyāyoga. The *Vyāyoga* is a play with a well-known Hero and a small number of female characters. The events related in it are to be of one day's duration. It is to have one Act only and to include battle, personal combat, challenge and angry conflict (XX. 90-92).

Bhāsa's Madhyama-vyāyoga is a solitary old specimen of this type of play.

Utsṛṣṭikāṅka. The *Utsṛṣṭikāṅka* or *Aṅka* is an one-act play with a well-known plot, and it includes only human characters. It should abound in the Pathetic Sentiment and is to treat of women's lamentations and despondent utterances when battle and violent fighting have ceased, and its Plot should relate to the downfall of one of the contending characters (XX. 94-100).

Bhāsa's Urubhaṅga seems to be its solitary specimen. This type of play may be regarded as a kind of one-act tragedy.

The Prahāsana. The *Prahāsana* is a farce or a play in which the Comic Sentiment predominates, and it too is to consist of one Act only.

The object of laughter is furnished in this, mainly by the improper conduct of various sectarian teachers as well as courtizans and rogues (XX 102-106).

The *Mattavilāsa* and the *Bhagavadajjukīya* are fairly old specimens of this type of play.

The Bhāṇa. The *Bhāṇa* is an one Act play with a single character who speaks after repeating answers to his questions supposed to be given by a person who remains invisible, throughout. This play in monologue relates to one's own or another's adventure. It should always include many movements which are to be acted by a rogue or a Parasite (XX. 108-110). The *Bhāṇas* included in the collection published under the title *Caturbhāṇī* seem to be old specimens of this type of play.

The Vithi. The *Vithi* should be acted by one or two persons. It may contain any of the three kinds of characters superior, middling and inferior (XX. 112-113). It seems to be a kind of a very short one Act play. But one cannot be sure about this; for no specimen of this type of play has come down to us.

2. Diction of a Play

(a) *The Use of Metre.* One of the first things to receive the attention of the Hindu writers on dramaturgy was the importance of verse in the dramatic dialogue. They discouraged long and frequent prose passages on the ground that these might prove tiresome to spectators (XX. 34). After giving a permanent place to verse in drama the Hindu theorists utilized their detailed knowledge of the structure of metres which varied in caesura as well as the number and sequence of syllables or moras in a *pāda* (XV. 38ff., XIV. 1-86), for heightening the effect of the words used, by putting them in a appropriate metres. In this respect they framed definite rules as to the suitability of particular metres to different Sentiments. For example, the description of any act of boldness in connexion with the Heroic and the Furious Sentiments is to be given in the *Āryā* metre, and compositions meant to express the Erotic Sentiment should be in gentle metres such as *Mālinī* and *Mandakrāntā*, and the metres of the *Śakkarī* and the *Atidhṛti* types were considered suitable for the Pathetic Sentiment (XVII. 110-112). In this regard the Hindu theorists, and for that matter, the Hindu playwrights anticipated the great Shakespeare who in his immortal plays made "all sorts of experiments in metre".

(b) *Euphony.* After considering the use of metres the author of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* pays attention to euphony and says, "The uneven and even metres which have been described before should be used in composition with agreeable and soft sounds according to the meaning intended.

The playwright should make efforts to use in his composition sweet and agreeable words which can be recited by women.

A play abounding in agreeable sound and sense, and containing no

obscure or difficult words, intelligible to the country people, having a good construction, fit to be interpreted with dances, developing Sentiments..... becomes fit for representation to spectators" (XVII. 119-122).

(c) *Suggestive or Significant names.* Another important aspect of the diction was the suggestive or significant names for different characters in a play. It has been said of Gustave Flaubert that he took quite a long time to find a name for the prospective hero and heroine of his novels, and this may appear to be fastidious enough. But on discovering that the Hindu dramatic theorists centuries ago laid down rules about naming the created characters (XIX. 30-36), we come to appreciate and admire the genius of the great French writer.

(d) *Variety of languages or dialects.* The use of Sanskrit along with different dialects of Prakrit (XVIII. 36-61) must be ascribed to circumstances in the midst of which the Hindu drama grew up. The dramas reflect the linguistic condition of the society in which the early writers of plays lived. As the speech is one of the essential features of a person's character and social standing, it may profitably be retained unaltered from the normal. Even in a modern drama dialects are very often used though with a very limited purpose.

IV. The Ancient Indian Drama in Practice

1. Occasions for Dramatic Performance

The Hindu drama like similar other forms of ancient art and poetry seems to have been of religious origin, and it developed probably out of dances and songs in honour of a deity like Śiva who in later times came to be styled the great dancer-actor (*naṭarāja*). As time passed, the dance with songs gradually assumed the form of regular dramatic spectacles, and the range of subjects treated was extended beyond the legends connected with the exploits of a particular deity. It is just possible that this development of the religious aspect came in course of time to be partially arrested, and plays began to be composed more with a purely secular character. And this change considerably loosened its original connexion with the popular deities. Possibly due to this the Hindu drama in the historic period of its career, is found to be acted sometimes for moral edification as in the case of the Buddhist plays, sometimes for the aesthetic enjoyment of the elite as in the case of Kālidāsa's works, and sometimes in honour of a deity as in case of one of Bhavabhūti's plays. In spite of various uses, the Hindu drama unlike its modern counterparts did possibly never become an ordinary amusement of everyday life. It was only on special occasions like a religious festival, a marriage ceremony, a king's coronation, a friend's visit that dramatic performances were held (p. 269; AD. 12-14). But among all these occasions religious festivals

were the most common for the performance of drama. It was natural that on such occasions the drama was a popular entertainment as well, the public being then in a holiday mood.

Another fact about the dramatic performances of the Hindus was that these were sometimes held in the form of contests (XXVII. 21-22, 71, 77-79). Different groups of actors vied with one another for the popular appreciation, and reward for their skill in the particular art. This drama, however does not seem to have been a regular feature of the Hindu, as was the case with that of the Greeks, and theatrical troupes gave, however, performance usually for money without any spirit of rivalry towards others, and were paid by the rich people or the different guilds.

2. The Time of Performance

Except in the midnight or at noon or at the time of the Sandhyā prayers, the Hindu dramas could be performed almost at any part of the day or of the night. But this does not mean that any play could be produced at any allowable time during the twentyfour hours. Though at the command of the patron the Director of a theatrical party could overlook strict rules in this regard, the time of performance was to be regulated according to the nature of the subject-matter of the individual play. For example, a play based on a tale of virtue was to be performed in the forenoon; a performance which was rich in instrumental music, and told a story of strength and energy, was to be held in the afternoon, and a play which related to the Graceful Style, the Erotic Sentiment, and required vocal and instrumental music for its production, was to be performed in the evening; but in case of plays which related to the magnanimity of the Hero and contained mostly the Pathetic Sentiment, performance was to be held in the morning (XXVII. 88-99).

Though in the modern times dramatic performance is mostly held in the evening, the ancient Indian rules regarding the assignment of a play of a particular type to a particular part of the day or of the night need not be considered queer in any way. On the other hand, they appear very much to have been based on a proper understanding of the ever-changeable nature of human personalities. Even if a play based on a tale of virtue or of woe, when properly presented on the stage, could be appreciated at any time, it had better chance of impressing the spectator in the forenoon or in the morning, when after the night's sleep and rest, he could be the most receptive in regard to these Sentiments. That a play including a story of energy and strength can better be assigned to the after-noon is to be explained on the assumption that on taking rest after meals at the completion the morning's activities, one becomes psychologically more competent to appreciate stories of strength and energy presented on the stage. In a similar manner, a play with love as its principal theme (i.e. with

the Erotic Sentiment) may be more effectively presented on the stage in the evening, when after the day's work, one is naturally inclined to enjoy the company of his dear woman, be she his wife or the hetaera.

3. The Playhouse or the Theatre

The Nāṭyaśāstra describes various types of playhouse, and their different parts have been mentioned to some extent in detail. But in the absence of evidence the like of which has been copiously available in case of the Greek theatre, it cannot be said how far the ancient Indian plays were performed in specially constructed theatres. It may be possible that only the kings and very wealthy people owned playhouses constructed according to the Nāṭyaśāstra, while dramatic spectacles meant for the common people were held in the open halls called the Nāṭ-mandir (Nāṭya-mandira) in front of the temples, or in a temporarily devised theatre under the cover a canopy, as in the case of the modern Bengali Yātrās which seem to have some resemblance and connexion with the ancient Indian Nāṭya described in the Śāstra. One remarkable feature of the playhouses described in the Nāṭyaśāstra is that they are of a very moderate size, the largest among them (meant for mortals) being only thirtytwo yards long and sixteen yards board, capable of accommodating about four hundred (400) spectators. This is in sharp contrast with the Athenian theatre which sometimes held as many as fifteen thousand (15,000) people.

* The comparative smallness of the ancient Indian theatre was a necessary consequence of the peculiar technique of the dramatic production. For in a larger playhouse the spectators could not all have heard delicate points on which depended in no small measure the success of a performance. The inordinately large Athenian theatre was not much handicapped in this respect, for the Greek drama depended on a considerably different technique.

The Nāṭyaśāstra describes three main types of playhouse : oblong (*vikṛṣṭa*), square (*catuṣra*) and triangular (*tryasra*). These again might be the large, medium or small, with their length respectively as one hundred and eight, sixtyfour, and thirtytwo cubits. This gives altogether nine different varieties of theatres, viz. (i) the large oblong, (ii) the large-square, (iii) the large triangular, (iv) the medium oblong, (v) the medium square (vi) the medium triangular, (vii) the small oblong, (viii) the small square and (ix) the small triangular. These nine types can also be measured in terms of *daṇḍas* instead of that of cubits. This will give us eighteen different dimensions of playhouse. But the Nāṭyaśāstra is silent about the use of the playhouse measured in terms of *daṇḍas*, and the playhouse of the largest type measuring 108 cubits in length have been prohibited by the Śāstra for the mortals. And it has been mentioned before that a playhouse more in area than thirtytwo yards long and sixteen

yards broad has been prescribed for them. This should be divided into three parts : (i) the tiring room (*nepathya*) (ii) the stage (*raṅgaṭīṭha* or *raṅgaśīṛṣa*) and (iii) the auditorium (*raṅgamaṇḍala*). Of these the tiringroom would be at one end of the theatre and would measure sixteen yards by four yards. On the two sides of the stage there should be two *Mattavāraṇis* each occupying an area of four yards by four yards and having four pillars. Thus the area to be occupied by the seats of spectators would be twentyfour yards by sixteen yards.

The tiring room (*nepathya*) was the place in which the actors and the actresses put on the costumes suited to the different roles, and from this place, the tumults, divine voices (*daiva-vāṇis*) and similar other acts proceeded. This part of the theatre was separated from the stage by two screens over its two doors. Between these two doors the members of the orchestra (*kulapa*) were to sit and the direction facing them was to be considered conventionally the east.

4. The Representation

To understand the technique of representation of the Hindu drama one must remember that it avoided stark realism and gave utmost scope to imagination and fancy. The one unmistakable evidence of this is the total absence of any painted scenery from the stage. This is but a negative side of it. If the Hindus avoided bringing in any kind of artificial scenery, they made positive efforts in communicating the meaning of the drama and calling forth the Sentiment (*rasa*) in the spectators through suggestive use of colour in the costume and make up of the actors and rhythmic movements of many kinds which have been summed up in their theory of four representations (*abhinaya*) such as *āṅgika*, *vācika*, *āhārya*, and *sattvika* (VI.23).

(a) The Physical Representation

Among these, the *āṅgika* should be discussed first. This consists of the use of various gestures and postures of which the *Nāṭyaśāstra* gives elaborate descriptions. Different limbs have been named and their manifold gestures and movements described, with various significance attached to each one of them (VIII.-XII). For example, the head has thirteen different gestures which are as follows :

Ākampita : Moving the head slowly up and down.

Kampita : when the movements in the Ākampita head are quick and copious. (Uses) : The Ākampita head is to be applied in giving a hint, teaching questioning, addressing in an ordinary way (lit. naturally), and giving an order.

The Kampita head is applicable (lit. desired) in anger argument understanding, asserting, threatening, sickness and intolerance.

Dhuta and Vidhuta : A slow movement of the head is called the

Dhuta and when this movement is quick it is called Vidhuta. (Uses): The Dhuta head is applicable in unwillingness, sadness, astonishment, confidence, looking side ways, emptiness and forbidding.

The Vidhuta head is applied in an attack of cold, terror, panic, fever and the first stage of drinking (i. e. intoxication).

Parivāhita and Udvāhita: when the head is alternately turned to two sides it is called the Parivāhita, and when it is once turned upwards it is known as the Udvāhita. (Uses): The Parivāhita head is applicable in demonstration, surprise, joy, remembering, intolerance, cogitation, concealment and [amorous] sporting.

The Udvāhita head is to be applied in pride, showing height, looking high up, self-esteem and the like.

Avadhuta: When the head is once turned down it is called the Avadhuta. (Uses): it is to be applied in [communicating] a message involving a deity, conversation and beckoning [one to come near].

Añcita: When the neck is slightly bent on one side the Añcita head is the result. (Uses): It is applicable in sickness, swoon, intoxication anxiety and sorrow.

Nihañcita: when two shoulders are raised up with the neck bent on one side the Nihañcita head is produced. (Uses): It is to be used by women in pride, Amorousness (*vilāsa*), Light-heartedness (*lalita*). Affected Indifference (*bibboka*), Hysterical Mood (*kilakiñcita*). Silent Expression of Affection (*moḥāyita*), Pretended Anger (*kuṭṭamita*)¹; Paralysis (*stambha*) and Jealous Anger (*māna*).

Parāvṛtta: when the face is turned round, the Parāvṛtta head is the result. (Uses): It is to be used in turning away the face, and looking back and the like.

Utkṣipta: when the face is raised up the Utkṣipta head is the result. (Uses): It is used indicating lofty objects, and application of divine weapons.

Adhogata: The head with the face looking downwards is called the Adhogata. (Uses): It is used in shame, bowing [in salutation] and sorrow.

Parilolita: when the head is moving on all sides, it is called Parilolita. (Uses): It is used in fainting, sickness, power of intoxication, possession by an evil spirit, drowsiness and the like.

The eyes are similarly to have different kinds of glances according to the States (*bhāva*) and Sentiments (*rasa*) they are to express. The eyeballs too are liable to similar changes to create impressions of different feelings and emotions, and so have the eyebrows, the nose,

¹ For the definition of all these terms together with the preceding ones see N.S. XXIV. 15, 18-22.

the cheeks, the chin, and the neck. The hands, however, are the most important limbs in the making of gestures. Gestures and movements of hands fall into three classes, viz. single (*asamyūta*), combined (*samyūta*) and dance hands (*nṛtta-hasta*). Single-hand gestures and movements relate to one hand only, while combined hands to both the hands. The following are examples of the three kinds of hand gestures:—*Patāka* (single hand): The fingers extended and close to one another and the thumb bent. *Anjali* (combined hand) Putting together of the two *Patāka* hands is called the *Anjali*. *Caturasra* (dance-hand): The *Kaṭakāmukha* hands held forward eight *Āṅgulis* apart [from each other] on one's breast, the two shoulders and elbows on the same level. Besides these gestures, the hands have varied movements which are characterised by the following acts: drawing upwards, dragging, drawing out, accepting, killing, beckoning, urging, bringing together, separating, protecting, releasing, throwing, shaking, giving away, threatening, cutting, piercing, squeezing and beating (IX. 161-163).

From the foregoing discussion about the gestures it is apparent that their uses fall into two different categories, viz. realistic and conventional. Of these two types, the gestures used conventionally far outnumber those of the other kind. But this should not appear strange. For the ancient Indian dramatists and theatrical producers were fully conscious of the limited scope of realism in arts of various kinds, and hence they conceived action as something very closely allied to dance. This demanded that while moving on the stage with or without uttering any word, the actors should gesticulate rhythmically, to impart grace and decorative effect to their figure. For this very purpose another set of gestures called *Dance-hands* (*nṛttahasta*) are also to be used. As their name implies these hands were exclusively to be used in dance, but for reasons mentioned above they were sometimes utilized at the time of declamation or recitation. The lower parts of the body down to the feet are also to be similarly used. Among these, the feet are the most important. On them depend the different movements of the entire body as well as the various standing postures. The movements of the feet are of three kinds, viz. ordinary gait, *Cārī* and *Maṇḍala*. Of these, the *Cārī* is a simple movement of the feet (XI.) while *Maṇḍala*, is a series of such movements considered together (XII.) During the stage fighting the two combatants are to move with *Cārīs* and *Maṇḍalas* in accompaniment with suitable music. And the gait is very valuable for the representation of different roles. In this matter too convention plays a very considerable part. The *Nāṭyaśāstra* lays down elaborate rules about the width of footsteps and the tempo of the gait for different characters according to their social position, age, sex, health and feeling as well as the peculiar environments in which they might be placed (XIII. 1-157).

(b) The Vocal Representation

The second means of theatrical representation consists of the use of speech. It relates to the proper musical notes (*svara*) voice registers (*sthāna*), pitch of vowels (*varṇa*), intonation (*kāku*), speech-tempo (*laya*) to be used in reciting or declaiming a passage for the purpose of evoking different Sentiments (*rasa*) in the spectators. For example to call forth the Comic and The Erotic Sentiments a passage should be recited with the Madhyama and the Pañcama notes, and for the Heroic and the Marvellous Sentiments the Śadja and the Rṣabha would be the suitable notes.

To call a person staying at a distance the voice should proceed from the head register (*śīras*) and when he is at a short distance it should be from the chest (*uras*), and for calling a man at one's side the voice from the throat register (*kanṭha*) would be proper (XIX. 43).

For any speech with the Comic and the Erotic Sentiments the prevailing pitch would be Udātta (acute) and Svarita (circumflex) while in the Heroic, the Furious and the Marvellous Sentiments it should be Udātta and Kampita.

In the Comic and the Erotic Sentiments the speech-tempo should be medium, in the Pathetic slow, and in the other Sentiments a quick tempo is appropriate (XIX. 59).

Besides the above aspects of speech, close attention was to be given in observing rhythm and cadence. And the metrical character of any passage in verse was to be fully expressed in its recitation or declamation. For this purpose the Nāṭyaśāstra devotes nearly two full chapters (XV, XVI) which discuss prosody and allied topics.

(c) The Costumes and Make-up

One important element in theatrical representation now-a-days is the various stage appliances such as, painted scenery, costumes and make-up. However able the actors and actresses might be in delivering the speeches assigned to their roles, without being placed against properly painted scenery and without having proper costumes and make-up, by their acting and delivery alone they cannot create that kind of stage-illusion which is necessary for the success of a dramatic production. But in the ancient Indian stage there was no painted scenery. Hence the actors had to depend a great deal upon costumes and make-up. By the term Āhāryābhinaya the Hindu theorists understood these two items (XXIII).

Though painted scenery is considered indispensable in the modern, theatre, the ancient Indians having a considerably different conception of the drama, did not require its aid for the production of a play. The wall that separated the tiring room (*nepathya*) and the stage (*raṅgapīṭha*) together with the screens covering the two doors connecting the stage and the tiring room, served as the back-ground to show off to advantage the

figures of the performers. And these, the wall and the screens, possibly did not contain anything other than the usual decorative designs. This simplicity in the character of the scenic apparatus was a necessary concomitant of the peculiar technique of the Hindu drama, and its cause may be looked for in its early history. The introduction of magnificent scenery appears to be a later development in the history of drama. Similarly the back scene of the Shakespearian stage consisted of a bare wall, and anything in the way of spectacular effect was created by the movements and grouping of actors.

The production of an impression by means of painted scenery would have been alien to the taste of the ancient Hindus who were more or less conscious of the limitation of realism in their various arts. In order to make the spectators visualise the place and time of the dramatic story in hand, the Hindus had a different device. Numerous descriptions of place and time composed in rhythmic prose and verse, which are scattered over the classical Hindu plays, served very efficiently indeed the purpose of painted scenery. When properly read or sung, these passages very easily created an illusion of the place or the time described. The elaborate description of Vasantasena's magnificent residence in the *Mṛcchakaṭika* was calculated to call up vividly its picture before the mind's eye. The same thing may be said of the grand description of the Daṇḍaka forest in the *Uttarāmacarita*. This device of making a scene lively, has been utilized by Shakespeare also. In appreciation of his very beautiful description of place and time, one critic says "The plays are full of such descriptive passages as can nullify the achievements of decorators and mechanics." It has already been mentioned that in the Shakespearian stage too painted scenery was unknown.

There being no scenery of any kind in the Hindu theatre which made no effort at realism, the spectators were required to use their imagination to the utmost. The demand on the spectator's imagination made by the ancient Indian producers of plays was further testified by their rules of conventional Zonal division (*kakṣa-vibhāga*) of the stage (XIV. 1-15). Some of these are as follows :

A Zone might change with the actor walking a few steps over the stage.² Any ancient Hindu play will furnish numerous examples of this convention. For example in the first Act of the *Śakuntalā* the king appears for the first time at a distance from Kaṇva's hermitage, but shortly afterwards he enters it by simply taking a few steps over the stage, looking around and saying. "This is the entrance of hermitage and let me enter it".

By the same kind of convention the inside and outside of a house was

² Due to this kind of convention, scenes of the Hindu plays were not clearly separated as they are in a modern drama. This puzzled F. Hall who says :

simultaneously presented.³ The rule relating to this was as follows : According to the Zonal division, those who entered the stage earlier should be taken as being inside [a house] while those entering it later are known to be as remaining outside it. He who enters the stage with the intention of seeing them (i.e. those entering earlier) should report himself after turning to the right. To indicate going to a distant locality one is to walk a good few steps over the stage and to indicate going to a place near by, a short walk only is needed, while a walk of medium duration will indicate going to a place of medium distance. But in case a person leaves one country and goes to a distant land, this is to be indicated by closing the Act in which such an event occurs, and mentioning again the same fact in an Explanatory Scene at the beginning of the next Act.

An example of some of these conventional rules occurs in the ninth Act of the *Mṛcchakaṭika* where Śodhanaka appears first as being at the gate of the court of justice and enters it by making a pantomimic movement; then again he goes out to receive the judge and re-enters, the courtroom after him by simply walking over the same stage. And when the judge has started work, Śodhanaka again goes out to call for the complainants. This going out also consists of actually walking a few steps over the stage.

Though painted scenery was not in use in the Hindu theatre objects like hills, carriages, aerial cars, elephants etc, were represented on the stage by suggestive models (*pusta*) of these. According to the *Nāṭyaśāstra* the model works were of three kinds, viz. *sandhima* which was made up of mat, cloths or skins, wrapping cloth, or other materials wrapped round something, and *vyājima* which was a mechanical contrivance of some kind. From Dhanika, the commentator of the *Daśarūpa* (II. 67-58), we learn about a model-work of an elephant for the production of the *Udayanacarita*, and the *Mṛcchakaṭika* owes its name to the toy cart which plays an indispensable role in the story.

(d) The Temperament

The fourth or the most important means of representation is the Temperament (*satva*) or the entire psychological resources of a man (XXIV). The actor or the actress must for the time being feel the States that he or she is to represent, and only then will the Sentiments related to them follow. This kind of representation was indispensable for giving expression to various delicate aspects of men's and women's emotional nature.

So far as is known, Hindu dramas have always been parted into acts; but never have they had scenes. It is somewhat to be wondered at, that the Hindus, with their inordinate love for subdivision, should have left those univented. (Introduction to *Daśarūpa*, pp. 28-29.

³ See note 2 above.

V. Literature on the Ancient Indian Drama

1. The Early Writers

Śilālin and *Kṛṣāśva*. Pāṇini (circa 500 B.C.) refers (IV. 3.110-111) to the *Nāṭasūtras* of *Śilālin* and *Kṛṣāśva*. As the works of these two authors have perished beyond recovery we are not in a position to have any exact idea about their contents. But Lévi and Hillebrandt have taken them to be manuals for actors (*naṭa*) though Weber and Konow have considered these to have been sets of rules for dancers and pantomimists, and Keith has accepted their view. Konow further thinks that the treatises of *Śilālin* and *Kṛṣāśva* were absorbed in the body of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (ID. p. 1)

2. The so-called sons of Bharata

After *Śilālin* and *Kṛṣāśva* come the writers whose names have been included in the list of the one hundred sons of Bharata, given in the extant version of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. (I. 26-22). Among these Kohala, Dattila (Dhūrtila), Śālikarṇa (Śātakarṇa), Bādarāyaṇa (Bādari), Nakhakuṭṭa and Āsmakuṭṭa have been referred to and quoted by later writers as authorities on dramaturgy and histrionics. Besides these, Vātsya and Śaṇḍilya have been named as authorities on drama by some writers. Such references and quotations are our only source of knowledge of them and their work.

(a) *Kohala* Among the writers on drama who wrote after *Śilālin* and *Kṛṣāśva*, Kohala seems to be the most important. In the extant version of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (XXXVI. 63), it is given in the form of a prophecy that Kohala will discuss in a supplementary treatise all those topics on drama that have not been touched by Bharata. From quotations of his works made by Abhinava¹ and another commentator,² as well as from their references to his opinion, it appears that Kohala wrote on dance and dramaturgy as well as histrionics and music.

(b) *Dattila*, *Śaṇḍilya*, and *Vātsya*. Dattila seems to be identical with Dantila or Dhūrtila mentioned in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (I. 26). Abhinava too quotes from one Dattilācārya³ and it is likely that he is not other than this Dattila. From these quotations it appears that he wrote on histrionics and music. Śaṇḍilya and Vātsya mentioned in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (XXXVI. 63) along with Dattila (Dhūrtila) are to us nothing but mere names. It is possible that they were writers on some aspects of drama and theatre.

¹ Ag I. pp. 173, 182, 183-184; II p. 26, 55, 130, 133, 142, 146, 148, 151, 155, 407, 416-417, 421, 434, 438-439, 443, 452, 459; De' Ms. p. 413, 436, 496, 521, 680.

² BhP. pp. 204, 210, 236, 245, 251.

³ Ag. I. p. 205, Besides this Ag. quotes and refers to Dattila no less than 14 times while commenting on chapter on music. See De's Ms. pp. 544, 573, 576, 580, 583, 588, 590, 624, 625, 628, 633, 634, 640, 642, 644, 650, 653. See also Kutta sl. 123.

(c) *Śātakarṇi* (*Śātakarṇa*, *Śālikarṇa*). *Śātakarṇi* as a proper name is found in inscriptions from the first century B. C. to 149 A. C. Hence it is possible (though not quite certain) that *Śātakarṇi* the writer on drama flourished about the first century A. C.⁴ Like kings in later times who were sometimes found to take interest among other subjects in drama and poetics and to write treatises on them, this *Śātakarṇi* might well have been a king or a person of royal descent. From the quotations made by later writers⁵ from him it appears he wrote on dramaturgy.

(d) *Āsmakutṭa* and *Nakhakutṭa*. These two writers from their names appear to have been contemporaries, probably belonged to the same locality. *Sāgaranandin*⁶ and *Viśvanātha*⁷ quote from *Nakhakutṭa*, and *Sāgara* only is known to have quoted from *Āsmakutṭa*⁸. From these quotations it appears that *Āsmakutṭa* and *Nakhakutṭa* wrote on dramaturgy.

(e) *Bādarāyaṇa* (*Bādari*). *Sāgara* quotes from *Bādarāyaṇa* twice⁹ and possibly names him once as *Bādari*, and from the extracts quoted it seems that this early writer discussed dramaturgy.

3. Samgrahakara

Abhinavagupta once mentioned the *Samgraha* and once the *Samgrahakāra*.¹⁰ In the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (VI. 3, 10) itself also one *Samgraha* has been mentioned. It seems that the reference is to the identical work. From these facts it appears that the work might have been a compendium treating of dramaturgy as well as histrionics.

4. The Present Text of the Nāṭyaśāstra (circa 200 A.C.).¹¹

5. Medieval Writers on Drama

(a) *Nandi* (*Nandikeśvara*) *Tumburu* *Viśakhila* and *Cārāyaṇa*. Besides the writers mentioned above Abhinava and Śāradātanaya refer to *Nandi* or *Nandikeśvara*¹² and the former also names *Tumburu*¹³ and *Viśakhila*¹⁴ with occasional reference to their views or actually quotations from them, and *Cārāyaṇa* has once been quoted by *Sāgaranandin*.¹⁵

(b) *Sadāśiva*, *Padmabhūti*, *Drauhini*, *Vyāsa* and *Ānjaneya*.

⁴ Select Inscriptions, pp. 191-207.

⁵ NL. 1101-1102, Rucipati's Comm. on AR. p. 7.

⁶ NL. 2768-2769, 2904-2905.

⁷ SD. 294, *Nakhakutṭa* has also been mentioned by Bahurūpa in his Comm. on *Daśarūpa* (Indian and Iranian Studies presented to D. Ross, Bombay. p. 201), p. 201 f.m.

⁸ 83, 437, 2766-2767, 2774-2775.

⁹ NL. 1092-1094, 2770-2771.

¹⁰ Ag. II. pp. 436, 2770-2771.

¹¹ See below sections VI. and VIII.

¹² Ag. I. p. 171, De's Ms. p. 559. This *Nandikeśvara* may be identical with the author of the AD.

¹³ Ag. I. pp. 165.

¹⁴ Ag. I. p. 199 also De's Ms. pp. 547, 564, 573, See also Kutṭa, sl. 123.

¹⁵ NL. 362-363.

Abhinava and Śāradātānaya once refer to Śaḍāśiva¹⁶ while some writers on drama, such as Padmabhū,¹⁷ Drauhini,¹⁸ Vyāsa¹⁹ and Āṇjaneya²⁰ have been named by Śāradātānaya only. But we are not sure whether they were really old authors or these names have been attached to some late treatises to give them an air of antiquity.

(c) *Kātyāyana*, *Rāhula* and *Garga*. These three writers, quoted by Abhinava and Śāgara may be counted among the medieval writers on drama. From the available extracts from his work *Kātyāyana*²¹ seems to have been a writer on dramaturgy. Rāhula has been twice quoted in Abhinava's commentary, and Śāgara²² has once referred to his view.²³ From these it appears that Rāhula was a writer on dramaturgy as well as histrionics. Garga as an authority on drama has been mentioned by Śāgaranandin.²⁴ In the absence of any quotation from him we cannot say what exactly he wrote about.

(d) *Śakaligarbha* and *Ghaṇṭaka*. Abhinava mentions among others the names of Śakaligarbha²⁵ and Ghaṇṭaka.²⁶ Of these two, Ghaṇṭaka seems to be a contemporary of Śaṅkuka, and as for, Śakaligarbha, we have no definite idea about his time. From the references to their views it appears that they wrote on dramaturgy.

(e) *Vārtika-kāra Harṣa*. Abhinava once quotes from the *Vārtika-karṇi*²⁷ and once from the *Vārtika*²⁸ and next time from the *Harṣa-vārtika*,²⁹ and besides this he once refers to the views of the *Vārtika-kāri*.³⁰ Śāgaranandin and Śāradātānaya refer to one *Harṣavikrama*³¹ or *Harṣa*.³² It seems possible that they all referred to the same author, and the name of the author of the *Vārtika* was *Harṣa* or *Harṣa-vikrama*. From these quotations and the references it appears that this *Vārtika* was an original treatise on dramaturgy and histrionics.

(f) *Māṭṛgupta*. *Māṭṛgupta* has been taken to be a commentator of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* by Sylvain Lévi.³³ Though this view has been accepted by authors who have written later on the subject,³⁴ from the metrical extracts³⁵ made from his work by some commentators it appears

¹⁶ BhP. 152, DR. IV. 38-3).

¹⁷ BhP. p. 47.

¹⁸ BhP. p. 239.

¹⁹ BhP. 251.

²⁰ See note 19.

²¹ NL. 1484-1485. Ag. II. pp. 245-246.

²² Ag. I. pp. 115, 172. NL. 3873-2175.

²³ NL. 3225.

²⁴ NL. 3226.

²⁵ Ag. II. p. 452. Kavi thinks that Śakaligarbha = Śakaleya = Udbhaṭa.

²⁶ Ag. II. p. 436.

²⁷ Ag. I. p. 172. This *Vārtika* seems to have been in original work like Kumārila's *Sloka-vārtika* written in verso.

²⁸ Ag. I. p. 174.

²⁹ Ag. I. p. 207 also De's Ms. p. 545.

³⁰ Ag. I. p. 31.

³¹ NL. 3225.

³² BhP. 233.

³³ Le Theatre indien p. 15.

³⁴ e.g. Skt. Poetics, Vol. (p. 32-33).

³⁵ A. dy pp. 2, 5, 7, 8, 9, 13, 15, 110, 126, 230, NL. 103, 314-316, 459-471, 534, 1186 (f). BhP. p. 234.

that he composed an original work on the subject. It is probable that in this he occasionally explained in prose the view expressed by the author of the Nāṭyaśāstra.³⁶ Interpreting in this manner one can understand the words of Sundara-miśra, who, commenting on Bharata's definition of the Benediction (*nāṇḍī*), remarks that 'in explaining this Mātṛgupta said etc'.³⁷ About the time of Mātṛgupta, we have no sufficient evidence. All that can be said is that, Abhinava quotes from his work once³⁸ and hence he was earlier than this great well-known commentator. Besides this Sāgaranandin, who is possibly earlier than Abhinava, names Mātṛgupta along with old writers such as Āsmakuṭṭa, Nakhakuṭṭa, Garga, and Bādarāyaṇa (Bādari).³⁹ hence it appears that he was not a late writer.

From the meagre information available about him scholars have identified him with the poet of that name living during the reign of Harṣa-vikramāditya of Kashmir who seems to have been the author of a work on drama called Vārtika. This would roughly place his work at the end of the 4th century A.C. or in the beginning of the 5th.⁴⁰ From the extracts made from his works it appears that wrote on dramaturgy and music.

(g) *Subandhu*. Śāradātanaya refers to one Subandhu who wrote on dramaturgy.⁴¹ If it is possible to identify him with the famous author of the Vāsavadattā, then he may be placed roughly in the 5th century A.C.

(h) *The compilers of the Agnipurāṇa and the Viṣṇudharmottara*, The Agnipurāṇa treats of *nāṭya*, *nṛṭya*, and *rasa*, but this treatment depends considerably on the Nāṭyaśāstra. There is literal borrowing from this work as well as paraphrases of some of its metrical passages in this Purāṇa. This portion of the Agnipurāṇa is usually placed after Daṇḍin (circa. 7th century).⁴² The Viṣṇudharmottara too treats of *nṛṭa*, *naṭya* and *abhinaya*, and this treatment too is dependent on the Nāṭyaśāstra and does not appear to be earlier than the 8th century.

6. Late writings on Drama

(a) *Daśarūpa*. The Daśarūpa (Daśarūpaka) of Dhanañjaya was composed in the last quarter of the 10th century A.C. during the reign of Muñja (Vākpatirāja, II) the king of Malawa. This work, as its name implies, treats of the ten principal forms of dramatic works (*rūpa*) which constitute the subject-matter of chapter XX of the Nāṭyaśāstra, but it

³⁶ For example Sagara, (NL. 534ff.) discusses Mātṛgupta's view in his compilation which is written in verse and prose. It seems that this author was his model.

³⁷ Skt. Poetics Vol. I. pp. 102-103.

³⁸ Ag. De's Ms. p. 543. Dr. S. K. De thought that Mātṛgupta was unknown to Ag. (Skt. Poetics, Vol. I. p. 33).

³⁹ See note 23 above.

⁴⁰ Keith, Skt. Drama, p. 291.

⁴¹ BHP. p. 238.

⁴² Skt. Poetics, Vol. I. p. 102-103.

actually brings in a few other relevant matters scattered over other parts of this comprehensive work.

Any careful student of the Nāṭyaśāstra will easily discover that Dhanañjaya in restating the principles of dramaturgy in a more concise and systematic form has carried too far the work of his abridgment and left out quite a number of important matters. The special stress which he lays on the literary aspect of drama by his exclusion of its histrionics and other technical sides, very clearly indicates the general decadence of India's aesthetic culture at the time. With his professed reverence for the rules of the Nāṭyaśāstra (ascribed to Bharata), he seems to have misunderstood the aims and objects of its author who composed his work for the playwrights as well as the producers of plays.⁴³

But whatever be its limitation, the Daśarūpa, and its commentary Avaloka without which it was only half intelligible, attained in course of time a wide popularity and gradually superseded the Nāṭyaśāstra which seems to have become very rare with the passage of time. And the Daśarūpa so thoroughly supplanted other dramaturgic works as existed before its time, that with the exception of the Nāṭyaśāstra it is the most well-known work on the subject and very frequently drawn upon by the commentators of plays as well as later writers on dramaturgy like Viśvanātha.

(b) *Nāṭakalakṣaṇa-ratnaśoṣa*. Slightly earlier than the Daśarūpa or contemporaneous with it,⁴⁴ is the Nāṭakalakṣaṇa-ratnaśoṣa (briefly Nāṭakalakṣaṇa) of Sāgaranandin. Till about a quarter of a century ago our only knowledge of the work consisted of a few quotations from it in different commentaries. But in 1922 the late Sylvain Lévi discovered its Ms. in Nepal and published a report on its contents and other relevant matters (Journal Asiatique, 1922, p. 210). Since then the work has been carefully edited by M. Dillon and published (London, 1937). Just like Dhanañjaya, Sāgaranandin too discusses in his Nāṭakalakṣaṇa, dramaturgy in detail and mentions only incidentally certain topics connected with histrionics. But unlike the Daśarūpa the Nāṭakalakṣaṇa does not treat exclusively of dramaturgy, but refers to histrionics whenever necessary. Though the author professedly depends on no less than seven different authorities such as Harṣa-vikrama, Mātṛgupta, Garga, Āsmakutṭa, Nakha-kutṭa, Bādari (Bādarāyaṇa), and Bharata (the mythical author of the Nāṭyaśāstra) yet his dependence on the last-named one seems to be the greatest. A large number of passages have actually been borrowed by him from the same.⁴⁵ Besides these borrowings the extent of Sāgaranandin's

⁴³ Ag. I. p. 7.

⁴⁴ See R. Kavi, 'Date of Sāgara-Nandin' in Indian and Iranian Studies presented to D. Ross, Bombay, 1939, pp. 198ff.

⁴⁵ See NL. pp. 143-144.

dependence on the *Nāṭyaśāstra* is apparent from his echoing of the numerous passages⁴⁶ of the latter.

(c) *Nāṭyadarpaṇa*. The *Nāṭyadarpaṇa*⁴⁷ of Rāmacandra and Guṇacandra is the next important work on dramaturgy after the *Daśarūpa*. Of the two joint-authors⁴⁸ of this text, who were Jains Rāmacandra lived probably between 1100 and 1175 A.C., and he was a disciple of the famous Hemacandra. Rāmacandra wrote a large number of works including many plays. But of Guṇacandra, the collaborator of Rāmacandra, very little is known except that he too was a disciple of Hemacandra. The *Nāṭyadarpaṇa* which is divided into four chapters, treats of dramaturgy.

This work has been composed in Anuṣṭup couplets. Its brevity of the treatment is comparable to that of the *Daśarūpa*, and as in the latter many of its passages cannot be fully understood unless a commentary is consulted. Fortunately for us the joint-authors of the work have left for us a very clearly written and informative *vṛtti* (gloss). It is evident from the metrical text that the authors had access to the *Nāṭyaśāstra* and exploited it very thoroughly. And whatever could not be accommodated in the text has been added in the prose *vṛtti* which has utilised also Abhinava's famous commentary. Besides this the authors have occasionally criticised the views of other writers among whom the author of the *Daśarūpa* figures most prominently.⁴⁹ All this has given the *Nāṭyadarpaṇa* a unique value and some superiority over the *Daśarūpa*.

(d) *Ruyyaka's Nāṭakamīmāṃsā*. Ruyyaka *alias* Rucaka,⁵⁰ who was a Kashmirian and flourished probably in the 12th century, was a voluminous writer on poetics. It was from one of his works (a commentary of Mahima-bhaṭṭa's *Vyaktiviveka*) that we learn of his *Nāṭakamīmāṃsā* a work on dramaturgy. No Ms. of this work has so far been discovered.

(e) *Bhāvaprakāśana*. Śāradātanaya, who seems to have been a Southerner and flourished in the 12th century, wrote the *Bhāvaprakāśana*⁵¹ which dealt with dramaturgy in greater detail than either the *Daśarūpa* or the *Nāṭyadarpaṇa*. And his work acquires an additional authority from the fact that Śāradātanaya had as his teacher one Divākara who was the Director of a theatre⁵² and might be taken as deeply conversant with the theory and practice of Indian drama as it was current in his time. Though Śāradātanaya depends much on earlier authors for the materials of his work, yet his approach to the subject is to some extent original. As the name of his work implies, it deals with the "expression" *prakāśa* of the

⁴⁶ Printed out by M. Dillon in the margin of NL.

⁴⁷ Ed. in G.O.S. Baroda, 1929. ⁴⁸ See Introduction of ND. p.3.

⁴⁹ But they have also drawn materials from older writers like Kohala, *Saṅkuka* and Ag. See ND. p. 224. ⁵⁰ See ND. Introduction p. 3. ⁵¹ Skt. Poetics, p. 190f.

⁵² Ibid. p. 186. ⁵³ Ed. G.O.S. Baroda, 1930. ⁵⁴ BbP. p. 2 also Introduction, p.6.

"State" (*bhāva*). Now the proper expression of the States by the actors according to the Nāṭyaśāstra gives rise to the Sentiments (*rasa*). Hence Śāradātanaya begins his work with the description of the States and everything connected with them. Next he passes very naturally to the discussion of the Sentiments. These being thoroughly discussed, he takes up the Heroines of different classes who are the main stay of the Sentiments. The time factor in the plot and the diction of the play which also are means of developing the Sentiments are considered next. Afterwards he analyses the body of the play and its different parts. This brings him to the consideration of the ten major and twenty minor types of play (*rūpa*), and finally of the miscellaneous matters connected with drama and theatre. To avoid prolixity we desist from giving here any detailed account of its contents which include all possible topics relating to dramaturgy. It may be briefly said that Śāradātanaya's treatment of the subject is in many respects more comprehensive than that of the Daśarūpa, the Nāṭakalakṣaṇa, and the Nāṭyadarpaṇa. And to attain his object Śāradātanaya has freely referred to the Nāṭyaśāstra⁵⁵ as well as the works of early writers like Kohala,⁵⁶ Mātṛgupta,⁵⁷ Harṣa⁵⁸ and Subandhu.⁵⁹ Besides this he has sometimes mentioned authors like Dhvanikṛt, Rudraṭa, Dhanika, Abhinava, Bhoja and, sometimes referred also to their views and criticised these.⁶⁰ All this adds to the great value of his work.

(f) *Sāhityadarpaṇa* and *Nāṭakaparibhāṣa*, Viśvanātha Kavirāja, who flourished about the thirteenth century⁶¹ was a poet and a scholar and in this latter capacity he wrote among other things the famous Sāhityadarpaṇa which treats all branches of the Skt. literature including drama. It was the sixth chapter of this work dealing with drama on which the early western writers of the ancient Indian drama mostly depended. For his treatment of drama Viśvanātha seems to have utilised the Nāṭyaśāstra,⁶² the Daśarūpa⁶³ and its commentary Avaloka⁶⁴ as well as the work of Rudraṭa and others.

Śiṅga-Bhūpala's Nāṭakaparibhāṣa is known only in name. But his Raśārṇavasudhākara⁶⁵ also treats of drama towards its end. It seems that no important treatise on drama was written after all these works.

⁵⁵ Śāradātanaya's debt to N.S. has been pointed out by the editor of his work, see Introduction of BhP. pp. 61-67. ⁵⁶ See above note 1. ⁵⁷ See above notes 33-37.

⁵⁸ See above notes 31-32. ⁵⁹ See above note 41.

⁶⁰ BhP. pp. 175, 179, 95, 150, 327, 32, 160, 194, 313, 12, 152, 194, 213, 216, 242, 245, 251. ⁶¹ Skt. Poetics, Vol. I, pp. 233 ff.

⁶² See SD. 281, 306, 321, 503, 517, 537.

⁶³ See SD. Viśvanātha wrongly ascribed to Dhanika what belongs to DR. (III. 32-33). This misled some scholars to believe that Dhanika and Dhanarajaya were not different persons. ⁶⁴ See Skt. Poetics, Vol. I, pp. 242 ff.

⁶⁵ Ed. Trivandrum Oriental Series, 1916.

VI. The Nāṭyaśāstra : The Text and its Commentators

1. Its Author

The Nāṭyaśāstra is commonly attributed to Bharata Muni.¹ But Bharata cannot be taken as its author, for in the Nāṭyaśāstra itself his mythical character is very obvious, and the majority of the Purāṇas are silent about the so-called author of the Nāṭyaśāstra², and there is not a single legend about him in any of the extant Purāṇas or the Rāmāyaṇa and the Mahābhārata. The word *Bharata* which originally meant 'an actor' seems to have given rise to an eponymous author of the *Bharataśāstra* or the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (the manual of actors).

2. Its Two Recensions

Whoever might be the author of the Nāṭyaśāstra it is certain that the work itself possesses undoubted signs of great antiquity, and one of these is that its text is available in two distinct recensions. In having two partly divergent recensions the Nāṭyaśāstra can well be compared with works like the Nirukta, the Bṛhaddevatā and the Śakuntalā. The editors of these works have differently settled the claims of their shorter and longer recensions. At first sight the tendency would be to accept the shorter recension, as representing the original better, because elaboration would seem in most cases to come later. But opinion is divided in this matter: Pischel regarded the longer recension as being nearer the original³, Macdonell has also given his verdict in favour of the longer recension⁴ but he has not ventured to reject the shorter recension entirely as being late, and Lakshman Sarup has definitely suggested that the shorter recension is the earlier one.⁵ All these go to show that the problem of the relation between two recensions of any ancient work is not so simple as to be solved off-hand. So in this case also we should not settle the issue with the idea that the longer recension owes its bulk to interpolations.

The text-history of the Nāṭyaśāstra shows that already in the tenth century the work was available in two recensions. Dhanañjaya the author of the Daśarūpa quotes from the shorter recension while Bhoja, who closely follows him, quoted from the longer one.⁶ Abhinava in his commentary of the Nāṭyaśāstra, however, used the shorter recension as the basis of his work.⁷ It is likely that the long time which passed since then has witnessed at least minor changes, intentional as well as unintentional, in the

¹ See IHQ. Vol. VI. 1930. pp. 72 ff, Annals of BORI, Vol. XV, 1934, p. 90 fn.

² See NS.I, 2-5 note 2.

³ Kalidasa's Śakuntalā, HOS. p. XI.

⁴ The Bṛhaddevatā, HOS. Vol. I. p. XVIII-XIX.

⁵ Introduction to the Nighantū and Nirukta, p. 39.

⁶ Preface to Baroda ed. of NS. Vol. I. p. 8.

⁷ See above, note 6.

text of both the recensions. Hence the problem becomes still more difficult. But a careful examination of the rival recensions may give us some clue to their relative authenticity. Ramakrishna Kavi who has examined no less than forty Mss of the text, is of opinion that the longer recension (which he calls B.) seems to be ancient, although it contains some interpolation (pointed at by him) going back to a time prior to Abhinava.⁸ Mr. Kavi, however, does not try to explain the origin of the shorter recension which he calls A. This view regarding the relative authenticity of the longer recension seems to possess justification. Reasons supporting it are to be found in the tests differentiating the two recensions, which are as follows :

(i) Chapters XIV and XV of the shorter recension dealing with prosody introduce the later terminology of Piṅgala (ra, ja, sa, na, and bha gaṇas etc.) while the longer recension uses terms like *laghu* and *guru* in defining the scheme of metres.

(ii) The shorter recension in its chapter XV gives definitions of metres in Upajāti. while the corresponding chapter (XVI) of the longer recension gives them in Anuṣṭup metre and in a different order. Considering the fact that the bulk of the Nāṭyaśāstra is written in this (Anuṣṭup) metre the longer recension in this case seems to run closer to the original work.⁹

Though Ramakrishna Kavi, has overlooked it, there is yet another point which may be said to differentiate the two recensions. The chapter dealing with the Nāṭyagūṇas and Alampkāras have nearly forty ślokas differently worded in the two recensions. These ślokas in the longer recension (ch. XVII) are written in the usual simple language of the Nāṭyaśāstra while (ch. XVI) in the shorter recension (the ślokas) betray a later polish. The opening stanzas of the chapter (XVI) in the shorter recension are in Upajāti metre while in the longer recension (ch. XVII) they are in the śloka metre. This points to the earlier origin of the latter for the bulk of the Nāṭyaśāstra as has been pointed out before is composed in the same metre. Now the shorter recension which appears to be of later origin, does not seem to be totally devoid of worth. It appears that this has in certain cases preserved what once existed but are now missing in the longer recension. The cases in which the shorter recension gives in a different language the corresponding passages of the longer recension may be explained by assuming that the passages in question were probably written from memory of the original in the prototype of the recension.

3. Unity of the Nāṭyaśāstra

Some scholars have entertained a doubt the unity and authorship of the Nāṭyaśāstra. They think that there are indications that "it (the

⁸ See above note 6.

⁹ See above note 6.

Nāṭyaśāstra) has been subjected to considerable rehandling in later times before it assumed the present shape....."

The alleged indications may be summed up as follows :

(i) The colophon at the end of the KM. text of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*.
 (ii) The mention of Kohala as the future writer on certain topics in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (XXXVI. 63). (iii) Bhavabhūti's reference to Bharata Muni, the so-called author of the *Śāstra*, as the *Tauryatrika-sūtrakūra*.
 (iv) The mention of the *sūtra*, the *bhāṣya* and the *kārikā* as its constituent parts in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* itself along with the existence of prose passages in it. As for the first alleged indication Dr. S. K. De has tried to connect the colophon of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (*samāptaś cāyam Nandī-Bharata-saṃgīta-pustakam*) with the chapter on music only.¹⁰ He opines that the *Nandī-Bharata* of the colophon indicates that the chapters on music (XXVIII-XXXIII) are Bharata's original teaching on the subject as modified by the doctrine of Nandī. If we could accept the view it would have been easy to believe in the composite authorship of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. But this does not seem to be possible for the following considerations :

(a) The colophon in question stands at the end of two Mss. copied from the same original and are missing in all the rest of the available Mss.

(b) The word *saṃgīta* occurring rarely in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* includes according to Śārngadeva (c. 1300 A.C.) *gīta* (song), *vādya* (instrumental music) and *nṛtya* or *nṛtta* (dance). Hence the colophon may be taken in relation to the entire text and not with the chapters on music alone.

(c) Nandī as a writer or authority on *saṃgīta* alone has not been mentioned anywhere else.

As for the prediction that Kohala will treat certain topics not discussed in the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, it may be said that there is nothing in it to show that Kohala is later than the author of this treatise. He was in all likelihood a predecessor or a contemporary of his.

The most important of all the alleged indications of the plural authorship of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* is the third one. The idea that the work was originally written in prose and was subsequently turned into verse, arose probably from a misunderstanding of the word *sūtra*. In spite of its traditional definition as *alpākṣaram asandigdham sūtravad viśvatomukham* etc. there is nothing in it to show that the *sūtra* must always be in prose. Indeed the *Nāṭyadarpaṇa-sūtra* is entirely in verse, and the *Saddharma-puṇḍarika-sūtra* of the Mahāyāna Buddhists is partly in verse and partly in prose. In the *Maṅgalācaraṇa* śloka of his commentary Abhinava too mentions the extant *Nāṭyaśāstra* as the *Bharatasūtra*. Thus on taking the *sūtra* in its oldest sense, the theory of the supposed original prose version of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* falls to the ground. The existence of the prose passages in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* does not in the least help this theory, and

¹⁰ Skt. Poetics, Vol. I. p. 24. Ed. GO 3. Baroda, 1929.

it may be explained on the assumption that the author found it more convenient to write certain things in prose. All this will remove the difficulty in understanding the words of Bhavabhūti who mentioned Bharata as the *sūtrakāra*.

4. Its Scope and Importance

It has already been shown what a great variety of topics the Nāṭyaśāstra discusses in connection with its principal theme, the dramatic art. In sharp contrast with almost all the later writers on the subject its author treats of dramaturgy as well as histrionics. In justification of this two-fold aspect of this work Abhinava says that 'it is for the guidance of the producers as well as playwrights'¹². As the drama in any form is primarily and essentially a spectacle, laws of its production should be considered indispensable for the playwrights. It is a wellknown fact that many good literary dramas often get rejected by the theatrical directors because of their construction being found unsuitable for successful and profitable representation in the stage. The author of the Nāṭyaśāstra was evidently conscious about this vital connection between the literary and technical aspects of a drama, and treated of both very elaborately. It is a very unique text dealing with every possible aspect of the dramatic theory and practice. It is no wonder therefore that the Nāṭyaśāstra was often quoted or referred to in later treatises on gestures, poetics, music, prosody and even on grammar, besides being often laid under contribution by commentators of different Sanskrit and Prakrit plays. And all the later writers on dramaturgy too depended greatly if not exclusively on this work, and most of them expressly mentioned their debt to the Muni Bharata, the supposed author of the Nāṭyaśāstra.

5. Its Style and Method of Treatment

In style the Nāṭyaśāstra differs very largely from all the later writers on drama who professed adherence to it and formulated their rules in a concise manner. Those latter are sometimes so very brief, that without the help of a commentator they are not easily intelligible. Though some passages remain obscure without a commentary or similar help yet the major portion of the Nāṭyaśāstra is written in a simple language in the śloka and the Āryā metres. Though composed mainly in verse, a very small number of its passages are in prose. As the work is in the form of dialogue between Bharata, its mythical author, and some ancient sages, it has some similarity with the Purāṇas. One of the charges brought against the Nāṭyaśāstra is that it is very diffuse. This is true. On a careful examination of his method of treatment it will be found that the author of the Nāṭyaśāstra, like the famous Pāṇini, treated of the subject analytically. He has taken

¹² Ag. I p. 7.

¹³ Haas, p. XXVIII.

up individual topics and considered them in every possible detail and has found it necessary to repeat things for the completion of the matter in hand. This has given it diffuseness. But the adoption of this method was unavoidable in a technical work which aimed at completeness. This however may be said to have rendered it difficult to some extent. The difficulty with which we moderns are confronted in studying this ancient work, is however primarily due to its discussing an art which has practically gone out of vogue for quite a long time. That the text was transmitted through a defective Ms. tradition is no less responsible for occasional difficulties it presents.

6. The Early Commentators

According to Śāringadeva (SR. I. 1. 9) the commentators who set themselves to the task of explaining or elucidating the Nāṭyaśāstra are Lollaṭa, Udbhaṭa, Śaṅkuka, Abhinavagupta and Kirtidhara. Abhinava in his commentary refers in addition to Bhaṭṭa Yantra and Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka who may be taken as commentators of the Nāṭyaśāstra, and quotes from of one Bhāṣya and one Vārtika. The Vārtika however seems to be an independent treatise on drama though the Bhāṣya an old commentary. But in the absence of suitable data our knowledge about the date of these commentators and the nature as well as the value of their work, is very inadequate. We are however discussing below whatever meagre informations may be gathered about them.

(a) *Ācārya Kirtidhara* and *Bhāṣyakāra Nānyadeva*. Abhinava has referred to Kirtidhara only once.¹⁴ But from the special respect shown him by the commentator who calls him ācārya, it appears that Kirtidhara was a very early commentator of the Nāṭyaśāstra, and as such he was possibly anterior to Bhaṭṭa Udbhaṭa and hence may be placed in the 6th or the 7th century.¹⁵ And Nānyadeva¹⁶ quoted by Abhinava as the author of the Bharata-Bhāṣya seems to be another early commentator of our text.

(b) *Bhaṭṭa Udbhaṭa*. Bhaṭṭa Udbhaṭa's¹⁷ opinion has been thrice quoted by Abhinava. As his views were controverted by Bhaṭṭa Lollaṭa who flourished in the 8th century it is possible that Udbhaṭa was a person of the early 8th or the late 7th century.¹⁸ Though it has been doubted¹⁹ whether Udbhaṭa was really a commentator of the Nāṭyaśāstra, from the reference to his work by Abhinava we may be fairly certain in this matter.

¹⁴ Ag. I. p. 208. Cf. Skt. Poetics, Vol. I. p. 29. ¹⁵ Cf. Skt. Poetics, I. p. 39.

¹⁶ He should be distinguished from his namesake who was a king of Mithila in the 12th century (see JASB for 1915, pp. 407 ff.)

¹⁷ Ag. II, pp. 70, 441, 451, De's. Ms. pp. 392.

¹⁸ See Skt. Poetics, I. pp. 75ff.

¹⁹ Skt. Poetic, I. pp. 37 ff.

(c) *Bhaṭṭa Lollaṭa*. Bhaṭṭa Lollaṭa has been referred to as many as eleven times.²⁰ From these he appears to be a commentator of the Nāṭyaśāstra. As the *rasa* theory of Śaṅkuka was known to have been levelled against Lollaṭa's view on the same, this latter writer flourished possibly in the middle of the 8th century.²¹

(d) *Śrī Śaṅkuka*. Abhinava referred to Śrī-Śaṅkuka or Śaṅkuka as many as fifteen times.²² About his time we seem to have some definite information. For he is probably identical with the author of the poem Bhuvanābhyaṇdaya written during the Kashmirian king Ajitāpīḍa whose date is about 813 or 816 A. C.²³

(e) *Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka*. Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka has been referred to as many as six times by Abhinava.²⁴ Besides explaining and elucidating the Nāṭyaśāstra, at least in part, he wrote on the Dhvani theory an independent work named the Hṛdayadārpaṇa. He has been placed between the end of the 9th and the beginning of the 10th century.²⁵

(f) *Bhaṭṭa Yantra*. From the single reference to him in Abhinava's commentary it appears that Bhaṭṭa Yantra²⁶ was a commentator of the Nāṭyaśāstra. About him nothing more can be said except that he preceded the celebrated commentator.

7. Bhatta Abhinavagupta

Among the commentators of the Nāṭyaśāstra, Abhinavagupta or Abhinava is the most wellknown. But his fame rests also on his commentary on the Dhvanyāloka as well as numerous learned treatises on the Kashmir Śaivism. From the concluding portion of some of his books we learn a few facts of his family history, and on the strength of these he has been placed between the end of the 10th and the beginning of the 11th century.²⁷ From the Abhinavabhārati we learn that his another name was Nṛsiṃhagupta.²⁸

Although like any other work of this class it professes to explain the text, Abhinava's commentary is not always an adequate help for understanding the several difficult passages of the Nāṭyaśāstra. This drawback might be due to its defective text tradition, but a careful study of it will convince any one that all its weak points cannot be explained away on this assumption alone. There are instances of Abhinava's not being sure about the explanation offered, for example, the word *kutapa* is once explained as

²⁰ Ag. I. pp. 208, 266, 279, 296; II. pp. 134, 196, 415, 423, 436, 452. De's Ms. p. 386.

²¹ Skt. Poetics, Vol. I. pp. 38-39.

²² Ag. I. pp. 74, 217, 274, 285, 293, 298, 318; II. pp. 411; 436. De's. Ms. pp. 403, 413, 437, 441, 448, 469.

²³ See Skt. Poetics, I pp. 38-39.

²⁴ Ag. I. pp. 4, 26, 278, II. p. 298, De's MS pp. 500, 508.

²⁵ Skt Poetics, I. pp. 39ff. ²⁶ Ag. I. p. 208.

²⁷ Skt. Poetics, I. pp. 117ff.

²⁸ See Ag. De's. Ms. pp. 428, 511.

'four kinds of musical instruments'²⁹ and next as 'a group of singers and players of musical instruments'³⁰ and then again as 'four of musical instruments',³¹ while explaining the *mattavāraṇi* he gives four different views³² and does not give special support to his own preference. Besides this, his explanation in some cases seem to be fanciful. For example, he explains *khaṇḍana* as (meaning) 'also fanning by means of a fan made of palmleaf'.³³ This evidently is wrong, for in the same context *vyañjanakam* 'fanning' has been mentioned, and *khaṇḍana* may better be interpreted as 'drawing patterns or designs'.³⁴ But such instances are not many. That Abhinava had as the basis of his commentary a defective text of the Nāṭyaśāstra, is apparent from its published portion, and his text was in places to some extent different from any of the versions that have reached us. It is due to this latter fact that sometimes particular passages of the commentary cannot be connected with any portion of the text (given above the commentary) in the Baroda edition. For example, once Abhinava writes "here are four *ca-kāras*",³⁵ but in the text indicated by the *pratīka* two *cū-kūras* only are available. And curiously enough a part of this text quoted elsewhere³⁶ in the commentary corroborates the available reading of the text. In another place of Abhinava's commentary we have the word *ālambhana* explained, but we look in vain for it in the text.³⁷ The same is the case with *avyatireka* and *āgama* occurring in the commentary later on.³⁸ And some responsibility for its reduced usefulness must be ascribed to the fact that Abhinava had his commentary based on an imperfect text of the Nāṭyaśāstra.

There is still another reason due to which Abhinava's work does not prove to be quite adequate for our need. It is probably because he wrote the commentary with a view to help scholars of his time, whose knowledge on many things relating to the Indian drama, theatre and general literature he could easily assume, his commentary sometimes falls short of our needs.

But in spite of these limitations Abhinava's work has its value. Whenever he has to explain any theory or problem concerning the dramatic art or general aesthetics, he does it very exhaustively by quoting all possible views on the same and often cites examples from a vast number of dramatic and other works some of which have perished. Often he sums up the discussion in a masterly fashion. That he was a voluminous writer on the abstruse philosophical topics gave him some facility in handling such matters. But, for the purpose of reconstructing the theory and practice of the ancient Indian drama, such scholastic discussions are often not of much value, though students of Indian poetics and aesthetics will surely

²⁹ Ag. I. p. 73.

³⁰ Ag. I. p. 65.

³¹ Ag. I. p. 186.

³² Ag. I. pp. 64-65.

³³ Ag. I. p. 41.

³⁴ See note 2 on IX 61-64.

³⁵ Ag. II. p. 34.

³⁶ Ag. I. p. 203.

³⁷ Ag. II. p. 34.

³⁸ Ag. II. pp. 97, 225.

be profited by their perusal. But it must be said of Abhinava's commentary that it gives considerable help in understanding some difficult passages of the very old obsolete text of the Nāṭyaśāstra, and for this we should be genuinely grateful to him.

VII. Data of India's Cultural History in the Nāṭyaśāstra

Besides giving all sorts of information relating to the dramaturgy and histrionics as well as the allied arts of dance and music, the Nāṭyaśāstra includes considerable other materials for the cultural history of India. The most important among these will be discussed below under their several heads.

1. Language

The Nāṭyaśāstra gives some description of Pkt. (XVIII. 1-25) and examples of Dhruvā songs in Pkt. (XXXII). From these materials it seems that the Pkt. of the Nāṭyaśāstra lie mid-way between the Pkt. of the classical dramas and that of Aśvaghoṣa's plays. Besides this there occur in this work (XVIII. 44, 48) some references about the nature of languages used by the ancient tribes like the Barbaras, Kirātas, Andhras, Dramiḍas, Śābaras and Caṇḍālas. There are besides other interesting matters relating to the language used by men of different professions and status in life.

2. Literature

In addition to Prakrit verses given as examples of Dhruvās, the Nāṭyaśāstra cites numerous poetical stanzas in Skt. as examples of the Benediction and of the different metres (V. 108-112, 130-131: XVI). These are very early specimens of the ancient Indian literature. It is on the testimony of these which are free from the artificiality of the later classical poetry, that P. Regnaud placed the Nāṭyaśāstra about the beginning of the Christian era (Introduction to Grosset's ed. of the NŚ. p. VII-VIII). The Nāṭyaśāstra contains also the earliest available discussion on figures of speech (*alaṃkāra*), and the method of criticism based on the theory of Sentiments (*rasa*) which became very popular amongst Indian scholars during the medieval times.

3. Art

In the Viṣṇudharmottara (II. 2. 4) it has been said that the canons of painting are difficult to understand without an acquaintance with the canons of dancing. Now the Hindu drama as we have seen before depends a great deal on dance which is in fact its mainstay. The same work similarly connects the canons of painting with the canons of image-making. Thus the three arts being connected with one another, the Nāṭyaśāstra receives an additional importance. This view is justified by the fact that the Nāṭyaśāstra describes various male postures (*sthāna*) such as Vaiṣṇava,

Samapāda, Vaiśākha, Maṇḍala, Ālīḍha and Pratyālīḍha (XI. 50-71), and female postures (*sthāna*) (XIII. 159-169) such as Āyata, Avahittha and Aśvakrānta. These and the various gestures described in the Nāṭyaśāstra may also be helpful in studying specimens of the ancient sculpture and painting. It should be noted in this connection that the Samarāṅgaṇa-sūtradhāra a medieval encyclopaedic work while describing the rules of making images describes (ed. GOS. Vol. II, p. 301ff) the hand gestures etc. almost in the language of the Nāṭyaśāstra.

4. Metrics

Fiftyeight varieties of metre of *sama*, *ardhasama* and *viśama* types have been described in the Nāṭyaśāstra (XVI). All these are perhaps anterior in time to the Chandah-sūtras of Piṅgala. One important aspect of this description is that the name of the following metres are different in the NŚ. e.g. Drutavilambita=Harinapluta (NŚ), Bhujaṅgaprayāta=Aprameyā (NŚ), Srāgviṇī=Padmini (NŚ), Mālinī=Nāndimukhī (NŚ), Hariṇī=Viśabha-ceṣṭita (NŚ), Mandākṛāntā=Śrīdharā (NŚ), Prithvī= Vilambita-gati (NŚ), Kusumita-latā-vellitā=Citrakāhā (NŚ).

5. Poetics

The Nāṭyaśāstra enumerates (XVII. 43-106) four poetic figures (*alamkāra*), ten Guṇas and ten faults (*doṣa*) of a composition. In brief these may be called the earliest writings on poetics. To the theory of Sentiment (*rasa*) and the States (*bhāva*) (VI-VII) also the same remark applies.

6. Costumes and Ornaments

Detailed descriptions of ornaments, and directions about costumes to be used by characters in a play according to their social status, profession, religious faith, and tribal origin etc. are given in the Nāṭyaśāstra (XXIII. 1-67, 110-127). These may throw interesting light on the social life of the Indian people in the remote past.

7. Mythology

The Nāṭyaśāstra mentions (I-V, XXXIII-XXXIV, XXXVI numerous gods, goddesses, demigods etc. Classified according to the system adopted by Hopkin in his 'Epic Mythology' they are as follows :

(a) *Lower Mythology* : Serpent, Birds, Waters. (b) *Spirits* : Piṭṛs, Bhūtas, Rākṣasas, Asuras, Daityas, Dānavas, Yakṣas, Guhyakas. (c) *The eight great gods* : The Sun-God, the Moon-God, the Wind-God, the Fire-God, the God of death, Varuṇa and Ocean, Indra, the Dikpālas (World-protector). (d) *The Host of Spirits* : Gandharvas, Apsarasas, Kāma, Aśvins, Maruṭs, Rudras, Viśvedevas, Ādityas, (e) *Divine Seers* : Bṛhaspati, Nārada, Tumburu. (f) *Earthly Rsis and Personages* :

Bala (deva), Nahuṣa, Saṇatkumāra. (g) *The Three Supreme Deities* : Brāhman, Viṣṇu, Śiva. (h) *Lesser God* : Kṛtikeya. (i) *Goddesses* : Sarasvatī, Lakṣmī, Umā, Pārvatī, Caṇḍikā, Siddhi, Medhā, Smṛti, Matī, Niyatī, Nipṛti. It is probably significant that Gaṇeśa and the Avatāras of Viṣṇu are absent from this list.

8. Geography. -

In its chapters XIV, XVIII and XXIII the Nāṭyaśāstra mentions some geographical names such as Aṅga, Anta (Anti) rgiri, Andhra, Avantī, Arvuda, Āvarta, Ānarta, Uśinara. Oḍra, Kalinga, Kāśmīra, Kośala, Kḥasa, Tāmralipta, Tosala, Tripura, Dākṣiṇātya, Dramiḍa, Nepāla, Pañcāla, Pulinda (bhūmi), Pauṇḍra, Prāgiyotiṣa. Prāṇsu-pravṛtti, Pavaṅga, Bahir-giri, Brahmottara (Suhmottara), Bhārgava, Magadha, Madraka, Malav-artaka, Mahārāṣṭra, Mārgava, Mālava, Mahendra, Mosala, Vaṅga. Yatsa, Vanavāsa, Vārtika (Mārtika), Vāhlika, Vidiśa, Vīdeha, Śīrasena, Śālaka, Sindhu, Surāṣṭra, Sauvīra, Gaṅgā, Carmaṇvatī, Vetravatī, Mahendra, Malaya, Sahya, Mekala, Kālapañjara, Himālaya, Vindhya, Bhārata.

9. Ethnological Data.

The names of the following tribes occur in the Nāṭyaśāstra. Kāśi, Kosala, Barbara, Andhra, Dramiḍa, Abhira, Śabara, Caṇḍāla, Śaka, Pallava (Pahlava) and Yavana. From the costumes and colours to be assigned to their body it may be possible to trace them historically.

10. Ars Amatoria.

The Nāṭyaśāstra mentions Kāmitantra or Kūmatantra (XXV. 38, 53-567) and Kāmasāstra (XXXV. 46). But as it divides women into twenty-four classes, and Vāṭayāna's Kāmasūtra into four classes these names do not seem to relate to the Kāmasūtra which probably comes later.

11. Arthasastra.

The Nāṭyaśāstra is of opinion that "The members of the court (*sabhāstāra*) should be appointed after consulting the views of Bṛhaspati who thinks that the following are the qualities required for this office. "They should be always ready for work, alert, free from indolence, undaunted by hard work, affectionate, forbearing, modest, impartial, skillful, trained in polity and good manners, deeply conversant with the art of argumentation and all other branches of knowledge, and not affected by sexual passion and the like" (XXXIV-87-90). The word *sabhāstāra* which has been translated here as a member of the court, occurs in the Smṛti of Vyāsa who holds that this officer should hold discussion about morals (*dharmaśāstra*) for the edification of those who are present (in court). In Mbh 4.1.24, however *sabhāstāra* appears only as a courtier (*sabhya*, Nilakaṇṭha) who is particularly interested in gambling (Jolly, Hindu law and Custom, pp. 287-288).

The description of the king, the *senāpati*, the *amātya* and the *prāṣṭivāka* as given in the Nāṭyaśāstra (XXXIV. 78-87) might well have been taken from the now lost work of Bṛhaspati recognised by Kauṭilya as one of his sources. The Nāṭyaśāstra gives besides one interesting information that the inmates of a royal palace included a *snātaka* (XXXIV. 64-69) and that there was besides a functionary named *kumārādhipati* (XXXIV. 76-77). As the definition has been lost, it is not possible to know what his duty was. Can he be identified with the *kumārāmātya* mentioned in Samudragupta's inscription ?

12. Psychology.

The Nāṭyaśāstra seems to be the first in recognizing the twofold importance of psychology in connexion with the production of a play. Its classification of Heroes and Heroines according to their typical mental and emotional states (XXIV. 210ff., XXXIV. 15ff.) proves its admission of the importance of psychology on the creative side of the dramatic art ; for with the complete knowledge of all possible reactions of different objects and incidents upon such Heroes and Heroines, the playwright as well as actors and actresses could attain the greatest possible success in characterisation. On the critical side also the importance of psychology was discovered by the Hindu theorists almost simultaneously. It was realised early that no strictly objective standard of beauty ever existed, and the enjoyment of a theatrical production consisted of peculiar reactions which the art of the playwright as well as that of the actors could successfully evoke in spectators of different types. It is on this assumption that the theory of Sentiments and States (VI-VII) important alike for the criticism of the theatre and the *belles lettres* has been elaborated by the author of the Nāṭyaśāstra. Such a view does not allow any kind of dogmatism in the criticism of art and literature, and will make due allowance for the views of people who may widely differ in their tastes because of their varying cultural equipment.

VIII. The Date of the Nāṭyaśāstra

More than sixteen years ago, a careful investigation of the linguistic, metrical, geographical and ethnographic data, of the evidence to be drawn from the history of poetics and music, of the Kāmasāstra and the Arthaśāstra, and from inscriptions the present writer came to the conclusion that the available text of the Nāṭyaśāstra existed in the second century after Christ, while the tradition which it recorded may go back to a period as early as 100 B.C. (The Date of Bharata-Nāṭyaśāstra", in the JDL. Vol. XXV. 1934).¹ Since this conclusion was made, a more intensive

¹ For a bibliography on the Date of the NS. see this paper p. 1.

study of the text as well as accession of fresh data has confirmed the writer's belief in its soundness. These additional materials are being discussed below.

1. The Geographical Data

Geographical names occur in the Nāṭyaśāstra (XIV. 36ff.) mostly in connexion with *pravṛttis* or Local Usages which seem to be a later conception and not at all indispensable for understanding the theatrical art as explained in the Nāṭyaśāstra. In fact the authors of the Daśarūpa and the Nāṭakalakṣaṇa, who speak of the *vṛttis* are absolutely silent on *pravṛttis* which are connected with them. Considering the fact that these works depend a great deal on the Nāṭyaśāstra their omission of this item may be taken as very significant. Geographical names occurring in connexion with the *pravṛttis* are found in the Mbh. and some of the Purāṇas, some of these being almost in the same sequence (see D. C. Sircar, "Text of the Puranic Lists of Peoples" in IHQ. Vol. XXI., 1945, pp. 297-314). It seems that some interpolator put them into the text of the Nāṭyaśāstra, for associating it with all the different parts of India, though the original work was an exposition of the dramatic art as it was practised in the northern India especially in the midland only. Hence the geographical data should not be used in determining the date of our text.

2. The Nāṭyaśāstra earlier than Kālidāsa

The argument that a particular dramatist who disregards any rule laid down in the Nāṭyaśāstra, will be earlier than it in time, will reverse the accepted chronological relation between the Nāṭyaśāstra and Kālidāsa.

(a) Though the fact has been overlooked by earlier writers on the subject, Kālidāsa too violates the rules of the Nāṭyaśāstra on the following points :

(i) Though the prescribed rule (XIX. 33) is that the king's wives should be given names connected with the idea of victory, some of Kālidāsa's royal Heroines have been named as follows : Dhārīṇī, Irāvati (Mālavī.) Harṣapadikā, Vasumatī (Śak.).

(ii) It is also in disregard of the rule (XIX. 34) prescribing for the handmaids (*preṣyā*) the names of various flowers, that Kālidāsa has Nāgarikā, Madhukarikā, Samābhṛtikā, Nipunikā, Candrikā, Kaumudikā (Mālavī.), Parabhṛtikā, Caturikā (Śak.) as the names of handmaids in his play. Vakulāvalikā (Mālavī.) is possibly an exception.

(iii) Though the prescribed rule (XIX. 34) is that the names having an idea of auspiciousness, should be given to the menials, Kālidāsa has Raivataka and Sārasaka (Mālavī.) as the names of servants.

(iv) The term *svāmin* has been used by an army-chief (*senāpati*) in addressing the king (Śak. II) in violation of the prescribed rule that it should be used for the crown-prince (XIX. 12).

(v) Besides these, Kālidāsa has written elaborate Prologues to his plays, though the Nāṭyaśāstra does not recognize anything of this kind as a part of the play proper. These as well as the departures from the rules in Bhāsa's play, may be taken as great dramatists' innovations which as creative geniuses they were fully entitled to.

(b) Besides these there seems to be other facts which probably go to show that Kālidāsa knew the present Nāṭyaśāstra. They are as follows :

(i) Kālidāsa uses the following technical terms of the Nāṭyaśāstra : *aṅgahāra, vṛtti, sandhi, prayoga*, (Kumāra, VII. 91), *aṅga-sattva-vacanāśrayaṇi nṛitam* (Raghu, XIX. 36), *pūtra, prūṣṇika, saṁsthava, apadeśa, upavahana, śūkhā, vastu, māyurī mārjanā* (Mālavī.)

(ii) Kālidāsa mentions the mythical Bharata as the director of the celestical theatre (Vikram, III).

(iii) According to Kāṭyavāyana, Kālidāsa in his Mālavī. (I. 4.0 ; 21.0) refers to particular passages in the Nāṭyaśāstra (I. 16-19 ; NŚ (C.) XXX, 92ff.)

3. The Mythological Data

In the paper mentioned in the beginning of this chapter the present writer was mistaken in his interpretation of the word *mahāgrāmaṇi* which does not mean Gaṇapati as Abhinava the reputed commentator of the Nāṭyaśāstrā opines (see notes on III.1-8.). The absence from the Nāṭyaśāstra of this deity who does not appear in literature before the fourth century speaks indeed for the great antiquity of this work.

4. The Ethnological Data

The Nāṭyaśāstra in one passage (XXIII. 99) names Kirātās, Barbaras and Pulindas together with Andhras, Dramilas, Kāsīs and Kosalas who were brown (*asita*, lit. not white), and in another passage (XVIII. 44) names Andhras and Dramilas together with Barbaras and Kirātās. Āpastamba the author of the Dharmaśāstra who lived at the latest in the 300 B.C. belonged to the Andhra land (Jolly, Hindu Law and Custom, p. 6 and also P.V. Kane, Hist. of the Dharmaśāstra. Vol. I. p. 45). Hence it may be assumed on the basis of these names that the Nāṭyaśāstra was in all likelihood composed at a time when a section at least of the Andhras and the Dramilas (forefathers of the modern Tamils) were still not looked upon as thoroughly civilized. Such a time may not have been much after the beginning of the Christian era.

5. The Epigraphical Data

Sylvain Lévi has discovered parallelism between the Nāṭyaśāstra and the inscriptions of the Indo-Scythian Ksatrapas like Chastana who are referred to therein as *szāmi* a term applicable, according to the Śāstra to

the *yuvārāja* or crown-prince (I. Ant. Vol. XXXIII. pp. 163f). Though MM.P.V. Kane (Introduction to the SD. p. viii) has differed from him, Lévi's argument does not seem to be without its force. It may not be considered unusual for common persons who are intimate with him to show the future king an exaggerated honour by calling him *svāmin* a term to be formally applied to the reigning monarch only. Besides the argument put forward by Lévi, there may be collected from the inscriptions other facts too which may incline us to take 200-300 A.C. as the time of the compilation of the Nāṭyaśāstra. These are as follows :

(a) The word *gāndharva* probably in the sense in which the Nāṭyaśāstra uses it (XXXVI. 76) occurs in the Junagarh Rock inscription of Rudradaman, I (150 A.C.). This also mentions terms, like *saushava* and *niyuddha* which we meet in the Nāṭyaśāstra probably in the same sense (Junagarh Inscription of Rudradaman I. See Select Inscriptions, pp. 172-173).

(b) The respect for 'Cows and Brahmins' (*go-brāhmaṇa*) which the author of the Nāṭyaśāstra shows at the end of his work (XXXVI. 77) has its parallel in the inscription referred to above. And respect for Brahmins also finds expression in more than one inscription belonging to the 3rd century A.C. (*op. cit.* pp. 159, 161, 165)

(c) The three tribal names Śāka, Yavana, and Pahlava appearing in the inscription of Vasistiputra Pulomayi (149 A.C.) occur in the same order in the Nāṭyaśāstra (*op. cit.*, p. 197,) and NŚ.

The cumulative effect of all these data seems to be that they may enable us to place the Nāṭyaśāstra about 200 A.C., the time of these inscriptions.

6. The Nāṭyaśāstra earlier than Bhaṣa

Lack of conformity to the dramaturgic rules of the Nāṭyaśāstra has sometimes been cited as an evidence of the antiquity of Bhaṣa, the argument being that as he wrote before the rules were formulated, he could not observe them. This view however, seems to be mistaken. For the rules occurring in the Nāṭyaśāstra cannot, for obvious reasons, be the author's fabrication without relation to any pre-existent literature.¹ If the Nāṭyaśāstra was written after Bhaṣa's plays, its rules had every chance of having been a generalisation from them as well as from numerous other dramatic works existing at the time, while the contrary being the case (i.e. Bhaṣa being later than the Nāṭyaśāstra) some novelties are likely to be

¹ F. Hall in his Introduction (p. 12) to the *Daśarūpa* says: At all events, he (Bharata) would hardly have elaborated them (the rules) except as inductions, from actual compositions.

introduced by the dramatist in disregard of the existing rules. It is on this line of argument that the chronological relation between Bhāsa and the Nāṭyaśāstra, will be judged below.

(a) On no less than three points, Bhāsa seems to have disregarded the rules of the Nāṭyaśāstra. These are as follows :

(i) The *sūtradhāra* (Director) begins the plays, though according to the Nāṭyaśāstra the *sthāpaka* (Introducer) should perform this function (V. 167).

(ii) In contravention of the rule of the Nāṭyaśāstra (XX. 20) Bhāsa allows death in Act I of *Abhiṣeka*.

(iii) In the *Madhyama-vyāyoga* and the *Dūtaghṛtaka*, Bhāsa does not give the usual *bharatavākya* (final benediction) and what he gives in its stead, may be an innovation.

Hence it may be assumed that the Nāṭyaśāstra was completed before the advent of Bhāsa.

(b) Besides this, there seems to be some good evidence in his works to show that the dramatist was acquainted with this ancient work on drama. For example, he mentions in a humorous context the Jester confounding the Nāṭyaśāstra (Avi. II 0. 38-39) with the Rāmāyaṇa. Bhāsa's mention of some technical terms as well as the acquaintance which he shows with some special rules of the Nāṭyaśāstra may also be said to strengthen the above assumption.

(i) First, about the technical terms. They are : *saṁsthāva*, *prastāvanā*, *sūtradhāra*, *prekṣaka*, *cāri*, *gati*, *bhadrāmukha*, *hāva*, *bhāva*, *māriṣa*, *nūlakīyā*, the root *paṭha*, *raṅga*.

(ii) The hetaera in the *Cārudatta* (I. 26, 38.) says within herself, "I am unworthy of being allowed entrance into the harem" (*abhāṇi aham abhāntara-pavesassa*). This seems to refer to the NŚ. XX. 54. The expression, "by means of a Nāṭaka suiting the time" (*kālasamvādinā nūlaṇa*) in *Pratimā*. (I. 4. 7) probably points to NŚ. XXVII. 88ff.

(iii) The vocal skill of the hetaera referred to by the Śakāra (Parasite) in the *Cārudatta* may also be said to point to the elaborate rules regarding intonation (*kāku*) in the NŚ. XIX 37-8.

(iv) Besides these, expressions like "the two feet made facile in dance due to training" (*ṛttopadeśa-viśada-carāṇau*) and "she represents the words with all her limbs" (*abhinayati vacāṁsi sarvagatiraiḥ*) in the *Cārudatta* (I.9.0, 16.0) probably relate to the elaborate discussion on dance and the use of gestures in the Nāṭyaśāstra.

On the basis of all these it may be assumed that Bhāsa was acquainted with the contents of the present text of the Nāṭyaśāstra. Hence

it may be placed in the 2nd century A. C. i.e. one century before the time generally assigned to Bhāsa's works. (Jolly, Introduction to AŚ. p. 10, but according to Konow Bhāsa's date may be the 2nd century A. C. See ID. p. 51).

From the foregoing discussions it may be reasonable to assume the existence of the Nāṭyaśāstra in the 2nd century A.C., though it must not be supposed that the work remained uninterfered with by interpolators of later ages. Such an interpolation may exist more or less in all the ancient texts. For example, Aristotle's Poetics too, in its received text, has been suspected to have interpolated passages in it. There are indeed interpolated passages in the Nāṭyaśāstra and some of these have been pointed out² and a few more may by some chance be discovered afterwards. But this may not bring down the work as a whole to later times.

² See notes on XVIII. 6, 48; XX. 63. Besides these cases, the seventeen couplets after XV. 101 and the five couplets after XVI. 169 are spurious. For these do not give any important information regarding the art of the theatre or dramaturgy and may be merely scholastic additions. The passage on *pravṛttis* XIV. 34-55 may also be spurious.

